THE *NEW YORK TIMES* BESTSELLING AUTHOR

SALLY HEPWORTH

MAD Mabel

They called it murder.
She called it justice.



About *Mad Mabel*

From the *New York Times* bestselling author of *The Soulmate* and *Darling Girls* comes the story of Mad Mabel. They called it murder. She called it justice.

‘In 1959, at just fifteen years of age, Mabel Waller became the youngest Australian in history to be convicted of murder.’

In 2025, on a quiet Melbourne lane, an elderly man is found dead by his neighbour, 81-year-old Elsie Fitzpatrick. No one suspects any foul play.

Until they discover Elsie’s past.

In the 1950s, her name was not Elsie. It was Mabel.

‘She is known around the world as Mad Mabel. But is she mad? More importantly, is she guilty?’

When the police open a new investigation and the media descend upon her, the elderly Mabel decides it’s time to set the record straight.

‘In a world first, at the age of 81, Mabel Waller is speaking.’

New York Times bestselling author Sally Hepworth is at her finest in this twisty, compulsive thriller of friendship, family and murder. Or is it justice . . . ?

ALSO BY SALLY HEPWORTH

The Mother's Promise
The Secrets of Midwives
The Things We Keep
The Family Next Door
The Mother-in-Law
The Good Sister
The Younger Wife
The Soulmate
Darling Girls

SALLY HEPWORTH

MAD Mabel



CONTENTS

Cover
About *Mad Mabel*
Also by Sally Hepworth
Title page
Contents
Dedication
Prologue
1
2
3 Then
4
5
6 Now
7
8 Then
9
10
11 Now
12
13
14 Then
15
16 Now
17
18
19

Then

Now

Then

Now

Then

Now

Then

Now

Then

Now
Then

Now

Then

Now

53 Then
54
55 Now
56 Then
57
58
59
60 Now
61
62 Then
63 Now
64 Then
65
66
67 Now
68 Then
69
70 Now
71 Then
72 Now
73
74
75
76
77
78
79
80 Persephone

Acknowledgements
About Sally Hepworth
End Ads
Copyright page

Newsletter

For Sash

PROLOGUE

It's interesting to note that there are two groups of people who are rarely, if ever, suspected of murder. These groups are elderly women and little girls.

On the whole, when it comes to murder, the stats very much favour the men. The odd woman is thrown into the mix every now and again, but she's inevitably perimenopausal (and having been through the change myself, I certainly understand why). But an elderly woman or little girl committing murder? It's one in a million.

I've always liked to think I was special.

1

My name is Elsie Mabel Fitzpatrick and I am eighty-one years old. I want it on the record that I don't look eighty-one. Not because I'm particularly attractive or youthful-looking – on the contrary, I've seen hairless mole rats more attractive – but because if storybooks are anything to go by (and I, for one, believe they are), eighty-one-year-olds are frail, birdlike creatures with silver hair who call people 'dear' and go inside the bank to speak to an 'actual person' rather than use the much more convenient ATM. At six feet tall with broad shoulders and a sturdy backbone, no one would ever accuse me of being birdlike – unless the bird in question was an ostrich. My hair is reddish-grey, and I call people 'dipshit' with far more regularity than 'dear'. Most importantly, I adore the ATM. Who wouldn't? I'm eighty-one years old, and I don't want to spend the precious time I have left in a stuffy, air-conditioned room talking to a power-tripping branch manager called Barry through plexiglass.

I digress.

I've lived on Kenny Lane for close to sixty years. Kenny Lane is a peculiar little cobbled street on the periphery of central Melbourne, made up of the back doors of restaurants and half a dozen single-fronted terrace homes, each adorned with intricately tiled porches and wrought-iron fences in varying states of disrepair. The tiny front gardens tell diverse stories: mine meticulously tended with blooming roses, the rest ranging from untamed beauty to sparse weed patches. Parking is limited to a single row along one side, and any non-resident who dares to park their vehicle in these public spots is destined to suffer the wrath of Mrs Nguyen. (I've yet to see a person make this mistake twice.)

There's the usual assortment of neighbours: Peter Pantages (aka Pete the Greek) at number 1; Joan Waters (litigious, and a real piece of work) at

number 3; and Roxanne (sex-crazed single mother) and her evil seven-year-old spawn, Persephone, at number 5. On the other side there's me at number 2; Old Ishaan (my nemesis) and his deranged Chihuahua, Nugget, next door at number 4; and the Nguyens – very nice couple so long as you don't utilise the public parking on Kenny Lane – at number 6.

The houses are close enough together that I could throw a tennis ball back and forth with residents opposite me if I was so inclined, which, needless to say, I am not. In fact, beyond the necessary interactions of neighbours – accusations of stealing space in each other's rubbish bins, lobbing dog droppings over the fence when Nugget does her business in my front garden, and shared complaints about the dreadful postman Dwayne – we don't interact at all, which is exactly how I like it.

It's a funny little street, to be sure. But it's home to me. The only real home I've ever had. And while I consider myself flexible about a lot of things, I'm not flexible about Kenny Lane. In fact, I'll tell you something for nothing: the only way anyone is going to get me out of this street is in a mahogany box. An extra-long one.

I am dangling a Lady Grey tea bag in hot water when I see it. From the kitchen I have a direct eyeline down the long corridor to the front door, under which I see a protruding piece of paper.

'Well, well, looky here,' I say to Daphne, who sits patiently at my round table, waiting for her cuppa. 'Must be another letter from Joan.'

Joan at number 3 is sixty-odd, has a neat grey bob, polished black orthotic footwear and darting, suspicious eyes. Since the day she moved in, I've been receiving notes underneath my door: about my porch security light shining into her bedroom window, about the placement of my rubbish bins, about my roses creeping too far over the fence line into the laneway. If I wasn't so full of myself I might have feared she didn't like me. Joan's nephew, she is forever at pains to point out, is a partner in a law firm. She's managed to include this detail in every one of her letters.

Your nephew sounds marvellous, I replied to her last note. *But I'm assuming he's going to be a little young for me, and besides, I'm not looking to date at this time.*

Daphne snorted her tea when I read that out to her.

In the year she's lived on the street, I've never heard Joan speak. Not a word. Each time I shout, 'Good morning,' she scurries away like a rat in a sewer. I suppose Joan is more of a pen pal than a neighbour.

'I wonder what I've done this time?' I say.

'Perhaps she's discovered our cannabis racket?' Daphne muses. 'You don't think she knows a lawyer, do you?'

We chuckle wickedly.

I shuffle toward the door, thinking this will make for most enjoyable conversation while we have our afternoon cuppa. I might read out the letter using a voice akin to the Queen's to make Daphne laugh.

Daphne laughs easily, a grossly underrated quality. Also grossly underrated are the bizarre outfits she wears. Today it's a magenta T-shirt with a bedazzled Eiffel Tower on the front. The rims of her glasses are magenta, just like her shirt. Daphne has always been quirky but it feels more pronounced somehow now she is an old lady. The comfort she brings me, too, feels more pronounced. If my life is a jagged graph of highs and lows, she is the thick, solid line right down the middle. Not a black line either, nothing as dull as that. Daphne's line is magenta.

I bend to retrieve the note, supporting my temperamental lumbar spine. I'd planned to wait until I was sitting down to open it – it's folded in half – but as I straighten, it opens itself, having not been folded with enough passion along the line. *Arthritis playing up, is it, Joan?*

I lift my glasses from the chain around my neck and perch them on my nose. It's a photocopy of an old news article. A very old news article. It must have been copied many times because much of the font is blurred, impossible to read. I can make out the headline though, clear as day. The sight of it makes me feel lightheaded, like I might faint.

'What is it?' Daphne asks.

I turn the page around to face her. She reads the headline slowly, her mouth bending around each word silently as she squints at the page. Finally, her lips stop moving and her eyes find mine.

'Someone knows,' I say unnecessarily. 'Someone knows who I am.'

*

This is a love story, by the way. It may not seem like it, what with all the blood and guts and murder, but nevertheless, that's what it is. And there is no greater love story than that of platonic female love. The kind of love I have with Daphne.

We aren't lesbians, before you start. Frankly, I find it appalling that people would assume such a thing – not that I take issue with lesbians, each to their own, I say, but because people have so little regard for female friendship that they can't fathom a closeness such as we have without the romantic element. More fool them.

There will be those who disagree with me, of course. People who say romantic love trumps platonic female friendship. Or parental love. Or love of self. Those people are just giving away the fact that they've never experienced true platonic female friendship. The kind of friendship you'd do anything to preserve – fight, steal. Even kill.

Here's a little-spoken fact for you: friends are like oxygen. If you've been blessed enough to have always been surrounded by friends, you might think I'm overplaying this. I don't blame you. If you'd always been surrounded by air, you wouldn't think to credit it for your very existence either. But I've spent much of my life gasping for breath, so I promise you, it's true: friends are like oxygen. And the only reason I'm still alive is Daphne.

2

‘Elsa?’

When you are as ancient as I am, the days are predictable. Early each morning, for example, I know I’ll hear a few crazies singing as they make their way home from a night out at the bars. I know I’ll see Mrs Nguyen from two doors down scurry past my window on her way to the nail salon. I know I’ll hear Nugget, Ishaan’s godforsaken Chihuahua, yapping for her breakfast. And so on and so forth. A lot of people think old folk find comfort in such sameness, and perhaps some of them do. Not me. I like change. Usually. Then again, the arrival of the *enfant terrible* Persephone on the street is one change that has me yearning for days of yore.

‘ELSA!’

I should, I suppose, take my share of responsibility. After all, I leave myself open to this sort of harassment by choosing to spend time on my porch of a morning. Unfortunately, as quaint as my terrace home is, it is measly in natural light and a woman has to get her vitamin D from somewhere.

‘It’s Elsie,’ I tell the child. ‘Else to my friends, which you are not. Elsa to no one.’

Daphne and I are on the front porch, open novels in our laps, trying to find relief from Nugget’s vile yapping. Honest to God, it’s the kind of noise that could make a woman insane. *Yap. Yap. Yap*. Equally spaced. No pauses. Highly pitched, vulnerable and vicious all at once. The only consolation is that the noise helps distract me from the article.

‘Forget about it,’ Daphne keeps saying. ‘Put the silly article out of your mind.’

And I do, for short periods. But my mind keeps getting drawn back to it like a fly to manure. I'm aware that people know my story, of course – I am a footnote in practically every article written about childhood evils. The difference is that while I am free to engage with or ignore those articles from the safety of my relative anonymity, now that Joan – or whoever put that note under my door – knows where I live, I feel exposed in a way I haven't been since I was fifteen years old.

As for the article itself, it had some inaccuracies, but I'd seen plenty worse. They got my name right, and my parents' names. They knew I was a reclusive child, and that I spent time in hospital. And, of course, they were correct in reporting that, over the course of my young life, everyone around me died. Without the latter detail, of course, the former would be entirely immaterial.

'But I like Elsa!' Persephone whines. 'From *Frozen*.'

'I like Maleficent.' I turn the page of my novel. 'Can I call you that?'

The child giggles. So does Daphne. *For pity's sake.*

Persephone is seven years old, daughter of Roxanne – the very attractive woman who moved in to number 5 a couple of months ago. The child's father doesn't appear to be in the picture, though there *has* been a string of unsavoury men in and out of the place at all hours of the night.

'I like the sex,' Roxanne told me when I raised an eyebrow at her, after watching her wave off yet another fellow one Saturday morning.

'Good for you, dear,' Daphne had told her cheerily, giving a little air punch.

'Is he your boyfriend?' I inquired.

Roxanne wrinkled her nose. 'God, no. No boyfriends for me.'

'Chicks before dicks,' Daphne agreed. 'Holes before poles.'

I'll admit, I chuckled at that. (Poor Joan, who had been walking by at the time, had just about passed out.)

I wonder if it's the sex or the child that makes Roxanne so tired. Every time I see her the poor girl has bags under her eyes. I sympathise, and yet it has to be said she has a fairly laissez-faire attitude to parenting, making herself scarce as Persephone terrorises the street – going from neighbour to

neighbour, demanding gold coin donations for school fundraisers or handing out substandard pictures she'd drawn and then returning to ensure they'd been properly displayed. One has to wonder where the child gets her audacity.

'Elsa!'

I sigh and peer over the top of my glasses at her. '*What?*'

'I have to interview an old person for my homework.'

Persephone, clearly, is ill-named. Anyone could tell you that a name like Persephone comes with a burden of expectation. A Persephone is lithe with golden hair, searching eyes, and a pensive, troubled spirit. This child is chubby and has a mouse-brown bob and smallish eyes; plain as a mud fence. She's also missing enough teeth that she resembles a sixteenth-century beggar. The child should have been named Medusa. Or Tempestas.

'And?' I prompt.

'And . . .' She stares demonstrably at Daphne and me. 'You're old.'

Daphne snorts. 'Elsie's older. She'll do the interview.'

The child looks at me. 'Will you do it?'

'Corsets she will!'

I give Daphne the stink eye. Traitor.

I wave to Peter, aka Pete the Greek, who is on his way home from a trip to Aldi, judging by the shopping bags. Peter lives directly opposite me. He's sixty-six years old and he spends most of his time drinking coffee and playing Tavli on his porch. The only time he ever leaves his house is to line up outside Aldi to purchase a television set or an automatic dog-feeder or whatever happens to be on sale that week. Upon his return, he always holds up his wares for me to admire, and I dutifully oblige because I'm fond of Peter. Occasionally he tries to sell me a coffee machine (because now he has three, *all paid for in cash*), but I draw the line. I'm not *that* fond of Peter.

'Elsie!' he calls out. 'Did you see that they've got long-handled hedge trimmers on special at Aldi this week? Not a bad price.'

'Is that right?' I say. No need to point out that Peter doesn't have a hedge, nor does he have so much as a plant in his entire courtyard. Typical

Greek, he paved the thing to within an inch of its life the moment he moved in.

‘Is that bloody dog still barking?’ he says.

‘Hasn’t stopped all day.’

Peter is instantly up in arms. ‘We should call the council,’ he says.

Peter loves being up in arms. So do I, truth be told. It’s a magnificent feeling. Superior-like.

Peter disappears inside his house. Once he’s gone I notice Persephone is observing me closely. ‘You smile whenever Peter’s around.’

‘What? Nonsense.’

‘You do.’

I’m about to protest further, but there’s no point, the child has moved on. She climbs into the chair opposite, right onto Daphne’s lap. Daphne beams. Unlike me, she’s always had a soft spot for children.

‘Right then,’ Persephone says, her pencil poised over a clipboard. ‘Why don’t we nip this in the butt?’

I take a slow, deep breath and let it out with otherworldly patience. ‘The bud.’

She ignores me. ‘How old are you, Elsie?’

‘How old do you think I am?’

She takes a moment to assess me. ‘I’d say . . . 167.’

‘At least,’ Daphne adds.

I give them both the stink eye. ‘I’m eighty-one.’

‘Eighty-one.’ Persephone is sceptical, but she writes it down. It feels unethical to dislike a child this much. ‘Now. Tell me something interesting. About the olden days.’

She gazes up at me as if expecting tales of riding dinosaurs and etching our ABCs into stone, Fred Flintstone–style.

‘Such as?’ I ask.

She thinks for a moment. ‘Something gory.’

I find myself wondering if it might have been Persephone who put that article under my door. ‘Such as . . .?’

‘Emma’s grandpa went to war and got shot in the leg!’

Persephone seems delighted about this, even forming a little gun using her thumb and forefinger and aiming it at her thigh. Daphne joins in, firing her own set of finger guns.

'Is that right?'

'Oh yes . . . there was blood and guts everywhere.'

'Guts? In his *leg*?'

'*Everywhere*,' she says. 'Oh! And Teddy's yiayia didn't even have *TV* when she was little!' She frowns, considering this a moment. 'She must have watched her phone.'

'Or her iPad?' Daphne offers.

It occurs to me that Persephone has been thrust into my life by virtue of some sort of karmic force. As you know, I haven't been a perfect citizen. And yet, I would be hard-pressed to find a hardened criminal of the worst variety who was deserving of this kind of torture.

'You know who you should interview?' I said, in a moment of genius. 'Ishaan!'

Ishaan, who is ninety-three, is my nemesis. He has lived next door for twenty-five years. He lived with Old Jim until five years ago when Jim died. *Mates*, Jim and Old Ishaan used to say whenever their living arrangements came up. *We're mates from university days*. As if I cared what Old Ishaan and Jim got up to. After Jim died, some bright spark decided to give Ishaan a demonic Chihuahua to keep him company. Ishaan has aged a lot since Old Jim died. The only time I see him these days is when he shuffles outside in his brown terry cloth robe to retrieve his vitamin deliveries. (Ishaan has never met a vitamin he didn't like. He is forever ordering them on iHerb. Fine by me, it is a free country after all. If he wants to give his last remaining dollars to charlatans for the privilege of turning his piss yellow, I wish him well.)

'He's dead,' Persephone says.

Daphne and I exchange a look. 'I beg your pardon?'

'Dead,' she says louder. 'D. E. D.'

'How do you know?'

‘Because,’ she says impatiently, ‘he didn’t answer when I knocked on the door before.’

‘So you assumed he was dead?’ Daphne says.

‘He’s *old*,’ Persephone says. It was as if she were trying to explain maths to a pair of stupid children. ‘You said so yourself. Old people die.’

‘Old people also take naps,’ I tell her, looking toward Ishaan’s.

‘But his boxes of vitamins are piled up on the doorstep,’ Persephone says.

‘Nugget *has* been barking more than usual,’ Daphne adds.

I sigh, then heave myself out of my chair.

‘Where are you going?’ Persephone calls after me.

‘Where do you think I’m going? I’m going to check if Ishaan is dead.’

‘But we have an interview to do!’

‘I’ll tell you one thing, if the old bastard has even a breath left in him, he’s going to do this bloody interview.’

‘And what if he is dead?’ Persephone asks.

I pause. ‘Then I’ll kill him.’

I really shouldn’t say stuff like that. It’s those kinds of comments that can land a girl in hot water. I should know.

Have you ever noticed there are two types of postal workers? There are the extremely helpful kind. The ones who pat the dogs, stow the package somewhere out of the rain, wait the extra minute for the elderly people to get to the door. And then there’s Dwayne, our postman.

Dwayne, if you don’t mind. Not Wayne. Not Dane. Dwayne. As if his mother had a stroke while filling in his birth certificate and the scrawl next to the name Wayne looked a little like a D.

As I arrive at Ishaan’s gate, Dwayne pulls up on his scooter and retrieves a small square box from his satchel. More vitamins, no doubt.

‘Not home?’ Dwayne asks.

I point to the small pile of boxes already on Ishaan’s doormat. ‘Apparently not. I can take it.’

‘Can’t. Needs to be signed for.’

For pity’s sake. As if someone is going to steal his bloody vitamins.

‘I’ll sign,’ I say.

‘Are you Ishaan Patel?’

‘There is nothing less attractive,’ I tell Dwayne, ‘than a humourless man.’

Dwayne returns the box to his satchel and moves to the next house, and I turn to the small pile of boxes already on Ishaan’s doormat.

I rap on the door with the old knocker.

‘When was the last time you saw Ishaan?’ I ask Peter, who is wheeling his rubbish bin, and mine, out to the mouth of the lane for collection.

‘Ishaan?’ He thinks a moment. ‘Must have been a couple of days ago. He was bent over retrieving a package from his doorstep when I walked past. When he noticed me he shouted: “Vitamin C!” Not “Good morning. Have you ever thought about taking vitamin C?” Or even “Looky here, my vitamin C has arrived.” Just “Vitamin C!” Then he disappeared back inside his house. Between you and me, Blind Freddy could see that Ishaan needs something a lot stronger than vitamin C.’

‘Ne’er has a bigger truth been uttered. Thanks, Peter.’

He moves along, unperturbed, and I go to the window and peer inside. It is impossible to see anything through the dirty net curtains.

I return to my place, past Daphne and Persephone who are still on my porch. The floorboards creak as I make my way down the hallway – if I were any younger I’d have worried I might need to redo the floors. I pass my bedroom, wallpapered in the once-vibrant orange and brown shades that were the height of fashion in the ’70s; the bathroom, with its avocado-coloured sink and toilet; the spare bedroom, door closed as always. I make my way into the back room, made up of a kitchen, a mishmash of orange laminate and cheap wooden cabinets; a dining corner, comprising one small, lacquered round table and four threadbare chairs; and a lounge room, with vintage armchair and couch, both upholstered in a faded tweed.

Through the back door is a small brick-paved courtyard and Hills Hoist. Ishaan and I share a fence line on one side, and the palings face him, so I

climb onto the backing rail and peer over.

Nugget sees me and begins barking hysterically.

'Ishaan!' I call out, leaning over the top. 'You there?'

No response. Then again, Ishaan is hard of hearing, he'd be hard-pressed to hear me at the best of times, let alone over the top of Nugget's barking.

'You're going to jump over?' Daphne asks, suddenly behind me.

'I guess I'll have to.'

It's true that I'm eighty-one years old, but as I've mentioned, I'm not your average eighty-one-year-old. I start climbing. It's pretty easy. My knees crack a little, and the weathered wood presses into my old hands uncomfortably, but it's fine until I get to the top. I'd hoped to see some sort of ledge, or chair, or barbecue area that I could step onto, but there is merely a drop straight down to a weedy-looking garden bed below.

'Do you see anything, Elsa?' Persephone calls.

'Elsie,' I correct. 'And yes, I see an incensed dog.'

Having Persephone on my side of the fence is all the motivation I need. I don't give myself time to consider whether I might break a hip, or my neck, or even how I will explain that I'm rappelling into Ishaan's back garden down the track. I also don't take the time to consider that, perhaps, a call to the police to conduct a welfare check might be a better idea. Unfortunately, this doesn't occur to me until I'm sliding down Ishaan's side of the fence, catching my ankle painfully on a shard of wood or nail.

'Shit!'

'I'm telling my mum,' Persephone calls. 'You sweared.'

'Fuck off,' I reply.

Daphne chortles.

I stand straight. To my surprise, Nugget doesn't take a chunk out of my ankle, or even my slacks. Instead, she looks at me intently, then runs back toward the house.

One thing I hadn't considered until now was what I would do once I got into Ishaan's backyard. I don't typically consider myself a fools-rush-in

sort. Perhaps I'm experiencing some of the Alzheimer's-induced madness that I read about recently in *Pensioner's Weekly*.

'What are you doing now?' Daphne calls.

'I'll just . . . go rap on the back door, I guess,' I tell her, and myself.

But as it turns out, I don't need to rap, because Ishaan's back door is glass, and through it I see him lying on the kitchen floor. He's in his brown terry cloth dressing-gown, and his skin is the dirty white colour of the linoleum floor. His eyes are open and unblinking.

Nugget watches him, her nose pressed up against the glass, her energetic little body suddenly drained of energy. For the first time all day, she doesn't yap.

3

THEN

I was born in 1944, just as the war was coming to an end. Christened Mabel Elsie Waller, I was the first child of Elliott Waller and Mary Fitzpatrick – a couple well known in the right circles for their good looks; their obscene wealth; and Rosehill, our stately home, an Edwardian mansion with a sweeping veranda, mahogany-panelled drawing rooms, and a full-time groundsman who still called my father ‘sir’ long after it was fashionable. It had once been the residence of my grandparents as well as several prominent figures in Australia, including a former prime minister.

They were also well known in our community as the parents of Mad Mabel.

I don’t remember ever discovering that was my nickname. Like discovering you have blue eyes or a vagina, it was something I’d always known but never thought a great deal about. I do, however, remember the day my mother found out.

It was a Sunday morning in the sweltering heat of an Australian summer, and I was six. The sky was the kind of endless blue you could fall into, and the parishioners of St Mary’s had spilled out into the courtyard after Mass and immediately split into three distinct factions: the men, who stood in loose circles, talking about business; the women, who stood in tight knots, gossiping about other women; and the children, who, elated after being forced to sit still for an hour, tore around on the grass outside the

presbytery, snatching each other's hats and frisbeeing them in front of oncoming traffic.

The men's conversation drifted over us – chatter about the Menzies government, the rise of suburban development, and whether petrol rationing would ever return. The women's talk was lighter, filled with murmurs of who was seen at Georges of Collins Street last week, which girl was engaged to a bank clerk, and how so-and-so's son had joined the RAAF.

I remained at my mother's side, something that I knew caused her tremendous irritation, particularly when my presence impeded the divulging of some juicy gossip by another mother. Still, her irritation was preferable to the humiliation of trying to join in where I wasn't wanted.

That particular day, I'd been grateful that another child – a little boy of about four or five – also insisted on hanging about his mother's legs, saving me from being the only one. Until he'd pointed his chubby little finger at me and said, 'You're Mad Mabel.'

My mother looked down at the boy, and then me. 'Did you just call her Mad Mabel?'

He nodded.

'Why?'

He shrugged. 'Everyone does.'

'Why?'

Neither the boy nor I had an answer for this. It hadn't occurred to me that there would be a reason, beyond a way to be cruel.

'Does everyone call you this?' she asked as we walked home from Mass a little while later in the shimmering heat. 'Even your friends?'

'Friends?'

Mum looked as if she was about to repeat herself. *Yes, Mabel, friends*. Then it dawned. 'You don't have any friends?'

It felt impossible that this could be news to her. Had she lived in an alternate house, where the doorbell rang constantly and the backyard was full of the squeals of neighbourhood children? Was it possible that she'd been so caught up in her own affairs that she hadn't noticed what a social failure her daughter was?

She became silent, perhaps thinking of all the opportunities I'd had to make friends – the playgroups, the church activities, the playdates at the houses of her friends who had similar-aged children. The reasons these didn't pan out varied. The church kids didn't think me pious enough; the kids from playgroup were scared of tall people; the twin daughters of my mother's friend Pauline already had each other, so didn't need more friends. I'd never expressly told my mother these things; we didn't have that kind of relationship. But I assumed she'd noticed. I'd thought she'd remained silent to spare me the embarrassment.

'I did have Daphne,' I said.

I said it to try to cheer Mum up, but it didn't have the desired effect.

Daphne was in my class at kindergarten. She'd started a few weeks after the rest of us, after her parents had relocated from England. After several weeks of following the teacher around at playtime while other kids buddied up to play, she'd marched right up to me and said: 'You're the princess and I'm the wicked queen, get in your tower!'

And we were off.

Daphne was the friend I'd been waiting for. She had a funny accent and said things like 'balderdash' and 'tickety-boo' and my personal favourite, 'Corsets I will.' She ate buttered bread with Marmite, and said 'I say' when surprised. She was the greatest thing to ever happen to me – she was cheeky and naughty and we were forever getting into mischief together. Perhaps this was why my mother hadn't been terribly disappointed when I told her the news that Daphne was moving back to England.

I was still broken-hearted.

'Well,' Mum said as we began to walk again. She reached into her handbag – a soft leather clutch from Finlay Bros – and took out her handkerchief, which she used to dab at her forehead. 'You'll make other friends then. At school. Don't worry.'

School, Mum decided, was where friendship would finally happen for me. She was sure of it. I didn't share her confidence. Even at a young age, I'd understood that school was nothing more than a convenient place to put the youth during those years they were not yet fit for the workforce. The

nuns would be strict, the uniforms scratchy, and the days long. But Mum was adamant.

I tried not to get caught up in her enthusiasm, but clearly, I didn't try hard enough. Because when my first day came around, I was hopeful. Almost expectant. Unfortunately, with great expectation came the opportunity for great disappointment.

School is an arduous thing. Sure, there are a few who sail through it like a yacht in the breeze, untouched by its breathless cruelty, but the vast majority would agree that it's ghastly. The stiff, itchy uniform. The unspoken hierarchy of the playground, policed far more rigorously than anything in the adult world. The lack of control over your life. The viciousness and unpredictability of a peer group hardwired to protect their place in the pack at all costs. The relentless inevitability of school, day after day after day. To add insult to injury, it's sold to you by older folk like it's a golden ticket to Willy Wonka's chocolate factory. Talk about gaslighting.

An only child of uninterested parents, I was left to my own devices for most of my formative years – encouraged to run off and play or simply make myself scarce. Once children were old enough to walk, they were expected to walk out the door and start creating mischief somewhere else. There's nothing wrong with this model of parenting, per se, and for many kids it worked well. There was the beach and bushland to explore, billycarts to race, and footy games in vacant lots that lasted until the streetlights flickered on. But for me, with no friends, it meant childhood was desperately, bone-achingly lonely.

Given my enjoyment of learning, my red hair and my unusual height, I was an obvious target of bullying at school. A smart girl who liked books and had the nerve to be taller than half the boys? Unforgivable. In grade 4, I was locked in the boys' bathroom at school and not released until I was prepared to declare that I had ambiguous genitalia. In grade 6, on the school bus, I was punched in the spine so hard I wet myself. The bus driver didn't stop, either. He merely called out for us to 'pipe down, in the back'. In

grade 7, I was given six sharp whacks on the hand with the strap by Brother Stanislaus for defacing a school library book that had been planted in my bag.

These indignities were distressing, of course, but nothing was as shameful as the performance I went through every afternoon when Mum asked, ‘Did you have a good day?’

‘Great,’ I’d say. ‘Wonderful!’

On the odd occasion, if I could muster it, I’d manage a story about something funny that happened in class or a friend I’d made. Sometimes I’d dawdle home and pretend that one of the girls from a few streets over had invited me to afternoon tea. As noble as it would feel to say I did this for Mum’s sake, it isn’t true. I did it for me. Because, as a few choice victims know, the only thing worse than bullying itself is the shame of speaking it aloud.

My bedroom at Rosehill was enormous by any yardstick. It had its own bathroom, a playroom and two enormous windows – one that faced the stretch of golden sand leading to the bay, and the other, a huge bay window and seat that overlooked the adjacent cul-de-sac.

The bay window gave me a ringside seat to the neighbourhood kids playing, which they always were. Most of the play revolved around sport. In summer, the boys played cricket; in winter, it was football, our driveway gate serving as the goalposts. When the weather was nice, I’d open the window so I could listen to them talking.

When my mother noticed me watching, she would suggest I join in, as if such a thing was easy. When I declined, she inferred that it was my reticence to try that was causing my issues with friends. She’d sigh dramatically, smooth down the pleats of her skirt, and remind me that when she was my age, she had friends over ‘for sponge cake and cordial’ nearly every weekend. After a while I understood that I had to march myself down, if only to satisfy Mum and stop her marching me down there herself.

I chose the day I overheard the kids in the street coming up with a plan to scale the back fences of all the houses in a race – a backyard challenge. Apparently, the Caseys at number 5 had got a new Sunbeam Mixmaster, and whoever made it around the whole cul-de-sac without getting caught by an adult would win one of Mrs Casey's famous malted milkshakes, the kind she served in frosty metal cups. I'm not sure if it was confidence in my climbing or my love of milkshakes that got me out of my window seat that day, but I sidled up to the group of kids who were discussing the best place to start the challenge and blurted out, 'Can I play?'

As expected, the kids assessed me with suspicion. It was as if I'd just stepped off one of the flying saucers I'd been hearing about on 3XY radio.

'The fence challenge,' I explained. 'I'd like to . . . join in.'

Their eyes slid back and forth in their sockets as they floundered to figure out who was authorised to answer. Such was the peculiar world of playground politics – hierarchies formed through footy prowess, sibling seniority and sheer force of personality. A few of the younger kids looked scared. I was scared too, though I was careful not to show it. My best chance, I'd figured, was to act as though I deserved to be there or, heaven forbid, belonged.

Finally, Billy Harris stepped up, the self-appointed authority. He was the oldest Harris boy, as handsome as he was stupid. I'd never liked the Harris boys. Shifty eyes, same as their father's.

'All right,' Billy said. 'You can be the timekeeper, Mabel. Go into your garden and wait by the fence. When the winner makes it over, come back and tell us who it was.' Billy didn't even try to conceal his smirk. 'Wait until the winner comes through. I don't want to see you again until the winner has made it over your fence.'

As the group ran away, I consoled myself with the fact that I already knew no one was coming.

4

Rosehill, my family home, was, and still is, the most beautiful house I've ever seen. I don't say this to be conceited, nor do I have a particular proclivity for beautiful houses, but the fact remains – it was a spectacular home. A grand Edwardian estate with a ballroom, a conservatory, a pool and a separate guesthouse. The walls were wallpapered and wood-panelled, the ceilings were high and papered, the cornices intricate. The lush gardens and expansive lawns were famously the site of the parish Easter egg hunt and had been long before the home was ours.

But while it's fair to say there was a lot of love for Rosehill in our community, no one loved it more than my father. During parties, he'd hold court, telling stories of its history, his personal favourite being his own history with the house.

'When I was a boy, I used to walk past Rosehill every morning on my way to school. Rosehill wasn't on the way to my school, mind you – it added a half-hour round trip to my morning – but day after day, I did it.

'Usually, I peered at it from across the road, but once, I was there when the iceman came in his horse and cart, and the gates opened so I could see right up the driveway. I thought it must be a castle because there was a princess right there in the window' – here he would turn to my mother, tipping his glass in her direction – 'my future wife.'

That part always got a reaction – an *awww* from the women, a teasing remark from one of the men, and, as expected, the faintest blush from my mother.

'I think even then, I knew Rosehill would be mine one day. I knew that I'd be the prince.'

It was a long time before I realised the love story wasn't between my mother and father at all. It was between my father and a house.

I noticed it in small ways first – how he would run a hand along the banister absentmindedly as he walked down the staircase, how he took his morning tea on the veranda, not for the sunshine but to admire the grand columns that framed the entrance. I started to see how he spoke of Rosehill not as a place where we lived but as something he owned, something he had conquered.

And my mother? She was part of the story, but not in the way I had thought. She was the girl in the window. The princess in the castle. Not loved, exactly. Just . . . there.

In the corner of my mother's bedroom was a dressing table with a large oval-shaped mirror in the centre and two smaller oval mirrors on either side. It had an upholstered bench seat that nestled underneath. The dressing table was a polished wooden piece, with rounded edges and delicate, carved legs. I knew enough from picture storybooks that a girl was supposed to sit at it of an evening while taking off her jewellery, after which she'd brush her hair a hundred times. I spent a large chunk of my early childhood sitting at this dressing table among the luxurious Lancôme lipsticks, compacts from Yardley, and delicate glass perfume bottles from Shalimar – watching Mum get ready for an evening out and listening to *Blue Hills*, her favourite serial, on the wireless radio.

'When *Blue Hills* starts,' she used to say, 'the world stops.'

Mum drank sherry, or sometimes gin, while she got ready for an evening out. Sometimes she drank both, and a lot of it. This could be a good thing. It was a good thing on the days she decided to give me a makeover. (I wasn't interested in makeup, but I was very interested in my mother's attention, so this was most welcome.) Occasionally, she'd keep my back to the mirror until she was finished so she could do a 'reveal'. She'd curl my lashes, pinch my cheeks and carefully apply a dash of lipstick – 'Red-Red' by Tangee. 'It's the perfect red,' she commented every time. 'Blood red.'

I always gasped and clapped when she finally spun me around, and Mum would watch me with a small, pleased smile.

On bad days, instead of watching me with a smile, she began to cry. Some days she cried so loud and for so long that the entire house pulsed with it. One day she became so upset she put her fist clean through the large oval mirror, all the way to the other side.

She was right, I thought, as I watched the blood run down her wrist. It was the exact colour of ‘Red-Red’ by Tangee.

5

‘You’re Elliott and Mary’s daughter?’

I was peering through the cigarette smoke of the dining room in a desperate search for my mother when the moustachioed man approached me. I’d been woken by the drunken shrieks of a particularly raucous dinner party – not an uncommon occurrence for me. My parents were well known for their epic parties, thanks to their affluence, courtesy of my grandfather’s prosthetic limb business (now run by my father). Many nights, I came downstairs to find inebriated guests slapping each other with titanium hands, or a hip socket lying on the white tablecloth next to the remains of the roast beef and Yorkshire pudding. I barely batted an eyelid.

‘Pardon?’

‘I said,’ he slurred, ‘are you really Elliott and Mary’s daughter?’

I wondered if the man was vision-impaired. How could one look at me and not see my father’s strong nose and jaw, and my mother’s pale complexion, blue eyes and large forehead? The origin of my hair colour was a matter of contention between my parents – while my mother was blond and my father’s hair was the darkest brown, they were both of Irish-Catholic heritage, which meant, according to my Aunt Cess, it was a fool’s errand trying to keep the redheads from the door.

The man took a step back, shaking his head.

I understood, even then, what he was thinking. That I wasn’t beautiful, like my mother with her pale peach complexion, her blond hair shaped into soft rolls or pinned in a neat bouffant that stayed in place no matter the weather. I also understood that it was a failing of mine. I understood it, even before I understood why.

‘She’s a little young, even for you, Arthur,’ Mum said, coming up behind me and twirling me like a ballerina.

Arthur chuckled, suddenly charming. ‘Touché, Mary.’

Mary, according to everyone you spoke to, always brought the fun. This may have been to do with the fact that she was drunk most of the time, and yet I’ve been drunk once or twice over my lifetime, and I don’t think anyone has accused me of ‘bringing the fun’.

‘To what do I owe this delight, Mabel?’

‘Noise woke me up.’

‘So you thought you’d come and have a dance?’ She twirled me again and I bumped into a circling waiter, spilling a tray of drinks.

‘Darn it,’ she said, letting me go. ‘Quick – off to bed. Before your father sees you.’

That was enough to get me moving. Unlike my mother, who could be unpredictable after a few drinks, my father was predictably short-tempered with me at all times, even when I wasn’t found doing something I shouldn’t. I scurried off, darting between the bodies I passed.

I paused at the grand staircase. It was at the centre of the house, beneath the chandelier in the foyer, and it was my favourite part. The staircase, made of rich, polished mahogany, descended as one from the top floor, then split into two at a landing, half sweeping off to the right, the other half to the left. Every time I came down it, I felt like a princess.

It was the part of the evening when people were too drunk to notice much, which made for terrific people-watching. It also made it relatively easy to go unnoticed if I tucked myself behind the stairs against the volute. After several minutes there, I had begun to think I was invisible, so when a woman with a platinum-blond poodle cut appeared and looked me directly in the eye, I gasped.

‘Shouldn’t you be in bed?’ Her perfectly arched eyebrows rose.

She was the most glamorous person I’d ever seen. She wore a white silk blouse with a gauzy A-line skirt covered in black butterflies. Her lips, a dramatic red, contrasted sharply with her almost-white hair, and left a stain at the end of her slim, white cigarette.

She took a puff, then turned her head to exhale. ‘Not tired, eh?’

‘No.’

‘I am.’ To my surprise, she sat down beside me on the step. Her gauzy skirt was so full I had to press myself against the banister to make space.

‘Must be lonely being the only kid in this big house,’ she said.

I nodded. I looked at my feet, but I felt her gaze. ‘I expect you regret what happened to Kitty now.’

I looked up.

It wasn’t unusual for grown-ups to not make sense at my parents’ parties. It was unusual for their ramblings to include me.

‘What do you mean?’

‘Susan.’

The woman and I both startled at my father’s voice. He stood at the bottom of the staircase, his shirt unbuttoned, his cheeks red from the wine.

‘Go to bed, Mabel,’ he said, dismissing me with a flick of his wrist.

I turned and ran up the stairs.

‘Why were you talking to her?’ I heard him say, when I reached the top. I squatted down, straining to hear.

‘Why wouldn’t I talk to her?’ Susan said. ‘She’s your daughter.’

My father made a dismissive noise.

For a moment, I heard nothing but the sound of a few people singing. I thought they might have moved away. Then my father spoke again.

‘We don’t talk about Kitty. Certainly not with Mabel.’

My father sounded irritated, but not angry. The way he sounded when he talked to my mother sometimes, before he kissed her. Not the way he ever sounded when he spoke to me.

‘Didn’t you sense that there was something . . . not quite right about her?’

There was a short pause.

‘I don’t know, Elliott,’ Susan said. ‘We didn’t talk for long. But she seemed like a normal child to me.’

‘A normal child?’ He made a noise, like a laugh when you don’t actually find anything funny. I couldn’t see him, but I pictured his contorted face, his intense stare that he locked people in with when he was going to have the last word. ‘The child is mad, Susan.’

They must have moved away from the stairs because I didn't hear any more after that. But I remained where I was for a long time, shame staining my skin like a handprint after a slap.

There were two things I liked about my father. Yes, it took me a long while to come up with them, but frankly, he's lucky to get two.

Firstly, a blind man could tell you my father had lovely hair. Thick and dark with the slightest wave that everyone said made him look like Cary Grant, including my father. He tended to his locks with obscene vanity, using specific combs and products and spending an inordinate amount of time in front of the mirror in our foyer, admiring himself. I recall him becoming very upset with my mother when she bought the wrong brand of hair cream from the store. He was partial to Brylcreem.

There was only one other good thing about my father, and that was his socks. The man had an enviable sock collection. Most were purchased from Harrods during visits to London, and they tended to be navy or black or, occasionally, maroon with grey diamonds. Pure wool. The epitome of luxury.

Often, when he sat in his armchair of an evening, his feet on the footstool, I'd see them peeking out of his trouser legs and think, *Those are nice socks*. On the days I fantasised about murdering him, I always imagined donating his great fortune to charity because I wasn't interested in any of it. *Except for his socks*, I'd say. I wanted to keep them. What can I say? They were very nice socks.

6

NOW

On a small street like Kenny Lane, populated entirely by busybodies, the arrival of a paramedic vehicle generates much hubbub. As I stand outside Ishaan's, talking to the paramedic, every resident appears, huddling around Pete the Greek, who is issuing 'facts' about what had happened with enough authority that even I start to question myself.

'Heart attack,' he says. 'Else broke in through the window and performed CPR.'

For pity's sake, Peter. The back door had been unlocked, so there was no need to break in, and as for CPR – even if it hadn't been clear that Ishaan was long dead, that would have been a stretch for me. I did manage to roll him onto his side and listen for breathing and a heartbeat as I'd seen done countless times on television, and frankly that was ghastly enough. It wasn't the fact that he was dead so much, more that it was Ishaan. I was okay with death. Ishaan's wasn't the first dead body I'd seen. Unlike the last one, there was no cracked skull or blood-spattered walls. Apart from a trickle of blood that came from one ear, it appeared to be a neat, orderly, natural-causes death.

I left him on the floor and called 000, before opening the door for Daphne.

'Anything else of note?' the handsome young paramedic asks.

His name, he told us a minute ago, is Anthony. Daphne and I had exchanged a meaningful look. He is tall, tanned and unmistakably buff

beneath his uniform. It irks me how young people think we don't notice this kind of thing as we age. We may be old, but we have eyes.

'What does "of note" mean?' Persephone asks. The child has no regard for personal space. Her warm little body presses against me hard enough that it very nearly pushes me off balance. She smells of something too sweet, like deodorant or cheap perfume or bubble gum. By her side is Ishaan's demonic dog, barking again.

'It means . . . perhaps he mentioned something to you – like taking a particular medication or experiencing chest pains?'

'He's a big fan of vitamins,' Persephone says.

'He's a big fan of this dog,' Daphne adds.

I glance down at the dog. 'What will happen to Nugget?'

Anthony shrugs. 'If there's a friend or family member who wants her, she might go to them. If there's no one, they go to the local rescue centre.'

All at once, as if understanding, Nugget stops barking.

'You heard that, did you?' I mutter. 'Good.'

Mrs Nguyen arrives home in the middle of the chaos, and takes in the scene. She lives on the other side of Ishaan with her husband, Mr Nguyen. At a guess I'd say they are in their forties, but we all refer to them as *Mr* and *Mrs* because we cannot pronounce their first names for love nor money. Mrs Nguyen runs the nail salon on the high street by day and works at her parents' Vietnamese restaurant several nights. Mr Nguyen doesn't do anything much, and whenever I come across Mrs Nguyen she tells me all about how she's going to leave him to join a women's commune, and I pump my fist in solidarity, and we go on with our respective days.

'I'll explain,' Persephone says to Mrs Nguyen. 'Don't listen to Pete the Greek, he doesn't know what he's talking about.'

Persephone leads Mrs Nguyen toward the huddle of residents.

At the same time, I watch Joan slip away from the huddle and sidle up to Anthony the paramedic. Odd woman. Her movements are so stealthy and so quiet I can't help but be intrigued.

'What happened to him?' she asks him, sotto voce.

'Hard to say,' Anthony says. 'The coroner will determine for sure.'

‘The coroner?’ Joan says. Her eyes boggle ever so slightly with excitement. ‘So there are signs of foul play?’

Joan, it appears, has cast herself as Jessica Fletcher in *Murder, She Wrote*.

‘The coroner needs to take the body and determine cause of death, but given his age,’ Anthony says, ‘and what I observed, I would say there’s nothing to suggest . . . foul play.’

Admirably, his face remains straight.

‘Still,’ she says, ‘you can’t rule it out.’ Her eyes widen and she juts her chin in my direction. ‘If you know what I mean.’

‘I’m not sure I do,’ Anthony says. He glances from Joan to me and back again, uncertain of the dynamic he’s dealing with.

‘*She’s* the one who found him,’ Joan cries. ‘Have you considered the possibility that it’s because she knew where to find him?’

All eyes dart to me. For the love of God.

‘You think *I* killed Ishaan?’

A few metres away, Pete the Greek and the group of residents have stopped talking and are pretending not to listen. Persephone outright gawps.

‘I won’t pretend to know the details,’ Joan says.

‘Then you have no business making accusations.’ Daphne’s voice is quiet, but full of menace. Persephone comes and stands beside her, perhaps in solidarity.

A white van pushes its nose onto the street. CORONER is written on the side in discreet green font. Anthony waves at the driver and points in the direction of Ishaan’s house.

‘I’m sorry, ladies,’ Anthony says to Joan, ‘but I have to speak to the coroner. If you have concerns, you need to speak to the police.’

‘I’ll speak to my nephew,’ Joan calls after him as he wanders off. ‘He’s a partner in a law firm.’

‘So let me get this straight,’ I say to Joan. ‘You’re suggesting that I murdered Ishaan, left him to rot on his kitchen floor for a while, then climbed the fence to discover him?’

‘Well, that’s silly!’ Persephone says. ‘Elsa wanted him to be alive because she wanted Ishaan to do the old person interview instead of her! I was the one who told her he was dead!’

‘That’s true,’ I say. ‘Have you considered that Persephone could be the killer?’

Persephone’s jaw drops. Daphne puts an arm around her. ‘She’s joking, poppet.’

Joan shakes her head. She’s facing away from me, projecting her words as if she’s on stage. ‘All I’m saying is that she should be investigated. She’s *dangerous*.’

‘I agree,’ I say. ‘But do you really think she could kill someone? She’s just a child.’

Persephone gives me the stink eye.

‘Joan,’ Pete says, putting a hand on her shoulder. ‘I think that’s enough.’

Joan shrugs him off. ‘Why is no one listening to me?’

‘Because Elsa isn’t dangerous,’ Persephone explains. ‘She’s too *old* to be dangerous.’

Mother of God . . .

‘What is *wrong* with you people,’ Joan cries, fully descending into madness. ‘Don’t you know *who she is*?’

Silence falls upon the little group.

As Joan’s gaze travels slowly and purposefully toward mine, I feel the knowledge settle over me – as quick and heavy as a storm cloud. The reason Joan scurries away every time she sees me. The reason she’s hell-bent on trying to force me out of the street. I’m a fool for not seeing it sooner.

Joan has known who I am all this time.

I open my mouth, praying for something clever and cutting to fall out of it. I’m a long study in clever and cutting. Instead, there’s only a noise – something like a croak. For a moment I think – horrifically, ridiculously! – that I might cry. It’s an indignity of old age, the way your body can betray you in an instant like this, with no warning.

Daphne puts a hand on my shoulder.

‘Joan,’ Pete says firmly. ‘Enough.’
This is the moment the police car pulls onto the street.

7

I'd planned to head straight inside, but by the time I make it up my front steps I fear my legs might give out on me, so Daphne insists I sit.

'Would you like to do some deep breathing together?' She starts inhaling.

'I'm fine,' I say to her.

Daphne keeps inhaling like a lunatic.

'For the love of God, Daphne, stop that before you hyperventilate.'

The police and the coroner are inside Ishaan's house. In the laneway, Peter and Joan are speaking in hushed whispers. The idea that Joan knows who I am is unsettling, but Peter knowing is mortifying. Peter is a good man and a good neighbour. The idea of him being aware of such a thing about me humiliates me to my very core.

'Forget her,' Daphne says. 'Miserable old cow.'

'Forget who? I don't know what you're talking about.'

Daphne rolls her eyes. 'You're shaking, darling.'

'She was the one then,' I say. 'Who put the article under the door.'

'But we already knew that, didn't we?' Daphne says.

I nod. 'Now we also know she told Peter.'

'We don't know that. Maybe Peter already knew?'

I shake my head. Oddly – unreasonably – I feel like I would have known if he did. It would have displayed itself through awkward, stilted conversations rather than the ease and comfort of our day-to-day acquaintance. In the end, I suppose, it doesn't matter.

'Shoo!' I say, when I look down and see Nugget at my feet. 'Shoo, you stupid dog.'

'Let her stay,' Daphne says, always a soft touch. 'She misses Ishaan.'

'At least someone does.'

‘Someone will come and get her soon.’

I roll my eyes. ‘Fine.’

We sit for a moment in silence. But when Daphne makes a noise, I glance over at her.

‘What?’ I say.

She’s giggling.

‘What?’ I repeat. I’m already laughing too, pre-emptively.

‘What about when she asked the paramedic if there was any evidence of . . .’ Daphne is laughing so hard she can’t finish.

‘Foul play!’ I cry.

We double over in the companionable silence that comes when there is no oxygen left for more laugher. It fills up every part of me until there is no room left for fear or shame or horror. This, I realise, is the true gift of friendship. The lifesaving part of friendship.

‘What’s so funny?’

The child appears from nowhere, causing Daphne and me to scream. I clasp a hand to my heart. ‘Mother of God, child, don’t you have a home?’

‘Yes. But I like hanging out with you.’

Daphne beams. ‘And we like hanging out with you, darling.’

‘Mother of –’

‘Don’t say “Mother of God”,’ Persephone jumps in. ‘You need to come up with a better catchcry.’

I close my mouth. Impertinent child.

‘You have blood on your shoe.’

‘What?’

Persephone is pointing at my right foot where blood has pooled on the top of my navy sneakers. ‘See?’

‘So I have.’ I pull up the hem of my trousers. There, just above the ankle, is a deep, ragged cut that appears to be oozing blood. ‘It must have been from the fence.’

Daph winces. She’s never been good with blood.

Persephone recoils. ‘I’ll get my mum. She’s a nurse. MUM!’

‘Don’t get your mother,’ I say, not only because she is not, to my knowledge, a nurse, but because it is entirely unnecessary. But it’s too late, Persephone is out of her seat, headed toward her terrace house.

‘Mother of –’ I cry, then slap a hand over my mouth. Persephone shakes her head disappointedly.

Roxanne lets herself in through my gate and onto my porch, carrying a white tin medicine box under one arm. She’s a tall woman, at least compared to anyone but me, the kind of scrawny slim of catwalk supermodels. She’s yawning, as per usual.

‘Your daughter has been bothering me for hours,’ I say, gesturing at Persephone. ‘You wouldn’t ever consider actually parenting your own child, I suppose?’

‘God, no,’ Roxanne says, setting down the box. She kneels by my feet. ‘I assume it’s this ankle?’

‘Was it the blood that tipped you off?’

Roxanne snorts. She is, it turns out, one of those offensively good-natured people. It makes me wonder if she is, in fact, a nurse. It’s always bothered me, nurses and their insufferable cheer. Never mind that they spend their days doing the most difficult and important job on earth for a wage barely above the poverty line, they do it with a bloody smile on their faces. It’s hard to take, truly it is.

‘A lot of drama today.’ Roxanne rolls up the leg of my slacks and starts efficiently unwrapping a sterile cloth from its plastic wrap. ‘How are you feeling?’

‘Me?’ I say. ‘I’m feeling fine. Why wouldn’t I be?’

In fact I’m feeling clammy and a little unwell.

‘Not every day you see a dead body.’

‘No, I suppose not,’ I say. My voice sounds a little funny, so I clear my throat. ‘Unless you’re a coroner, I suppose. Or in the medical field. By the way, Persephone tells me you’re a nurse.’

I mean it comically, to highlight the fact that children are insufferable liars, but Roxanne shoots her daughter what I would consider to be *a look*.

'I am,' she says after a beat. 'Also a cook. A chauffeur. A cleaner. Generally I go by the job title of mother, though.'

'That's why you're always yawning then,' I say. 'All that mothering.'

She shrugs. 'You have to hustle, don't you? To make ends meet.'

I consider this. 'Persephone's father contributes though? Financially?'

'We make do,' Roxanne says. She rummages in her box and pulls out a tube of something. 'Anyway, let's see what we have under all this blood.'

As she begins to clean the wound, I find myself staring. She's a lovely-looking girl. Almost black hair, pale skin, rosy cheeks, water-blue eyes. She's in a tracksuit today, but I've seen her tarted up to go out on the town, and in her tight dresses you can't help but notice her hourglass figure. There'd been a time when I would have yearned for even one-hundredth of this beauty, but one of the many glorious things about old age is that while aspirations of beauty may linger, they sit well below aspirations of health, comfort and absence of pain.

'Owww!' I cry. '*Mother of God, Roxanne!* What are you putting on me now? Acid?'

'It's antiseptic,' she says, rolling her eyes. 'Sissy.'

'Elsie Fitzpatrick?'

We all look up. A pair of uniformed police stand in front of us.

'Good afternoon,' one says. 'I'm Constable Harris and this is Constable Gibson.'

The police are both men, which is disappointing. All the British crime shows I watch have led me to believe that police partnerships are exclusively between a man and a woman, generally a young, exceptionally attractive couple with Cockney accents and a lot of unresolved sexual tension.

'Oh good!' I say. 'Are you here for the dog?'

'Which dog?'

I point at Nugget. I get the feeling that these policemen aren't the sharpest tools in the shed. They are both that north-of-sixty, thick-necked

variety of man – the kind that still lives with his elderly mother and tells people that he 'cares' for her when really he's just waiting it out so he can steal her fully-paid-off two-bedroom villa-unit in Bonbeach. They are the same height (five-foot-eight would be my guess) and the same build (rotund), and both have that pink-stained mottled skin of one who drinks too much and doesn't take care of himself. It would have been difficult to distinguish one from the other had it not been for Harris's thick salt-and-pepper moustache and beard, and the fact that Gibson is bald as a bowling ball. In light of this, I call them – inside my own head – Hairy and Baldy.

'Nugget isn't my dog,' I say. 'She's Ishaan's. Ishaan who *just died*?'

Understanding dawns, finally. 'Oh. Well, no, we're not here for the dog. You'll have to call the animal shelter.'

'*I'll* have to?' I blink. 'Can't *you* call the animal shelter?'

'I'm afraid not. We just wanted to give you our card, as you were the one to find your neighbour.'

The moustachioed policeman holds out a business card and I take it.

'What happened to your arm?' he asks.

'What?' I look at my arm. 'Oh, that. It happened a couple of days ago when I discovered Nugget in my garden. When I returned her to Ishaan, he grabbed her and scratched my arm! That'll teach me to do a community service.'

'Rude,' Persephone says.

'Yes. Well. Admittedly I was threatening to send her to the sausage factory. But never mind that.'

There's a short silence. Even Persephone doesn't speak. It's irritating, having to be the one to fill the silence all the time.

'Anyway, why do I have to call the animal shelter? Nugget is the only resident I dislike more than Ishaan.'

Roxanne also gives me a funny look. I realise I might have made a faux pas.

'Disliked,' I correct. 'My apologies. *Disliked* more than Ishaan.'

8

THEN

Trips abroad were part of the fabric of my childhood, in the same way dinner and bath time are for other kids. I'm not sure I can adequately describe the glamour of this kind of travel – these days just about anyone can jump on a discount airline with their neck pillow and compression socks, but back then it was a big deal. My mother bought outfits just for the ship over there. She wore tailored dresses with long, pencil-thin skirts and little hats that perched on her head, and she styled her hair to perfection in French twists and the occasional pompadour. I got a new frock just to throw streamers as my parents pulled away from the dock at Station Pier!

I was not invited on these trips, obviously.

While my parents travelled the world, I stayed home with my Aunt Cecily.

Cess was my mother's younger sister. She and my mother had grown up at Rosehill, when it was owned by their parents. Now, as Cess was unmarried, she remained in the guesthouse, except for when my parents went abroad, when she'd move in to a spare bedroom in the main house. It happened enough that by the time I was ten, she didn't bother moving back to the guesthouse upon their return.

'All that coming and going,' she said. 'Not good for this old body.'

Cess was twenty-eight when she said that. Positively ancient, it seemed.

Cess was a fascinating contradiction to me. She didn't work due to her family wealth, yet she was happy to perform duties like cooking and

laundry, and believed strongly in rights for women. She didn't suffer fools, but she could play the fool if it was advantageous for her in the long run. She didn't believe in women conforming, but she put enormous effort into her appearance.

She was the kind of attractive that could stop men, and oftentimes women, talking when she walked into a room. Her platinum-blond hair was pixie-cropped, her lips were Revlon 'Cherries in the Snow' red, and she favoured slacks over skirts – cigarette pants or pedal pushers with fitted tops and thick shiny belts buckled tightly at the waist. She smoked cigarettes and drank martinis. My mother called her a widgie, in a whispered voice through pursed lips.

'Wouldn't kill her to put on a frock once in a while,' my mother would say. 'And grow out her hair a little. She'll never find a husband dressing like that.'

I suspected Cess would have had no trouble finding a husband if she'd wanted one. But I had a hunch she didn't. And that hunch turned out to be correct.

When Cess was in charge, she tended to my needs without fuss or complaint, and I went about my life as before. Unless Vanessa – Cess's best friend – was visiting, in which case I made sure I was around. I adored Vanessa.

Cess and Ness, as they called each other, had been friends since they were kids. Ness worked as a librarian at our local library. Like Cess, Ness was whip-smart, but she had a softness to her. Her face seemed always on the verge of a smile, as if recalling a funny joke. She was small and pretty with a swinging high ponytail and cat-eye glasses. But the best thing about Ness was her way of making me feel like she was truly interested in what I had to say.

'What are you working on?' she'd ask, if she found me doing my homework at the kitchen table. Then, rather than going about her business and making tea or drying the dishes like Cess would, she'd sit and give me her undivided attention as I told her about Australian history, or Pythagoras'

theorem, or narrative poetry with the enthusiasm of one who'd never known such things existed.

'She's fantastic, Cess,' she'd say, after reading a banal piece of writing I'd completed. 'Have you read this? Her vocabulary is better than most adults! And her turn of phrase!'

When she did this, I acted embarrassed or uninterested, too afraid she would realise that I lived for these comments. I lived for them.

'You should write a diary,' Ness said to me one day.

'What for?'

'For your thoughts. Or your feelings? Or your imaginations! You can write anything you like in there. It would be a great way to develop your writing.'

Once I heard Cess and Ness talking after I'd left the room to wash up for dinner. 'Why don't they take her abroad with them? It would be fantastic for a kid like Mabel. She'd get so much out of it.'

'She would,' Cess agreed. 'But that would involve her parents thinking of someone other than themselves for five minutes and I don't see it happening.'

It wasn't the first time I'd heard Cess say such a thing about my father, not by a long shot. But I was surprised to hear her lump my mother in. That said, Mum had been drinking more and more recently, and I knew that bothered Cess. It was true she probably didn't think about anyone other than herself after a few drinks.

'After what happened to Kitty, you'd think they'd appreciate the child they had. Spend some time with her.'

Kitty. The name sent a jolt through me.

We don't talk about Kitty, my father had said at that dinner party when I was little. *Certainly not with Mabel.*

I was starting to suspect my parents had had another child – Kitty. But why didn't they talk about her? And why certainly not with me?

'Well,' Ness said. 'If they're too stupid to appreciate Mabel, you and I will have to do it.'

'Is that right?' I heard the smile in Cess's voice.

‘Damn straight,’ Ness said.

From outside the door, I smiled, even though I had no way of knowing at the time that that conversation changed the entire course of my life.

While my parents were away for months at a time – in England, Hong Kong or South Africa – my mother and I wrote letters. Mum was a beautiful letter writer. With pen and paper, she seemed better able to distil her thoughts and feelings. In this, and perhaps only this, my mother and I were the same. She wrote on stationery that was floral and embossed, the ink dark and precise, as if every letter had been carefully chosen. I felt more connected to her by reading her letters than I did when in her physical presence.

You would love Italy, Mabel. Everywhere you turn there is something magnificent – the Colosseum, the Duomo, the statue of David! I feel like I’m in a history book. As you walk about, you can practically feel the souls of the people who walked before you. In a place like this, you can’t help but reflect on your life, and what’s important. Several times a day, I see it through your little observing eyes, I smell it through your sensitive little nose. I hear your funny little questions – ‘Why is the air full of happiness here, Mummy?’

You may seem bookish, darling, but in your heart, you’re an artist.

Lovely, right?

That particular letter was in grave danger of disintegrating from so many nights under my pillow, days in my pocket or sweaty hand. The paper had begun to yellow at the edges, the ink smudged where my fingers had touched it too many times. It was a silly yearning, I suppose, to be so desperate for a mother’s love. So desperate that I didn’t mind that I couldn’t recognise myself in the letters at all. The word ‘little’, for example, used three times in this paragraph, wasn’t one typically used for me. The comment about the air being full of happiness was whimsical in a way I could never be. And she was wrong about me being an artist, a poet. I was bookish, nothing more.

It was almost as though she were writing the letters to someone else entirely. Some days, when I could distance myself enough, I'd wonder who she was actually writing to.

As a librarian, Ness was always on the hunt for books I might enjoy. Each time I finished something, it became her mission to find something I'd enjoy more. Each search began with a quiz.

'What's the best book you've ever read?'

'The worst?'

'What did you just finish?'

'If you could invent a book, what would it be about?'

I'd answer as best I could, shy at first, but with more confidence when I realised she genuinely cared. Every time – without fail – she'd press the perfect book into my hands.

One day, that book was *Anne of Green Gables*.

'The protagonist, Anne, reminds me of you,' she said, eyes sparkling behind her cat-eye glasses. 'She's smart and creative and has fiery red hair. And she's an orphan.'

I blinked and took the book from her, startled.

'Not that you're an orphan,' she added quickly, flustered. 'You know what I mean.'

I wasn't sure I did. My mind scrambled to make sense of it, to decode what she meant. But before I could ask, she did something unexpected: she pulled me into a hug. It was brief and a little awkward – her cardigan smelled like peppermint and old paper – but it was warm. Intentional.

I stood stiffly, heart racing, until something in me softened. And then I understood. Not just the Anne comparison, but something bigger. This woman saw me. And she cared.

It was, I realised, the first time in my entire childhood I could remember someone hugging me without being asked or obligated. Just because they wanted to.

9

Of course I started a diary. As Ness suggested, I wrote about my thoughts and my feelings and my imaginations – whatever came to my mind. It felt strange. I'd been raised in a house where feelings were something you folded up and put away, like winter jumpers in the spring. But with a pencil in hand, I found I could make sense of my feelings. It was like cracking open a secret room in my own brain.

Oftentimes I found myself writing about Cess and Ness's friendship. It seemed to me that there was something magical about it.

Part of it was that it was unusual. Most women their age spent most of their time with their husbands and children, or occasionally with their husbands' friends' wives. It was uncommon to see two unmarried women attending Mass together, doing their grocery shopping, visiting the theatre. Because of this Cess and Ness were often the subject of whispers about town. Perhaps this was the reason Ness spent a lot of time at our house, away from gossip and prying eyes.

Cess and Ness loved to talk. I remember marvelling that after so many years of friendship, they still had so much to talk about. Eavesdropping was among my favourite pastimes when Cess and Ness were talking. They always had the most salacious gossip – about our local priest, about the neighbours, about the fathers of kids I knew who had become a little too friendly with one of them at the parish ball. The only thing better than listening to their gossip was listening to the wonderful, baffling way they knew what the other was saying, without needing to use full sentences.

'Cess?' Ness would say. 'Do you –'

'Yes, okay, but let me just –'

'Of course, I'll help you.'

And then they'd walk as one to the laundry, take baskets of wet clothes outside, and hang them out on the clothesline.

When I asked how they always seemed to know what the other was about to say, they looked just as puzzled as I was.

'A feeling?' Ness ventured.

'Experience,' Cess said, more confidently. 'When you've been friends as long as we have, you start to notice the patterns. I always know what Ness is thinking.'

Ness chuckled. 'Usually even before I do.'

'You're bosom friends,' I said once. 'Like Anne Shirley and Diana.'

They exchanged a glance, then a smile.

I don't know exactly what it was about that moment – but it made my chest ache. I felt happy watching them, and at the same time, like I might cry. I wanted what they had – badly.

It was like spotting a beautiful car you knew you'd never be able to afford. You were glad it existed. But sad it would never be yours.

10

Even at seven or eight, I knew where I belonged at Rosehill – and it wasn't in the ballroom. Particularly during one of my parents' famous dinner parties. While the grown-ups drank sherry and waltzed beneath the chandeliers, I stayed tucked away in the kitchen with the caterers, who let me stir sauces and sprinkle herbs like I was part of the team. I spent hours there, apron tied over my party dress, happily invisible.

But my favourite part of the evening always came after the catering staff packed up and slipped out the side door. That's when the stealth portion of the night began. I'd tiptoe through the house, observing the party from the shadows, crouched in nooks and behind curtains, tucked on stair landings or behind half-closed doors. I didn't really need to hide. By that time of night, the guests were too drunk or too distracted to care.

I always carried my diary and pencil with me as I did my rounds, making notes about everything I saw, as if I were a journalist.

> **10:22 pm**: Lady in red dress laughs loudly, spills champagne down her dress. Man in blue suit licks her neck, her chest and her tummy. People laugh and the man says: 'What? I didn't want good champagne to go to waste.'

> **11:13 pm**: Woman in green shoes tells man in shiny black shoes that he's making a fool of himself. Man in shiny shoes slaps her. Woman cries.

I recorded the last entry from the floor of the coat closet, which was why I could only see the people's feet. I was still in the closet writing up my notes when the door whooshed open and a hand dipped inside, retrieving a fur.

'What are you doing there, scallywag?'

Mum looked like a movie star. She was wearing a cream dress with a glittery cape and heels so high I worried for her ankles.

‘To bed,’ she said as I scrambled to my feet. She dropped a kiss on my head. ‘Scoot.’

I scurried up the stairs. But as I started down the hallway toward my bedroom, I heard something. It sounded breathy and gruff and frightening – and close. I stopped, looked around.

I saw the blond, Hollywood hair first – a beacon in the darkness at the end of the hallway against the wall. Next I saw shoes, glittery gold mules that were attached to creamy white legs that were suspended midair at an odd angle. For a moment, I thought I was seeing an angel. Then I realised the legs were wrapped around a black-suited man. As my eyes adjusted I realised the man’s trousers were lowered and his buttocks were visible, clenching and unclenching rhythmically against the woman.

In horror, my eyes fell to the floor, and that’s when I noticed. Between the man’s shiny black lace-ups and the fallen trousers was a sliver of maroon sock bearing grey diamonds. Pure wool.

11

NOW

A week passes. Then another.

More vitamins arrive at Ishaan's porch and remain there. His curtains stay drawn. The screen door doesn't open. One morning, a van pulls up and a cleaning company begins unloading supplies onto the kerb. A few hours later, the boxes of vitamins are gone. Later that day, I hear Mr Nguyen telling Dwayne – in a low voice, but not low enough – that Ishaan had died.

The next time I wheel my bin out to the kerb, I pause at Ishaan's now-empty porch. It looks strange without the clutter. Barren, almost. I'm suddenly overcome.

Maybe it's the reminder that one day, all of us will stop receiving packages. That the world keeps spinning without ceremony. Or maybe I'm just coming down with something. I've often found that a jolt of emotion is the harbinger of a nasty cold or virus. Just when I start to worry I'm depressed, I sneeze or vomit and think, *Oh good. That's what it was*.

I don't hear from the police again. Life continues as before. Joan scurries away every time she sees me. Persephone makes a pest of herself. Peter is as affable as ever, which I find baffling, considering what I'm certain he knows. He even brought over a fluffy dog bed and dog feeder for Nugget (both bought on special at Aldi, obviously), which I initially refused because I had no intention of keeping her. I tried putting the dog out on the

street and she stood on my doorstep, barking. Finally, to avoid her crapping in my roses, I let her inside and called the animal shelter.

'You're at *capacity*?' I cried. 'But you're a bloody shelter.'

'Yeah,' the guy said. 'Even shelters run out of space, I'm afraid.'

'But I'm an elderly woman. The dog is bereaved. I'm not equipped.'

'I don't know what to say.'

'What would happen if I came and left her on the doorstep?' I said. 'You'd have to take her then.'

'Unfortunately,' the man said, 'the dog would have to be euthanised.'

I looked at Nugget, at my feet, who had the good sense to stop barking.

What's happening? Daphne mouthed.

'If you could keep her for another week or two, I promise I'll find her a spot.'

'Two weeks,' I said. 'Tops.'

Yesterday – two weeks to the day – I called again, only to be told it would be another two weeks.

'Seven days,' I said. 'After that, I'll euthanise the dog myself.'

Daphne laughed. 'You wouldn't dare!'

'With everything you know about me,' I said to Daphne, 'do you really believe that?'

*

One afternoon, when I venture onto my porch to let Nugget do her business, I find Persephone in the laneway with a purple iridescent hula hoop around her neck. She attempts to make it spin by jutting and retracting her chin rhythmically, but the hoop remains motionless. Odd child.

'Elsa!' she cries when she sees me. I might have found her excitement endearing had she not tossed her hoop into the air with excitement, sending it hurtling into my rosebushes. 'Want to play Uno?'

For the love of God.

'No,' I say. 'And get that hula hoop out of my rosebushes.'

But she's already seated at my wrought-iron table, pulling the cards from her pocket.

'Is Nugget yours now?' Persephone says as she concentrates on dealing. Her tongue sticks out as she does it, which is something approaching – but not quite – endearing.

'Don't be absurd, child.'

'What will happen to her?'

I glance into the street for someone to palm her off to. But everyone is wiser than me. 'Sausage factory, I expect.'

'*What?*' She looks up, eyes wide and broken-hearted. Mother of God.

I have an idea.

'Unless . . . I don't suppose you want her?'

'*Me?* A dog?' Her face morphs from confused to utterly delighted. 'OMG OMG OMG.' Her face falls. 'But my mum would never let me.'

'I'm sure I could help you convince her,' I say.

'Really?' Persephone abandons the cards and kneels on the porch. 'You think?'

'Why not?' I say, feeling downright convivial. What a marvellous idea! With the dog, the child might even find herself too busy to visit me. I can't believe I didn't think of it earlier.

'Come here, little one!' she says, thrusting out a chubby hand toward Nugget. Nugget bares her teeth.

'Oh,' she says, withdrawing her hand. 'She doesn't like me.'

'Nonsense,' I say gaily. 'She's smiling!'

Nugget growls at her.

'Oh, don't worry about *that*,' I say. 'She does that to everyone. Look.'

I reach out a hand toward the little hellion, fully prepared to take a flesh wound and a dose of rabies if it gets rid of the dog. But the damned thing approaches slowly, and licks – licks! – my hand. I rip it away.

'I think she wants to stay with you, Elsa!' Persephone says.

'Balderdash. She's confused. Perhaps she thinks I'm Ishaan. Anyway, why are you still here? Where is your mother?'

'Sleeping.'

‘*Sleeping?* In the middle of the day?’

She nods. Odd. I wonder, idly, if Roxanne might be a very friendly drug addict. She *does* always look tired.

‘What if we play Snap?’ Persephone says.

‘No.’

‘One game?’

‘Go play with someone else.’

She looks around dramatically at the empty street, then cocks an eyebrow. ‘Who?’

Impertinent child. ‘I don’t know. A friend?’

‘But you’re my friend.’

‘Don’t be absurd.’

She crosses her arms and sticks out her bottom lip. ‘Why is that absurd?’

‘Because I’m eighty-one. And you’re . . . how old?’

‘Seven.’

‘How many seven-year-olds do you know who are friends with eighty-one-year-olds?’

‘It’s not ideal,’ she agrees, after a moment’s consideration. ‘But beggars can’t be choosers.’

I feel a rare moment of pity for the child. ‘You’re not a beggar, child.’

She laughs. ‘I know that. *You’re* the beggar. I’m the chooser. Because I choose you!’

It’s irritating to notice somewhere behind my exasperation, a part of me is affected by this. *I choose you*. It’s hard to imagine a nicer thing to say to a person, especially when you’re not the sort of person people tend to choose. And yet here she is. This loud, bossy, sticky-fingered child declaring, without hesitation, that I’m the one she wants. As if I’m some grand prize and not just the only adult left upright on the street.

Persephone offers me a winning smile, knowing she’s got me. ‘What do you say? Uno or Snap? What do you say, bestie?’

Mother of God.

12

I've been trying to ditch Persephone for an hour when I notice a man loitering in the mouth of Kenny Lane. There's a sense of menace about him, which is oddly exciting. He's dressed in jeans and a black bomber jacket – too well dressed to be homeless or a council worker. Thirty-odd, luscious dark brown hair, slicked. Black jeans, hands in pockets. An Italian Stallion. He's wearing sunglasses despite the overcast day. I wonder if the fact that he looks suspicious to me is my confirmation bias at work. I've been told the human brain is magnificent at making you see things that aren't there when you feel unsafe, and yet it feels as though this chap has wandered out of central casting, having auditioned for the role of 'shady character'.

It has to be said, Kenny Lane isn't a lovely suburban street. In recent years it has gained an appeal from trendy young folk who like the inner-city location and who have been forced to give up the dream of large backyards, butler's pantries and walk-in wardrobes due to the cost-of-living crisis, but in its heyday, it was considered a dive. Due to its proximity to a police station, several nightclubs and a highly suspect massage parlour, we get our share of unsavoury folks. I don't mind it – I quite enjoy the people-watching – but it's not uncommon to hear the blare of the police siren as it screams around the corner or the raised voices of newly aggressive men picking fights after too many beers. It's part and parcel of where I live, and normally I accept it with the good humour of an elderly woman who hasn't enough money to move anywhere else. But ever since I discovered that Joan – and possibly others – know who I am, I feel . . . less good-humoured about it.

I look around and find Persephone gone. Excellent news, obviously, though irritatingly, without her iridescent hula hoop. I sigh and remove it

from my rosebushes as the Italian Stallion starts down the laneway.

He pauses at Roxanne's place. Her porch is an exact replica of my own, and of the houses either side of it, if a little shabbier on account of it being a rental. Out of the corner of my eye I see movement on Roxanne's porch.

Persephone. She's half hidden behind a sad-looking yucca in a terracotta pot. Her face is scrunched up as though she's trying to make herself smaller.

I walk out into the lane.

'Can I help you?'

The man glances over at me. As he does, Persephone creeps across her porch and lets herself in the front door. She closes it behind her.

'Actually, yes,' the man says. 'Does Roxanne live on this street?'

'Roxanne?' I cock my head, peer to the heavens. 'No. No Roxannes. We did have a Suzanne once, but she didn't last long and that was over twenty years ago. Now we have Joan – she's in her mid-sixties. Peter – late sixties.' I point in his direction. Peter, playing Tavli on his porch, looks over at us. 'The Nguyens over there. Ishaan – he's dead. And,' I point to Roxanne's house, 'a bunch of university students live in that one. I'm not sure of all their names, to be honest.'

I see from his expression that he doesn't quite trust me. 'Oh. I was sure she lived here. She's a young woman. Has a little daughter around six years old.'

Now I shake my head more confidently.

'No children on this street. Believe me, I'd have noticed that.'

A whisper of a smile comes to his lips.

A curtain twitches at Roxanne's house. That's when I notice Persephone's round face tucked in the bottom corner of her front window, watching.

'Everything all right, Else?' Peter shouts from his porch. He regards the Stallion.

'Everything's fine,' I say.

But he goes and gets to his feet. The Stallion turns to face him. 'You live here?'

'I certainly do.'

‘Do you know Roxanne?’

Peter opens his mouth, ready to sing like a canary. He even turns to look at her house. At some point before projecting, he catches himself. His gaze touches mine.

‘Er, no. No, I don’t.’

Unfortunately he caught himself too late.

The Stallion smiles. ‘That one, is it? Thanks, Pops.’

Peter walks into the laneway and I feel a twinge of worry. I can practically see the adrenaline building under his skin until he sees the size disparity between him and the Stallion. Peter is fit and on the tall side, but he’s also an elderly man. The Italian Stallion, on the other hand, is reminiscent of Russell Crowe in his *Gladiator* days.

Some of the heat goes out of Peter’s voice.

‘I hope you’re not here to cause any trouble. This is a quiet street, but a very well-located one. The cops are right around the corner, they can be here in thirty seconds. Shall I call them?’

Peter keeps a straight face, bless him. While it’s true that the cops are around the corner, the last time someone from Kenny Lane called – the Nguyens after an aggravated break-in – they didn’t arrive for hours. In fact, they only showed their faces after Peter walked down there and threatened to call *A Current Affair* and say that the police were disregarding the safety and wellbeing of elderly citizens.

The man opens his mouth just as Joan powers into the street in her orthotic footwear, back from her walk. A younger man – perhaps the nephew – is by her side. The Stallion notices them, but it’s hard to tell if it’s their arrival or the threat of the cops that sparks his departure.

‘Tell Roxanne that Shane is looking for her,’ he says.

Peter and I follow him out of the street, several steps back, and look both ways to make sure he’s gone. Only when I’m sure he is do I glance toward Roxanne’s front window. Persephone’s face is gone.

13

The next morning is quiet. Peaceful. I'm reading the newspaper. Daphne is padding about the house in her lime-green slippers, humming something tuneless. The air smells faintly of crumpets and honey. It would have been close to perfect if Nugget – the freeloading menace – hadn't taken up residence next to my feet. Honest to God, if Ishaan wasn't already dead, I'd murder him for bequeathing me that snarling footstool. She growls at me whenever I so much as adjust my blanket.

Daphne has just put the kettle on and I'm eyeing a second crumpet when the doorbell rings. Nugget lets out a low, suspicious growl. I glance at Daphne, whose eyebrows shoot up with barely contained glee. For pity's sake. It doesn't take much to excite that woman – yesterday she practically hyperventilated over a catalogue from Spotlight. But I'll admit, when I open the door, I feel it too. That little jolt. Because standing there on my porch are the policemen. Baldy and Hairy.

'Praise Jesus! You're here for the dog.'

Beside me, Nugget whines, as if she's understood. Daphne appears in the corridor behind us, resplendent today in a rainbow crocheted cardigan and lime-green slacks.

'Actually, no,' Hairy says. He doesn't even seem apologetic. 'Not about the dog. We're here about –'

'Oh!' I say. 'The Italian Stallion?'

A pause. 'The what?'

'Shifty type, hanging around the street? Asking about who lives here?'

'Likely a perve,' Daphne adds. 'You should send a squad car.'

Hairy and Baldy exchange a look. 'Can we come inside?'

'Of course!' Daphne says.

'You don't mind if Daphne stays, do you?' I ask.

Baldy reaches down to pat Nugget's head. 'Not in the least.'

I stand back from the door and the policemen come inside. Daphne walks ahead of us and gets mugs out of the cupboard, as if the church ladies have arrived for morning tea. Nugget remains right under my feet. It occurs to me, not for the first time, that she's being guided by Ishaan from beyond the grave, his mission to ensure I have a nasty fall.

'Tea?' I offer.

'Sure,' says Baldy.

'We have English Breakfast,' Daphne says eagerly, 'or peppermint. I like Lady Grey, personally.'

When Baldy doesn't reply, I raise my eyebrows.

'Oh . . . uh, white with one, please.'

'Nothing for me,' says Hairy.

I direct them to my round table and they take a seat while Daphne and I make the tea.

'White with one,' I say, putting a mug in front of Baldy. I sit at the third chair of the table, Daphne sits at the fourth. Nugget, the presumptuous little ferret, sits on her lap. 'What can I do for you?'

'Firstly,' Hairy says, 'I'm sorry for your loss.'

It takes me a moment to realise they're talking about Ishaan. 'Oh, Ishaan isn't a loss. The contrary, to be honest. It's my gain. I disliked him intensely.'

'Elsie,' Daphne says in a warning voice.

'I did. He was a miserable old bastard. Always had been. But after his partner, Jim, died, he got that awful dog and our relationship declined from there.'

Baldy's eyebrows – which are cruelly thick and full – rise. 'How did the relationship decline?'

'How do you think? The man had no business having an animal. He could barely take care of himself. Nugget barked from dawn to dusk, disrupting the neighbourhood. And because Ishaan was too old to walk her, he just opened the door and let her terrorise the street! Can you imagine? She was always crapping in my front garden. Near the roses! I'm not a

fancy woman, but I am proud of my roses and I can do without stepping on dog turds while I'm pruning.'

'You're a twit of a woman,' Daphne says under her breath. I ignore her. I'm quite enjoying my little trip down memory lane.

'So you and Ishaan would . . . argue?' Hairy says, sitting forward.

'If by "argue" you mean throwing faeces back and forth over the fence, yes.'

'You threw faeces . . .'

'The dog's faeces, obviously,' I explain. 'It was in a poop bag, I'm not an animal. Whenever I came across one of her turds, I lobbed it over the fence at Ishaan. That's not a crime, is it?'

I get the sense from the way the policemen look at each other that they aren't sure. For pity's sake.

'So Ishaan was your nemesis?' Hairy says slowly. 'And yet, you were the one who went in search of him? Why was that?'

'I was trying to get out of being interviewed by the precocious child across the road! She's a monster, really and truly. She wanted to speak to someone old. Ishaan doesn't have a lot on me, but when it comes to age, he pips me.' I hesitate. 'Well. He did.'

They are quiet for a moment, then Hairy says: 'Is it true, Ms Fitzpatrick, that you threatened to kill Ishaan prior to his death?'

'I most certainly did not,' I say, appalled. 'Who told you that?'

'I'd have to check my notes.'

'Do that,' I say, indignant. 'Anyone who knows me knows that if I was going to kill him, I'd never forewarn him.'

Not so much as a smirk.

'What do you think happened to Ishaan, Ms Fitzpatrick?' Baldy says, adopting a patronising, kindly voice.

It feels like a remarkably ridiculous question. 'I think he got dicked by the dangling dong of destiny, that's what I think.'

Baldy and Hairy blink at me. I'm vaguely reminded of Tweedledee and Tweedledum. Daphne laughs so hard a little fart slips out.

‘I mean, I think his time was up,’ I say. ‘He was ninety-three years old, gentlemen.’

Baldy lets out a long sigh. Hairy sits back in his chair.

‘Constables,’ I say, ‘I understand that you need to dot your i’s and cross your t’s, but is this going to take long? Daphne and I have dinner plans.’

I avoid Daphne’s gaze. We never go out of an evening.

‘I think that’s all we need for today,’ Baldy says.

I nod, trying not to overthink the ‘for today’ part.

‘Oh, one more thing,’ Hairy says as they stand. ‘We’ll need your shoe.’

‘My shoe?’

‘What on earth do you need her shoe for?’ Daphne cries.

‘You were wearing it when you found Ishaan, correct?’

‘Of course. Both of them.’

‘I’m told there was some blood on one of your shoes. Given the blood, it’s considered evidence,’ he continues, dragging what looks like a plastic ziplock bag from his satchel.

‘The blood was from a scratch on my leg, for pity’s sake!’

I look down at my shoes. It had only been a drop or two and it was now almost imperceptible against the navy canvas, at least with my eyesight.

‘Still,’ Baldy says. ‘We need to take it.’

‘Will I get it back?’ I ask.

‘They’re a nice pair of shoes!’ Daphne adds. ‘Homypeds are they, Else?’

‘They’re my favourites. Got them in the Boxing Day sales at Harris Scarfe,’ I say. ‘Wear them every day.’

Again, the police do not look apologetic. Clearly neither of them has suffered through the Boxing Day sales.

‘Well,’ I say, sitting on the chair, ‘you may as well take them both. Not a lot of use to me without the other.’

I reach toward my shoe, to remove it, but Hairy intercepts me. ‘Allow me,’ he says, and then puts on gloves. Despite my insistence he take both, he only takes the right and drops it into the bag. The indignity of sitting

there while he does it is nearly as bad as then leading them back down my hallway, wearing one shoe only.

'I did wonder,' Baldy says, the moment before I open the door, 'what had become of you. I think most people expected you would have started a new life. I never would have thought you'd still be right here in Melbourne.'

With Nugget at my heels, my hand freezes, halfway to the door.

'I suppose you did change your name,' Hairy says. 'Then again, you couldn't just go around calling yourself Mad Mabel, could you?'

They chuckle. When I don't join them, their smiles fade away. 'For the record, I never went around calling myself that,' I say.

They blink, glance around. 'Yes. Right. Fair enough. We better go then.' Suddenly they are in a hurry to leave. 'Bye, Ms Fitzpatrick. Bye, Daphne.'

Once again, they leave without the dog.

14

THEN

Lord Mayor's Camp was a summer camp a couple of hours out of Melbourne, designated for disadvantaged children. The irony that my parents secured me a spot with a hefty donation appeared to be entirely lost on them.

The camp itself was a relic – faded bunting, peeling signage, and that unmistakable scent of sun-warmed lino and damp towels. My parents had a holiday home perched on a nearby cliff, close enough to smell the sausages the camp leaders barbecued at lunchtime. The idea that I might return there each night clearly hadn't occurred to them – or if it had, it had been swiftly and unapologetically rejected.

'You're fourteen years old,' Dad had said, on the way down. 'I had a job by the time I was fourteen.' His words felt like a lecture from the pages of a men's magazine, full of hard-nosed advice on building character.

'You'll have more fun with other kids around,' my mother had said, in a kinder voice. Her voice was warmer, but there was a certain idealism about her, as if she truly believed every child needed the same dose of cheerful camaraderie, regardless of what I might think.

As I stood on the precarious ledge of the flying fox, I wondered if my mother actually believed I'd have more fun here.

'Is this safe?' I called to the counsellor below. My voice wavered, though I tried to steady it. The harness – meant for a much smaller child – pinched in odd places and buckled loosely in others. The timber platform

beneath my feet felt spongy, the kind of wood that wouldn't survive a good thunderstorm.

'You're the eighth person to take it in the last hour,' the counsellor called back, voice flat with boredom. 'Was safe enough for them.'

His tone reminded me of a teacher just counting down the hours to retirement.

As I looked down, I found myself thinking of Anne Shirley. When Josie Pye dared her to walk the ridgepole of the Barrys' kitchen roof, Anne hadn't hesitated. She'd had doubts, of course, but she lifted her chin and did it anyway.

'Come on, Big Bird,' a kid called from the ground. 'People are waiting!'

I tried to summon some of Anne's courage, even as the wind tugged at my skirt, a cheerful pastel number my mother had insisted I wear, thinking it would make me 'fit in with the other girls'.

And then I stepped off.

The harness jerked, tilted – then spun. I picked up speed at an alarming rate, swinging sideways, then upside down. My hips slid out of the loose straps and for a moment I hung from my knees, gripping wildly at the air.

I heard the collective gasp from below. My knees started to slide out of the harness.

A second before I hit the ground, I recalled Anne's fate the day she walked on the Barrys' roof. A great tumble into the garden bed.

'Oof,' I heard someone say, and then pain exploded like a bomb.

In movies, the injured person always blacks out and wakes up in the hospital, unsure where they are. I didn't black out. I didn't wake up in the hospital feeling confused. There are a few hazy patches where I might have lost consciousness for a few seconds, but on the whole, I was aware of it all. I still remember it with breathtaking clarity.

The pain was otherworldly. Untouched (or barely touched) by the narcotics they injected and dripped into me ('An adult's dose,' I heard the paramedic say, 'look at the size of her.'). It was in my arms, my

collarbones, my chest, my pelvis. How I would have welcomed blacking out of this pain!

My mother appeared at my side in the hospital, as I was lying on a stretcher, awaiting surgery. She was dressed in a pale yellow organza dress with a full skirt, delicate white gloves, and a matching hat perched on her carefully set hair. She must have come straight from a garden party.

She looked more distressed than I felt. 'I'm sorry, darling,' she said. 'I'm so, so sorry.'

It felt like such an odd thing to say. It wasn't as if she'd built the flying fox or forced me into the ill-fitting harness. She gripped my hand so hard it hurt.

'What can I do?' she asked me. Her breath smelled of wine. 'How can I make it up to you?'

'Nothing,' I told her. Because the truth was, she was already doing it. Not just being there, though that might have been enough. But the way she was looking at me. As if she cared. As if she . . . loved me.

'So you're okay?'

I was in the sort of pain that makes death seem like a kind option. Surgery was minutes away. I had never been less okay. And I'll tell you something – it changes a person, this sort of pain. It changed me irrevocably. After I experienced it, I became blacker inside. Living up to my father's impression of me, perhaps: not quite right.

'Yes, Mum,' I said to her. 'I'm okay.'

'Mum?'

My left arm was broken in two places, and three ribs were cracked clean through – injuries that required two surgeries and enough metal hardware to set off airport alarms for life. Mercifully, I was knocked out cold for all of it.

When I finally came to, I was in the ward, stitched and bandaged, floating somewhere between pain and morphine. My mother was sitting

beside the bed. At first, I felt a warm, blurry kind of relief – until I noticed she was crying.

My mother sniffed, shaking her head. ‘Hello, darling.’ She retrieved a tissue from her sleeve and wiped her nose.

‘Why are you crying?’ I asked.

‘It’s nothing, darling,’ she said in that tone of voice that meant something entirely different. ‘I’m just glad you’re okay. I don’t know what I would have done if . . . if I’d lost you.’

She crumpled under another round of tears. I watched her closely, understanding somehow that these tears weren’t for me.

‘Are you thinking about Kitty?’

It was out of the blue and it wasn’t. I’d thought about that name from time to time, ever since I’d first heard my father utter it – and more since I’d heard Cess say it. But I wasn’t fixated on her. I think I had a sense that one day, I would find out more, and this felt like that day.

Mum broke out of her tear-filled trance and stared at me. ‘Mabel . . . you know about Kitty?’

I didn’t know about Kitty, of course. But one could make assumptions, and I felt more sure than ever that my parents had had another child at some point.

‘I’ve . . . heard some things.’

‘Okay. Well . . . I’m sorry about that. We didn’t think you remembered her. And it’s not the kind of thing you want to remind a child of.’

‘What isn’t?’

Mum exhaled as if she were blowing out a candle. ‘Kitty – Katharine – was your sister.’

My sister. It felt impossible – and yet oddly familiar, like something I’d always known. Even while hearing of her for the first time, little memories rose unbidden: a cream knitted blanket in my mother’s arms; the whisper of baby hair (blond, not red) against my cheek; chubby wrists screwed on like doll parts; a single, razor-sharp bottom tooth. ‘What . . .’ I started, before having to clear my throat. ‘What happened to her?’

‘Poliomyelitis,’ Mum said. ‘She was only a year old. Darling child.’

I knew about polio, of course. Everyone did. Rose Keaney, down the road, had been relegated to a wheelchair because of it. Cate McDonald from three doors down had died of polio, and so had her brother Garry.

'I had polio too,' I said.

Mum nodded. 'When you were three and a half. You must have picked it up at kindergarten. It was a terrible time. It spread through contact, so everything was closed for weeks on end – public swimming pools, libraries. But trying to stop kids from playing – you might as well try to stop water from flowing downstream.'

She fished a packet of Peter Stuyvesants from her purse and lit one with a shaky flick. Her red lipstick blurred at the corners as she exhaled. She wasn't a smoker – not really. Only at parties. Usually.

'I remember walking down the street and seeing all the neighbours' kids out on their porches,' she said. 'That's what the doctors told us to do. You had to be isolated from the family, but especially from other kids.' She took a deep drag. 'So when you got sick, we set you up on the patio with some picture books and dolls. You were a good child, you never complained, just sat happily out there in your own imaginative little world. Cess or I ferried out food and water when mealtimes came around. Do you remember this?'

I gave the faintest shake, barely more than a tremor.

'Well . . . one day, I came outside and found you on your knees, playing with Kitty.'

A nurse appeared in the doorway, hesitated at the sight of Mum, then quietly retreated. Mum took another slow drag, unfazed.

'How did she get out there?' I asked.

Mum turned her head and blew smoke over her shoulder, then gave a small, helpless shrug. 'We'd locked the door, so we don't know how she got out.' Her eyes fixed on a point beyond me – distant, unblinking. For a moment, she looked like she might say more. Instead, she gave her head a slow shake, like trying to clear a fog. 'Anyway . . . she caught polio. It got into her brain and spinal cord. By that night, she was paralysed. She died within the week. And you made a complete recovery.'

‘But why? Why did I recover, and she died . . . if she caught it from me?’

‘That was the thing about polio,’ Mum said, stubbing out her cigarette with slow, deliberate pressure. ‘No one knew why one child recovered and another didn’t. Maybe she was younger. Smaller. Who knows?’

She rose and walked to the window. I sat with the weight of it, trying to piece it together. As heartbreaking as it was, the story wasn’t unfamiliar. It was the 1950s – everyone knew someone who’d died or been left crippled by polio.

‘But . . . why didn’t you tell me?’

Mum glanced back at me, just for a second, then turned away again. Her eyes found something far off, something safer than my face. ‘You were so young. A year or so after she died, you seemed to forget she existed. I didn’t see the point of forcing you to remember.’

The words of the woman at the dinner party – Susan – floated back into my mind – woven into the clink of glassware, the polite murmur of guests, the scrape of dishes – when she’d said, *I expect you regret what happened to Kitty*.

‘What did I do?’

Mum glanced at me. ‘Pardon?’

‘A woman said to me once . . . “I expect you regret what happened to Kitty.” What did I do?’

Mum looked away. She was quiet for long enough that I thought she wasn’t going to answer. As I was about to repeat the question, she spoke. ‘As I said, the door was locked. Dad says he heard you calling her. He believes you unlocked the door.’ Mum walked away from the window and to my bedside. ‘Perhaps you did call her? You were three and it wouldn’t have been criminal for you to want a playmate.’

There’s a slightly pleading tone to Mum’s voice. As if she’s trying to make herself believe it.

‘He blames me?’

‘It’s the grief talking. He was besotted with Kitty.’

(All these years later, that comment still cuts hard.)

‘We told him you couldn’t possibly have unlocked the door from the outside. Even if you’d been tall enough to reach, you didn’t have a key!’ my mother continued. ‘But he thinks you were jealous of her.’

I took in this new piece of information. ‘Wait . . . he thinks I unlocked the door because I wanted Kitty to get sick?’

Mum lifted her hands, and then let them fall back to her sides: a non-answer. I stared at her in disbelief. ‘Do you think I wanted her to get sick?’

She shook her head. Then a moment later, she said: ‘You didn’t, did you?’

‘No!’ I said. ‘Of course not.’

Mum looked relieved, even though she must have known that I didn’t remember. For all I knew I did unlock the door. Maybe I was jealous. Maybe I even wanted her to die.

15

My hospital room had mint-green walls, pink plaid curtains, and an ever-present scent of boiled cabbage. I was lucky enough to have a private ‘balcony’, which was, in fact, just a fire escape with rusting railings and a single potted fern that had long since given up on life. Most of the time, I stared out the hospital window, counting the minutes as they crawled by.

It was scalp-itchingly boring. No radio, no magazines. My parents had paid for a private room, which offered a lovely view of the park opposite. A kindly nurse with thick nylons and a crisp, starched uniform pushed my bed right up to the window so I could watch the tram lines crisscross the streets below. If I was propped up, I could see mothers pushing their prams through the park, and the odd man in a fedora, tilted just so, as he read the newspaper in the sun.

Occasionally there was a school group playing sport in the park, which was slightly more interesting even if it did make me ache with loneliness even more than I already did. It felt like a reminder that I’d been removed from society, even more so than I usually was. It felt a lot like being strangled, very gently.

My mother came to the hospital every morning, dressed immaculately in a perfectly pressed dress or suit, gloves and all, as though she were attending Mass or a ladies’ luncheon. She always brought her hip flask and a packet of Peter Stuyvesant Lights, which she now smoked constantly at my bedside. Cess and Ness came every few days, dressed far more casually, and holding bags of books from the library or cellophane-wrapped mixed lollies. They also brought my diary, which I wrote in daily. My father didn’t visit at all. I didn’t want him to, obviously, but I also hated him for it. It was funny how that worked. Just as illogical as love, I supposed.

Mum and I didn't talk about Kitty again, but I suspect that Mum thought of her often, as I did. The fact that she not only existed, but that my father believed she'd died at my hand was hard to come to terms with, even if it explained a lot. Was this why my father hated me? Did he have reason to? Was I, as he'd said to Susan at the dinner party, not quite right? Was I mad?

In the end, all I could do was read to take my mind off the endless cycle of questions. Despite the vast selection of books Ness had brought, nothing comforted me as much as reading *Anne of Green Gables*. It was between its pages that I first stumbled across the phrase 'bosom friend'. It made me think of Cess and Ness's friendship – the way they knew and loved each other so fully. I'd never desired such a friend more than as I lay prone in the hospital, day after day.

It was the part of the book where Anne was living with Mrs Thomas and her drunken husband that I kept coming back to. It was during this time that Anne had felt so lonely that she used to imagine her reflection in the glass door of the bookcase was a girl called Katie Maurice. Never had I seen my own loneliness articulated and reflected back like that.

One evening, I found myself putting my hand on my reflection in the hospital window.

'Katie?'

Katie, of course, didn't reply. I should have known that even imaginary friends would be out of my grasp.

I removed my hand from the window.

I was going to find a bosom friend, I decided then and there. It wasn't going to be easy, but it hadn't been easy for Anne either. In the end, Anne found Diana Barry. And I was going to find my bosom friend too.

About a week into my hospital stay, I woke one morning to find Mum at my bedside. I could smell cigarettes before I even opened my eyes – and port, mingling with the stale scent of Chanel No. 5.

'Hi, Mum,' I said.

Her gaze was out the window, softly unfocused, and she startled at the sound of my voice. She was still wearing the navy polka-dot dress from the day before, its stiff taffeta skirt slightly crumpled, her stockings laddered at the knee.

'Oh. Hi, darling.'

'What's wrong?'

She looked surprised at the question, which baffled me. My mother wore her emotions on the outside for all to see – in the way she turned her head, in the straightness of her spine, and, of course, in the strength of the alcohol she was drinking.

'Nothing's wrong.' She forced a smile, then lit a cigarette, inhaled deeply. 'But I can't stay long. Your father's going away tomorrow. I need to finish packing his things.'

Ah. So that's why she was upset. My father had always travelled for work, but until recently, he'd always taken Mum with him. She loved to travel. Our house was littered with photographs of them on cruise ships, in first-class train compartments, and posing in front of iconic statues and buildings. But recently, my father had been taking trips alone.

'Where is he going?'

She exhaled smoke. 'London.'

'Oh.' I understood that she was upset, but it could've been worse. Mum had been to London lots of times. He could have been going to Paris. Mum loved Paris.

'He's not going alone, Mabel.'

I frowned, trying to catch up. *Not alone?* 'Who is he going with?'

'Susan McGinty.'

She said it lightly, casually, as if she were testing it out. But her lips stiffened around Susan's name.

'Susan McGinty,' I repeated. It felt familiar, but I couldn't quite place it. Then suddenly, I did. Susan McGinty was the woman from the party. The one who'd talked about Kitty.

Mum's gaze snapped to me. 'Yes. Do you know her?'

I thought of the noises in the hallway. The platinum-blond hair. The creamy-white legs. My father's socks.

'I think I met her once, at a party at Rosehill.'

'Oh.'

'Why is she going on a business trip with Dad?'

She stood and walked to the window. 'I'm not sure. I found their shipping tickets for the P&O Liner in his bag. I'll ask him when he's home from work. There's sure to be a reason.'

Mum inhaled deeply on her cigarette. I watched the delicate bones of her neck move gently and wondered what kind of reason would satisfy her. Did it even need to be true? Or did it merely have to be plausible enough to allow her to maintain the status quo of the deeply unhappy life she lived with my father?

'I saw them,' I said, a spur-of-the-moment decision. 'Dad and Susan. I saw them together.'

Mum looked at me. Her gaze was somehow unfocused and intense all at once. 'What?'

'In the hallway at Rosehill. It was during a party. They were upstairs, near my bedroom.'

Mum's hand, pale and shaking, reached for the windowsill and missed, brushing empty air. 'What were they doing?'

I tried to find words for what they were doing while Mum butted the cigarette out in the ashtray.

'They . . . her legs were kind of . . .' I tried to move my legs to show her. '. . . and Dad was standing up, lifting her . . . and they were grunting.'

I was still deep in thought, trying to find the right words to explain what I'd seen, so I didn't see Mum move until it was too late. Her open palm struck my cheek and nose – clumsy, but hard. Hard enough to make me taste blood. The shock of it stole my breath.

'You vile girl. Why would you say such a thing? What is the matter with you?'

She leaned in, forehead nearly touching mine. Her breath was hot, her body trembling. Her eyes were no longer Mum's – they belonged to

something wild, something cornered. She appeared to be waiting for an answer to her question. What was the matter with me?

It was a good question. Certainly there was something. Something very wrong. She felt it, and in that moment, I felt it too.

Mum stood abruptly, standing and moving with such purpose that I thought she was leaving. But instead of walking out of the room, she strode toward the balcony and flung open the door.

I sat upright, tossing my legs over the side of the bed.

'Mum,' I called after her, then petered out because she was moving so fast. Too fast. She didn't so much as pause or glance back over her shoulder. She simply launched over the balcony railing and disappeared without a sound.

16

NOW

Daphne and I take the bus to Harris Scarfe and I buy a new pair of Homypeds. Burgundy, as per Daphne's insistence. Better to hide the blood, she says mischievously, and I laugh, but I have to say, I prefer the navy.

The trip to the shops wipes me out. There, I've said it. I don't like admitting this sort of thing – not even to myself. I've never minded getting old, not really. Helps when you never had much beauty to lose in the first place. But this part – this business of needing a lie-down after buying a pair of shoes – this bothers me.

I should be able to catch the bus to Westfield, pick out something vaguely orthopaedic, and return home without feeling like I've run the Melbourne bloody Marathon. But here we are.

Daphne and I both collapse into our respective caves, and I don't stir until morning. When I do, Persephone is at my door, rapping like a debt collector. By the time I've ascertained it's her, she's muscled her way in far enough that I can't close the door without causing her a semi-serious injury.

'I'm hungry,' she announces.

'Does this look like McDonald's?'

I try again to shut the door, but she pushes past me and charges down the hallway. 'Mum says I can't have McDonald's,' she calls over her shoulder. 'What have you got?'

The audacity.

I glance out into the laneway for her mother, but of course she's nowhere to be seen. For pity's . . . no.

By the time I make it into the kitchen, she's biting into a Granny Smith.

'I prefer Pink Lady apples,' she says, observing the apple as if it's committed an egregious sin, then immediately takes another large bite. 'Why are you still in your robe? I thought grannies got up early.'

I glance at the clock, wondering when it became my job to feed this intrusion breakfast.

'Got anything baked?' She's still chewing – apple juice glistening on her lips.

'Nope. Nothing baked.'

She opens my fridge and peers inside, undaunted. 'I thought grannies always baked. Muffins and cakes and scones. I'm not a fan of scones though, so don't bake them.'

'I won't.' I flick on the kettle and drop a coffee bag into a mug.

'You could bake an apple pie!' Persephone's eyes widen. 'Apple pies are my favourite. Mmm-mmm dee-licious.'

I lean against the counter and cross my arms, aiming for stern and unwelcoming – though judging by her complete lack of concern, I might as well have thrown on a party hat. 'Won't your mother be looking for you?'

'She's sleeping.'

Sleeping! For pity's sake. 'What time does school start?'

'Eight-thirty,' she says, opening the pantry.

I glance at the clock again. It's creeping up on twenty past. Roxanne and Persephone don't have a car, and the walk would be fifteen minutes at least. Back in my day we were reprimanded for tardiness, but from what I hear, schools don't reprimand. Nowadays they like to *encourage children*. Everyone gets a medal for existing.

I'm about to suggest she run along and wake up her mother when she wheels around. 'Elsa – there's no baked goods here! Just arrowroot biscuits.' Despite her accusatory tone, she grips the packet of biscuits in her chubby little hand.

‘Forgive me,’ I say dryly. ‘I didn’t realise I’d be entertaining royalty for breakfast.’

‘That’s true,’ she says, more conciliatory now. ‘Fine. I forgive you.’ She tosses the apple core into the *sink*, and shoves the arrowroots deep into her pocket. ‘Right then . . . I better get to school. How about afternoon tea? I like banana bread.’

She doesn’t wait for a response, just takes off down the hallway.

The hide! I imagine the faces of Mrs Harris, or Mrs Casey, who lived on my cul-de-sac when I was growing up, if I showed up uninvited and demanded banana bread. The child really does think she’s royalty!

And yet, I do have four bananas in the fruit bowl, all starting to turn.

I’m rummaging through the pantry for brown sugar when I realise I haven’t heard the screen door slam shut. What’s that little devil up to now?

I sigh – loudly, for my own benefit – and start the slow trudge down the hallway.

Persephone is standing in the doorway to my second bedroom, peering inside.

‘Elsa,’ she says cautiously, ‘why do you have –?’

‘Get out of there. This instant.’

My voice comes out sharp – too sharp, louder than I meant. I can feel my heart hammering. That room. Of all rooms.

Persephone turns, startled, cheeks flushing. ‘But –’

‘But nothing.’ I hurry forward, faster than I have in days, and gently – but firmly – guide her out of the doorway. I shut the bedroom door behind me with a snap.

‘You don’t go snooping through people’s homes like that,’ I say, breath tight. ‘It’s incredibly rude.’

Persephone looks up at me, confused at first – then wounded. Her eyes fill. ‘I’m sorry.’

The sight of her, small and sorry and blinking back tears, injures something in me. I want to make it better, but I can’t. I’m too ashamed. Too sad. Funnily enough it’s that exact shame and grief she just saw in that room, boxed up and gathering dust.

In any case, even if I could have explained, I wouldn't have been fast enough. Because Persephone has already darted out the door, taking my arrowroot biscuits with her.

17

I used to be an early riser. In my younger years, my body would spring to life at 6 am like a Labrador pup at mealtime. These days, it doesn't so much spring as it negotiates. And it doesn't start negotiating until at least eight o'clock, when it shuffles into the kitchen for a cup of tea, then shuffles straight back to bed to drink it like a civilised pensioner.

But not today. Today, I'm ripped from slumber at 7:30 am by someone pounding on my front door like they're trying to sell me a Bible. After a momentary leap of fright, I settle back against the pillows. One didn't need to be Poirot to figure out who it was.

'Go away, Persephone, you irritating little despot!'

I'd slept fitfully the night before. It had been difficult to get back to sleep after an upsetting dream about Joan, Peter, Cess and Ness, and the Italian Stallion. In my dream I sat in a room with them – all of them – while they interviewed me for the tell-all: *Mad Mabel: In Her Own Words*. But then the room became a courtroom, and all of them morphed into jurors as my sentence was being handed down and I was crying out for my mother who I couldn't find anywhere.

The fist pounds against the door again and I wait for Persephone's indignant little face to appear at my window. She wouldn't see much through my sheers but she'd see enough to know I was awake. I make a mental note to tell her that waking up your *bestie* at the crack of dawn is a sure-fire way to keep you friendless. I may not be a great citizen, but I can offer her this public service.

But no face appears at the window.

'Ms Fitzpatrick?'

I sit up straight. Not what I was expecting. The voice is unusually deep, like a radio presenter on a smutty channel, which rules out Persephone. I

wonder, suddenly, if it could be the police? Perhaps someone in the neighbourhood was burgled overnight and the police are ‘canvassing the area’? If that’s the case, I’ll send them to Joan’s house. Joan is hard of hearing and unlikely to have heard anything, but she’ll welcome their visit so she can mention that her nephew is a partner in a law firm.

‘Just a minute,’ I call out, wrapping my towelling dressing-gown around my midsection. It’s full length, which means it barely covers my knees. I briefly check my reflection in the hall mirror on the way to the door and I’m delighted to find I look terrifying. My hair is sticking up at odd angles and the left side of my face has settled deep into its grooves after eight hours of sleeping on that side. Since about the age of seventy, it might be noon before my face starts to look vaguely symmetrical.

‘Adeem Anand.’ The young man on my doorstep extends his hand like a gun.

He’s younger than I expected, given the depth of his voice. By the look of him I’d say he is twenty-something. He’s stocky and prematurely balding, but well-endowed in the eyebrow area, as if two fat caterpillars have taken up residence on his forehead. There is a pretty, nondescript blond woman by his side who looks to be similarly aged.

He waits. When I don’t take his hand, his bravado falters. ‘Uh . . . this is my colleague Libby Conquest.’ He nods in her direction. ‘Are you Elsie Fitzpatrick?’

‘Why should I tell you?’

Adeem Anand glances at his counterpart. She doesn’t quite roll her eyes, but her facial expression conveys the effect.

‘Ms Fitzpatrick,’ she says, ‘Adeem and I host a YouTube channel – AdLib. Have you heard of YouTube?’

‘Of course,’ I snap.

It’s not a lie. I’ve heard of it. Couldn’t tell you how it works, or what it’s used for, but that wasn’t her question.

‘Great,’ she says. ‘Well, we have a channel on there where we dig into old crimes and we thought –’

I blame the early hour for my slowness. *Old crimes*. I try to shut the front door but Adeem blocks it with a meaty arm. ‘Ms Fitzpatrick. We’d like to cover your side of the story. *Sympathetically*.’

‘If you don’t let me shut this I’ll scream,’ I say, even though I doubt my scream has much heft to it these days. If Persephone was here I’d get her to scream for me. The little barbarian has quite the set of lungs. It occurs to me that it’s the first time I’ve wanted the child around.

‘Ads, for God’s sake, get your arm off the door.’ Libby smacks at his arm with all the energy of a frustrated older sister. Adeem releases the door, immediately contrite.

I find myself disarmed by Libby’s interruption, so although Adeem has removed his arm from the door, I don’t close it right away.

Libby takes advantage of my hesitation. ‘I apologise for Adeem, Ms Fitzpatrick.’

‘I imagine you have to do that quite a lot,’ I reply.

‘You have no idea.’

‘Hey –’ he starts, but Libby silences him with a little hand gesture, closing her palm like the conductor of an orchestra. It’s impressive. I make a mental note to try it with Persephone.

‘How did you find me?’ I ask.

Libby says: ‘We’re investigative journalists, Ms Fitzpatrick. I understand you go by your middle name, Elsie, and your mother’s maiden name, but your name is still legally Mabel Waller, so it wasn’t difficult. Yours was the second door we knocked on.’

‘I’d definitely recommend you tighten up your security and unlist your address,’ Adeem says, ‘given the new interest in your case.’

‘My . . . case?’

‘Adeem and I have spent a great deal of time studying the facts of your story. Personally I’ve always thought there was more to it than what was reported at the time. I mean, we *know* there was, considering you were never allowed to give your side. And now there’s been another death, it’s never been more important to clear your name.’

‘I’m sorry . . . ?’ They are talking too fast. Why do I need to clear my name? ‘I’m afraid I’m lost. What the dickens are you talking about?’

‘We read the article. As far as we’re concern–’

‘What article?’ My voice sounds sharper than intended.

They pause for a beat, surprised. ‘It was all over the internet yesterday. About your neighbour who died.’

It takes a second to land. Ishaan. Of course. But why was there an article about Ishaan? He keeled over, presumably from old age or heart failure – or possibly from Nugget’s attitude. It was sad, but not suspicious.

‘For pity’s sake! Why is everyone so interested in the death of an irritating old bastard who lived for ninety-three long years? I’ve seen popes farewelled with less fanfare.’

Adeem pulls a device out of his rucksack – one of those rectangular things that seem to control young people’s brains – and taps away. A moment later, he turns the screen to face me.

82-year-old convicted murderer ‘Mad’ Mabel Waller questioned over the suspicious death of ‘nemesis’ neighbour.

I stare at the headline, and for a moment, everything is still. There it is – dragged out of the dark like a corpse from a swamp. Convicted murderer. Mad Mabel. I haven’t been called that – to my face – in a very long time, but one doesn’t forget how it feels.

Now here it is again, shameless and blinking in bright typeface – distributed to the world. Or at least to my part of the world.

I grip the edge of the chair, hard. ‘I’m eighty-one,’ I whisper.

No one says anything. The only sound is Nugget growling low from her cushion like she senses the storm coming. I press my lips together. *Steady, Elsie*.

‘As YouTubers, we have a lot of freedom around how we want to do this,’ Libby says gently, ‘and we have a strong preference for uncut footage from you, so you could rest assured we wouldn’t twist your words. The reason we want to speak to you is that we think there’s a lot more to the case than people know.’

‘So,’ Adeem says, ‘will you speak with us?’

Beyond them, in the laneway, another pretty blond woman emerges from a white van bearing the logo of a television station. She joins a man holding a camera. Before he can even point the camera at me, another car pulls up outside Mrs Nguyen's house. Into her parking spot. I see the camera equipment through the back passenger window. I look back at the headline.

'What do you say?' Libby asks.

'I'm eighty-one,' I say, and I close the door quickly before anyone can stop me.

18

‘As I said to the last girly I spoke to, and the girly before that, I don’t *want* to make an appointment!’

Truly, I’ve never understood people’s fixation with in-person meetings. Under ideal circumstances, a telephone call is more than enough to convey information. And these are far from ideal circumstances.

It’s been twenty-four hours since those YouTube interlopers knocked on my door with their camera-ready teeth and cheerful accusations, and since then, my street has turned into a live set for some true crime melodrama. Reporters, strangers, people with boom mics and bad intentions – hovering, whispering, snapping photos.

I’ve always preferred to keep to myself. But now, I’m not just hiding for comfort. I’m hiding because I’m scared. Not that I’d admit it out loud. Not even to Daphne. But it’s not the first time the world has turned on me. I don’t know if I could withstand it a second time.

‘We really do prefer clients to come in –’

‘I’m eighty-one!’ I snap. ‘A crotchety, slightly confused, possibly deranged murder suspect! And you think I should what – catch the tram down and queue up like I’m getting my blood pressure checked?’

‘You tell ’em, Else,’ Daphne chimes in, pumping a fist.

She’s planted herself next to me on the sofa, close enough to hear every word and – more importantly – to keep an eye on me. She made it through the crowd this morning wearing a neon-green poncho with the hood drawn so tightly she looked like an incognito tennis ball.

‘Going undercover,’ she’d said, tapping her nose like she was MI5.

God love her. I don’t know where I’d be without her in my corner.

There’s a long sigh from the other end of the line. Then: ‘Hold, please.’

I roll my eyes so hard I nearly give myself a migraine. I can't believe this is happening. Ishaan's death was the *definition* of an expected death. Case in point: a bloody seven-year-old was the one to call it! And yet, part of me knows that nothing can be done. The court of public opinion has handed down its verdict. Again.

We'd called the police first. It seemed the sensible place to start to find out what could be done, if anything, about the gross miscarriage of justice that had been delivered in the headline of that article. We encountered a slight issue with the receptionist when we couldn't remember Hairy's or Baldy's actual names, so after being passed around from pillar to post, I ended up speaking to an idiot named Greg.

'What I want to know,' I'd said to Greg, after he'd introduced himself, 'is if the death is suspicious.'

'Sorry?' he said. 'Which death?'

'Ishaan's death. The headline in the article I read called it a suspicious death. So I want to know how you define suspicious.'

'You're inquiring about the death of Ishaan Patel?'

'Keep up, Charlie.'

'Greg.'

'It was an expression,' I said. Told you Greg was an idiot.

'Well,' Greg said, 'it is still an open investigation at this point, so I can't really say if it's suspicious.'

'And yet *someone* did say. To the media. How else would they have known that I was Ishaan's neighbour? And that he was my nemesis!'

'She's got you there,' Daphne said.

I'll admit, I was feeling rather good at that point, especially when Greg put me on hold to see what he could find out. When he returned, though, he had nothing. 'Ms Fitzpatrick, I've spoken to the detectives on this case, and they have assured me that they have not spoken to the media.'

'Then how did the media get this information?'

'I couldn't say. A member of the public may have reported something. A neighbour, perhaps?'

Joan, I realised. It was Joan. 'I'm going to kill her.'

‘Pardon?’ Greg said.

Daphne snatched the phone out of my hand. ‘Gotta go, Greg,’ she said, and ended the call.

‘Kill her later,’ she said. ‘First, we need legal advice.’

Which led us to this call.

We found the law firm, BrennanWhiteMcDonald, in the Yellow Pages. When I explained my predicament to the receptionist, she’d made her boredom patently clear through her non-verbal language – the long pauses, the sighs, the length at which she forced me to listen to their in-house ad for their own legal firm. When I am finally connected to a fourth girly, she is equally rude and disinterested until I mention my name. Or, rather, use the name Mad Mabel Waller.

‘Mad Mabel Waller,’ she repeats, her voice dripping in disbelief. In the background I can hear the thwack of her long fingernails against the plastic-coated desk. ‘*You* are Mad Mabel Waller?’

‘*Yes*.’

I sound huffy, which annoys me. There’s so little dignity in being huffy. And yet, if people don’t listen, that’s how I end up.

The fingernails cease their thwacking on the desk. ‘Just a moment.’

A few seconds later, I’m finally greeted by a fifth girly, who sounds like she is paid more than fifteen dollars per hour.

‘Good afternoon, this is Senior Partner Linda Raiti.’

‘Linda. I hope you are more helpful than the last four girlies I’ve spoken to.’

‘I’ll certainly try. I understand that you have questions around the legalities of an article written about you?’

‘That’s right.’

‘And . . . to confirm . . . I’m speaking with Mabel Waller?’

‘I go by the name Elsie Fitzpatrick nowadays. But yes, we are one and the same.’

‘So how can I help you, Ms Fitzpatrick?’

‘I want to know my legal rights. An article has been written about me that I believe is defamatory.’

‘All right. Tell me about the article.’

‘Well, I didn’t read the whole thing,’ I admit. ‘But the headline said: “Eighty-two-year-old convicted murderer Mad Mabel Waller questioned over the suspicious death of nemesis neighbour.”’

Daphne growls, newly appalled.

‘I see.’

‘Now there are media swarming all over my little street and I’m a prisoner in my own house. Are they entitled to use my name in association with this crime? Which, by the way, is not actually a crime, my neighbour died of natural causes.’

‘Well,’ she says. ‘That depends.’

‘On what?’

‘On a number of things. Which is why it’s better for you to –’

‘I don’t want to come into the office. I’m an elderly lady with mobility issues.’ Small white lie, but what does Linda know? ‘I’m happy to pay for your time if you can tell me over the phone.’

Another white lie. I’m not happy to pay, what fool would be? But of course I will if push comes to shove.

She sighs. ‘Right, well . . . my first questions would be around the accuracy of the headline. So let’s start there. Were you questioned over your neighbour’s death?’

‘I was. I was the one who found him.’

‘I see. And they called him your . . .’

‘Nemesis. That part was correct, at least.’

‘Hmm.’

‘They said I was eighty-two!’ I say. ‘I’m not. I’m eighty-one.’

Linda doesn’t reply.

‘What?’ I say, finally.

‘Given that the headline – save for your age – is accurate, you’ll have a hard time suing for defamation. We can search for other headlines, but given the notoriety of your . . . story, you’ll have a hard time suing *anyone* for defamation.’

‘Why is that?’

‘Because your story will more than likely be deemed to be in the public domain, which means it’s fair game.’

I don’t dislike Linda Raiti, even if I dislike what she is saying. She strikes me as a pragmatic and considered woman, and I admire this sort of person. It’s unfortunate, because if she’d been rude or unreasonable, I’d have had a place to focus the burning ball of emotion in my chest.

‘So I can’t sue?’

‘Strictly speaking, you can. Whether you succeed is another matter.’

‘You don’t think I’d succeed?’

‘What is she saying?’ Daphne asks. I hold my finger to my lips.

‘I’m not saying you couldn’t succeed,’ Linda replies carefully. ‘But if you decided to take this on, you’d have a pretty big fight on your hands. I imagine more than one media outlet would be involved. It would be a long fight. Given your age, it almost certainly would be a fight that outlives you.’

I open my mouth, but my response gets stuck in my throat. Daphne’s hand grips the hand not holding the phone and squeezes it.

‘Ms Fitzpatrick?’ Linda says gently.

I clear my throat. ‘Mmm?’

‘I’m sorry I don’t have better news for you.’

I clear my throat again. ‘Not to worry. Right then. How much do I owe you for your time?’

‘Nothing,’ she says.

‘Nonsense. I understand how it is, billable hours and all of that.’

‘I’ll write this up as a coffee break.’

I nod silently. Daphne’s thumb strokes the inner part of my wrist.

‘I . . .’ *appreciate it*, I want to say. But the words don’t project. A silent tear slips down my cheek. It strikes me that, with all the cruelties in this world, there is still nothing quite as dangerous as kindness.

‘All the best, Ms Fitzpatrick.’

‘Thank you,’ I manage.

Daphne takes the phone and ends the call.

‘Are we fucked?’ she asks, handing me a handkerchief.

‘Yep.’ I blow my nose like a foghorn. ‘We’re totally fucked.’

19

It isn't the way I expected to spend the afternoon. A camera is balanced on a tripod on my little round table and the room is full of nervous, expectant energy. My home hasn't held a lot of guests in the almost sixty years I've lived here. I imagine the walls and windowpanes and ceilings feel as uneasy as the three of us.

It's lineball to tell who is the most uncomfortable out of me, Libby and Adeem as we sit at my little round table, though I'd probably put my money on Adeem because his pale blue shirt is ill-fitting and pulled taut across his stomach, and the blind pimple on his nose is stretched so tight that the light is bouncing off it and making it glow.

'So,' Libby says. 'What made you decide to speak with us?'

She's a pretty little thing. Round moon face, masses of blond hair secured haphazardly on the top of her head with a green claw clip. Sandals. Jeans. An oversized men's business shirt. She lifts her cup of tea to her mouth and blows on it. I'd raised an eyebrow when she requested chamomile – because who on earth stocked that sort of nonsense? – but then I stumbled across an individually wrapped tea bag in the back of my tea drawer that I think came out of a free goody bag from the 'aging actively' festival at the library a few years ago. Its discovery filled Adeem with a false sense of optimism because he went ahead and asked for green tea. *Green tea!* Before I could even curl my lip and ask if he thought this was some kind of hipster tea establishment, he quickly added, 'Or whatever you have is fine.'

It has to be said, the pair look too young to be drinking tea. One of the (many) confronting things about being elderly is that to me, everyone looks like a kindergartener. There's something sweet about it when dealing with a cashier or tradesperson, but disconcerting when it is your surgeon and they

are about to remove your gallbladder. Had I been having my gallbladder removed today, I'm not certain I would have selected Libby and Adeem for the job, but for this particular role their youth makes them feel less threatening somehow. More earnest about capturing the truth rather than jaded into 'getting ratings' or however they measure it on YouTube.

'This is the first time you've spoken publicly to anyone,' Libby prompts gently, when I don't answer. 'Why now?'

It's a fair question. After my call with Linda Raiti, I'd spent twenty-four hours weighing my options – what few remained. Linda had been frank: legal action was unlikely to achieve much, certainly not the thing I needed most – getting the media circus off my bloody lawn. So, I did the only thing I had left. I opened my mouth and hoped the beast might lose interest once it had been fed.

'There was never any point talking about it before. What was done was done.'

'And now?' Adeem asks.

'Now I just want peace,' I say. 'Even if I have to earn it the hard way.'

'You thought if you gave it something, it might finally leave you alone?'

'Yes,' I say. 'I suppose so.'

Daphne had opted not to stay for the interview. That surprised me – and, in truth, unnerved me, even though deep down I knew this wasn't her story to tell. She was part of it, yes. But the mess? The history? The consequences? That was mine.

'Well, I sincerely hope it has that effect,' Libby says. 'Last question before we start recording. Why us? I'm sure plenty of people were clamouring to talk to you.'

They were. Over the past few days, I'd had emails from respected journalists offering generous sums, podcasters flaunting their download numbers like poker chips, even one who claimed their last series got an innocent man out of prison. I'd heard from a famous Australian author who'd built her reputation on solving cold cases – her latest was that fifty-year-old kidnapping of Ida McCabe, now reopened thanks to her keen investigative nose.

And I'd decided to go with Libby and Adeem, who look too young to be drinking tea.

'I thought you two would be easier to manipulate than those big film networks.'

'Full disclosure,' Libby says, 'we can only be manipulated for large amounts of cash.'

'No problem. I'll give you the coordinates of my treasure and you can dig it up after the interview.' I lean forward and lower my voice. 'It's buried with the bodies.'

The pair exchange a look, and I find that I'm smiling. I stop before they notice.

'Right,' Libby says, putting her tea on the table. 'Now that that's sorted. Any questions before we start?'

'My face will be blurred, right?' I say. 'And no details of my whereabouts will be released? The whole purpose of this is to get rid of people, not attract more of them.'

'Absolutely,' Libby says. 'And as we said, you will be shown the edited footage before it's posted, so we'll have the ability to cut anything you're not happy with then.'

I nod.

'Mostly you will be talking freestyle about your childhood. We won't interrupt unless we need something clarified. If I do interrupt, don't look at me, keep looking at the camera – okay?'

I look at the camera, which isn't, in fact, a camera at all, it's an iPhone, propped up on its tripod on my dining table. Then again, an iPhone is a camera, isn't it? An iPhone is everything. It even has a little buzzer that reminds me to take my pills.

'Okay.'

'But before we start, I'll do my lead-in. Are you ready?'

I nod again.

Libby takes a deep breath, and Adeem counts her in. When the light goes red, she morphs before my eyes into another person. A mature person. It's very impressive.

‘In 1959, at just fifteen years of age, Mabel Waller became the youngest Australian in history to be convicted of murder. The media interest around the case was enormous, due to the aggressive nature of the crime. Rumours abounded that this was not her first murder, and this has remained the topic of debate for decades. She is known around the world as Mad Mabel. But is she mad? More importantly, is she guilty?

‘In a world first, at the age of eighty-one, Mabel Waller is speaking.’

20

THEN

Two days after my mother died, my father came to the hospital.

He wore brown slacks and a red-and-blue checked shirt. His trilby hat dangled from one hand, and his jacket was draped neatly over his arm. His shoes were polished. His shirt was ironed. His expression was neutral – not quite solemn, not quite blank. Just . . . emptied out.

'Your mother,' he said, 'has passed away.'

For a moment, I thought he might be joking. Or senile. Or had wandered into the wrong hospital room. It had been two days since she went over the balcony of my seventh-floor room. Two days since the nurse with the trembling hands and watery eyes told me she hadn't made it. Two days since Cess arrived, chalk-pale and crying so hard she couldn't speak.

Now, here was my father, delivering the news as though I hadn't been there. As though I hadn't lived it.

'I'm aware,' I said.

Something flickered across his face. Barely. A twitch at the corner of his mouth. A lift of one eyebrow, so slight I wasn't sure I'd seen it. The air between us grew tight, brittle. As if the room itself disapproved of my tone.

'Are you being clever, Mabel?'

I dropped my gaze to the white knitted blanket pulled over my knees. I'd been moved to a new room – mercifully. This one had a window, but no balcony. Fewer places to fall from.

'No,' I said. Quietly.

He stepped over to the window and leaned against the sill. For a long moment, he inspected his fingernails, turning his hands under the light like a man trying to remember what dirt looked like.

Then he looked up. ‘If you know,’ he said, ‘why aren’t you more upset?’

He made no attempt to hide the accusation in his question. If anything, asking it gave him pleasure. Like he was a detective and this was the gotcha moment.

‘I am upset,’ I replied. It was true, I was. And yet I wasn’t crying. I hadn’t shed a tear in two days. It wasn’t that I wasn’t sad. To the contrary, my pain was too enormous for tears. ‘Are you?’

Hatred darkened his eyes. He pushed off the windowsill and moved to the end of my bed. ‘Who are you to ask me that?’ he roared.

His raised voice had the desired effect of intimidating me into silence, so I didn’t answer.

‘What were you two talking about, anyway, before she . . . she . . . jumped?’ he asked after several seconds.

It took me by surprise, this question. Given the calculated way he was asking, I didn’t feel inclined to answer. So I shrugged.

But he wasn’t letting it go.

‘Mabel?’ His gaze burned into me. ‘What were you talking about?’

‘I don’t remember.’

Of course I remembered. We were talking about Susan McGinty. Did he know that?

‘You’re lying. Did you argue? Did you say something to upset her?’

I examined his face for guilt, or responsibility. Neither were present.

‘Did she really jump from the balcony?’ he asked.

I shouldn’t have been shocked. I knew he’d never take responsibility for the part his relationship with Susan McGinty had played in her death. I never expected he’d attribute responsibility to me. Silly of me, since isn’t that what he’d done with Kitty?

‘Susan McGinty,’ I said quietly.

Now he was the one to look shocked. ‘Pardon?’

‘You asked what Mum and I were talking about. It was Susan McGinty.’

I didn't expect guilt, or an admission. I certainly didn't expect him to apologise for suggesting I had something to do with it. And so, I wasn't sure why I said it. Maybe, as he'd suggested earlier, I was trying to be clever.

A nurse bustled into the room, saving us both from speaking.

'How's the patient?' she said. 'Ah, Dad's here. Good.'

My father smiled and acted pleasant as the nurse did her checks, refilled my water and completed her paperwork, but I could tell she sensed something was amiss.

'Is everything okay in here?' she asked finally.

'Fine,' my father said.

She nodded, glancing at me. 'You're okay, Mabel?'

I cleared my throat. 'Fine.'

She dropped the chart into the pigeonhole at the end of the bed. 'In that case, I'll leave you to it.'

And she left.

'The funeral will be on Thursday at St Mary's,' my father said, once the nurse was gone. 'Obviously, you won't be able to attend in your condition.' He put on his trilby. 'I've had to delay my trip for it, but I'll be leaving on Friday for London. I'm not sure when I'll be back, but you'll be in safe hands with your aunt.'

He slid his arms into his jacket and, without so much as a goodbye, strode to the door.

'Who unlocked the door?'

He stopped mid-stride, but his gaze remained forward.

'To the porch?' I continued. 'Mum said the door to the porch was locked the day Kitty came outside and started playing with me. She said she didn't know how it became unlocked.'

Still he didn't look at me, but from the side view I thought he might have smiled slightly.

'Dad?' This time my voice sounded pleading. I hated myself for that. But with my mother gone, he was the only one I could get an answer from. And I needed answers.

‘Goodbye, Mabel,’ he said. And just like that, the last person who could tell me the truth walked out the door.

I didn’t consider myself to be a particularly dramatic person. To the contrary, I’d always believed myself to be calm, unflappable. And yet, that day in the hospital, after my father left, I threw my copy of *Anne of Green Gables* against the wall hard enough that it left a dent in the plaster.

‘Whoa,’ someone said.

I froze. ‘Who said that?’

‘I did.’ A girl appeared in the doorway. Like me, she was dressed in a hospital gown, but she wore a hot-pink fluffy cardigan over the top and had matching hot-pink slippers. Unlike me, she was smiling. Her skin was so pale it was almost translucent. She pulled an IV behind her, on a trolley. ‘They told me there was another kid in this ward!’

She grinned to reveal small, bucked front teeth. Her face was long and oddly narrow, like someone had pressed it between two encyclopaedias. Her hair, the colour of milky tea, floated around her ears in wisps that gave her the overall effect of a mushroom. Her eyes were a pale, watery blue.

‘I couldn’t believe it when I saw it was Mabel Waller.’

She came farther into the room, and I searched her face for recognition.

‘No way!’ I said.

‘Way.’

‘No way! Daphne Barton? The Daphne Barton from kindergarten?’

‘The one and only.’ She grinned.

‘I thought you moved back to England.’

‘You thought correct,’ she said, perching herself in the visitor’s chair beside my bed. ‘I moved back a few weeks ago. Doc said I needed the warmer weather and the sea air. For my TB.’

‘You have tuberculosis?’

She nodded with delight. ‘Top shelf case. Could barely inhale when I got here. But I’m on the mend. They say I’ll be starting school any day now. St Mary’s.’

‘You’re going to St Mary’s Brighton?’ I asked, stunned.

‘Darn tootin’. I’m boarding. Is that where you go?’

I nodded slowly, trying to keep up.

‘Talk about fate,’ Daphne said. ‘’Course, I’m not a bright spark. My dad says I’m thick as two planks. But if you can overlook that, I think we should be friends.’

I blinked at her.

‘I mean, I know you probably have about fifty friends already,’ she added quickly, ‘but I don’t. And being the new girl is rotten. So I’m relying on the kindness of a good few. What do you say?’

There were many things I wanted to say. Too many. So many that I found myself unable to speak at all.

Undeterred, Daphne ploughed on. ‘You’re probably wondering what I bring to the table. Good question. First, I’m loyal. Buried-the-body-without-asking loyal. Okay, slight fib – I’d ask, but only once the body was good and buried and we were somewhere with thick curtains. Secondly –’

My mouth twitched.

‘– I can talk my way out of anything. The key is to keep talking. Never stop. Just keep throwing words like spaghetti at a wall until they get tired and let you go.’

She wasn’t wrong. It was the same energy that had made me adore her in kindergarten. That oddball confidence. That whiff of chaos.

‘Anyway, that’s just the trailer,’ she said. ‘What do you think? Friends?’

She extended her pinkie toward me like a royal sceptre. And without meaning to, I lifted mine to meet it.

‘There. It’s done. You can’t break a pinkie swear. Not ever.’

I didn’t know that. But I liked the sound of it. So I nodded.

‘Guess we’re stuck with each other now,’ she said.

Oh, how I hoped so.

Daphne stayed the whole afternoon, parked beside my bed, chatting away like a radio show without an off switch. I’m not sure I got a full sentence in. But I didn’t mind. I’d had enough of my own thoughts to last a lifetime. Her monologue was everything I didn’t know I needed. When she

finally rolled away, I was exhausted – in the best possible way. And that night, as I drifted off to sleep in my balcony-less hospital room, the world felt a shade less grey.

I'd found my bosom friend.

21

Five days after my mother died, she rose from the dead. Like Jesus in the tomb, only it took my mother a couple of extra days.

I was being discharged from the hospital when a young nurse swept into my room, all bounce and brightness, as if the walls weren't still heavy with death. 'Your mother has arrived,' she announced with a smile.

And for a split second – I believed her.

Of course I knew it wasn't true. I'd held the knowledge of my mother's death like a burning coal for five days. But grief plays tricks, and something in me – some foolish, fragile part – looked to the doorway expecting her. Hoping.

When I saw the figure silhouetted there, my heart cracked all over again.

'Her aunt,' Cess corrected, stepping into the room with her arms folded. 'Her aunt has arrived. For pity's sake.'

Cess wore a black pencil skirt and a black shell top and black pumps. I'd never seen Cess wear so much black. 'Ready, Mabel?'

'Ready.'

I'd packed my clothes, my toiletries, my books and my journal. But I wasn't sure I was ready. My bones were set and healing, there was nothing they could do for me in the hospital that rest at home couldn't do. And Daphne had been discharged the day before, so there was nothing more for me there. And yet, as Cess signed the paperwork, took my bag, and guided me to the parking lot, I felt leaden with dread.

A Mass booklet was waiting for me on the passenger seat and a picture of my mother beamed back at me from the cover.

'I saved that for you,' Cess said. 'Not as good as your mother picking you up, I know.'

I opened my mouth to say thank you. When nothing came out, she nodded and started the ignition.

'Your father left for London this morning,' Cess said as we drove.

I nodded. I was glad he wasn't going to be there, obviously, principally because with him gone, I'd thought I could lie to myself that Mum and Dad had gone on another trip. But my father was right, as it turned out. I was a terrible liar. And with every inch closer we got to Rosehill, the less I was able to lie about where she was.

The neighbours waved uncomfortably as we pulled onto the street. Mrs Harris muttered a greeting as she came home, pushing two kids in a stroller with another one on her heels. Mr Watkins, the gardener, was weeding the front garden and he told us he'd cut some lilies – Mum's favourite – and put them in vases around the house. If he thought it was rude that neither Cess nor I responded, he didn't show it.

We walked to the front porch, and Cess opened the door and gestured for me to go in.

'Go on,' she said.

But I didn't. I wasn't entirely sure what stopped me at that particular point. Perhaps I was afraid of the house, knowing my mother wouldn't be there? Or perhaps I was waiting for her to come home?

Cess didn't push me to go inside, nor did she go in. When it was clear I wasn't entering, she moved to a patio chair and sat down. We stayed there for nearly an hour, not talking. I found myself looking around, imagining myself out there when I was a child with polio. Imagining a sister playing with me. It felt familiar yet intangible, like a movie I'd seen a long time ago, or a dream I'd had.

It was the sound of a car door closing – soft but final – that pulled me from my trance. Then came the gentle crunch of footsteps on gravel.

Ness appeared on the porch seconds later, her arms outstretched, and without a word she folded both Cess and me into her embrace. We stood there, the three of us, held together in a kind of human knot – me in the middle, the unlikely centre of something warm and aching.

It should have felt awkward. Ness was so small, barely up to our shoulders, and Cess and I were not huggers. Not with each other. Not with anyone. We were stiff-backed, self-contained women, trained from girlhood to tuck our feelings in like the corners of a hospital sheet.

But somehow, it didn't feel awkward. It felt right. And it must have felt right to Cess too, because as Ness held us, she let out a sound I'd never heard from her before – a raw, involuntary gasp, sharp as a snapped string.

That was the moment – five days after my mother fell from the seventh-floor balcony – that I finally cried for her.

Not because I wanted to. But because, at last, I could.

*

I'm not sure if Ness moved in after my mother died, but it felt like she was at our house around the clock after that. She was there when I woke in the morning, there when I went to bed.

I was glad for Ness's presence, not only because I liked Ness, but also because she filled the silence. She talked about the kind of day it was going to be – overcast, sunny, possible showers. She talked about how it might be nice to go down to the beach later and get our toes wet. She talked about how she'd seen fish on special and wouldn't it be nice to have salmon for dinner. It wasn't annoying. It felt like a lifeline.

She did other things too – opened all the windows to let in the breeze, spread bright cloths across the table like she was laying out sunshine, turned on the wireless to let a little music move through the rooms. Looking back, I sometimes think this should be a service one could gift the grieving: the quiet, steadfast presence of someone who still believes there's joy to be found – someone willing to hunt for it on your behalf. Because in those early days after my mother died, it was Ness, I am certain, who allowed me to continue to breathe.

There was one other thing that allowed Cess and me to continue breathing: our mutual hatred of my father.

'He didn't deserve Mary,' she said to Ness one morning, apropos of nothing. I was eating breakfast and she was clattering around the kitchen. 'He never did. He was always speaking to her like she was a fool, all because he was threatened by how smart she was. Any woman would turn to the booze, being married to a man like that.'

'Cess,' Ness said, tipping her head toward me.

Cess had abandoned her all-black outfit for high-waisted jeans rolled up to below the knees with a white shirt and black flats. She even wore a red scarf around her hair. But it didn't do much to brighten up her mood.

'What? You're the one always saying we don't give kids enough credit. You think she doesn't know her father is a sorry excuse for a human being?'

She looked at me. 'Mabel, you know your father is a sorry excuse for a human being, don't you?'

'I do.'

'Cess!' Ness stood up and started collecting plates. 'He's her father.'

'I hate him,' I said. 'And he hates me. Because of Kitty.'

I didn't look at them but I imagined Cess and Ness were exchanging a look. 'I didn't know you knew about Kitty,' Cess said.

'Mum told me. In the hospital.'

Cess pulled up a chair at the table and sat beside me. Ness stood behind my chair with a hand on my shoulder. 'I'm not sure what your mother told you, Mabel, but Kitty succumbed to polio, like many kids did. Your father had some odd beliefs about it but –'

'She caught it from me.'

'For heaven's sake,' Cess said. 'No one knows where she caught it. It was everywhere. Besides, you were three years old, it wasn't your responsibility to keep your sister away.'

'Whose responsibility was it?'

'I don't know.' She threw up her hands. 'No one's. Everyone's! There were plenty of us about. Your mother. Your father. Me. We all kept an eye on her, but Kitty was a busy one-year-old, crawling around, getting into

everything. I know your mother blamed herself. I blamed myself.' Cess placed a hand on my head, then ran it through my hair. 'We don't need anyone else blaming themselves. Certainly not you, darling.'

She'd never called me 'darling' before. It brought tears to my eyes.

'Why not?' I asked. 'My father blames me.'

Neither Cess nor Ness spoke for several seconds.

'Your father was very upset after Kitty died,' Cess said, after a time.

'Mum told me,' I said. 'He must have . . . really loved her.'

Cess exhaled. 'Kitty was a sweet child, a pretty little thing. She toed the line, smiled on demand. Very like your mother. She reflected back the parts of himself that he wanted to see. So yes, I think he did love her, in his way.'

When my mother was alive, she used to accuse Cess of being too brusque, too direct. *Just because something is true doesn't mean you need to say it, Cecily*, Mum would tell her. But I'd always admired Cess's directness. It meant that when she said something, I knew it was true. The flip side, of course, was that when she said something, I knew it was true.

It made the sting of this comment – that my father loved Kitty – particularly painful.

'I loved her too, Mabel, of course I did, she was my niece. But to be perfectly honest . . . she was far less interesting than you.'

I looked at her. 'What do you mean?'

'You came out, larger than life – full of questions and observations and thoughts. You were curious and intelligent and didn't suffer fools. And maybe' – she paused, as if considering something – 'maybe that was the problem?'

I wasn't following. 'What was the problem?'

'Your father has always had a preference for things that don't challenge or intimidate him. It's the same with most men, I'm afraid.' Cess looked me squarely in the eye. 'You outshone your father from the moment you were born. There are very few men who can cope with something like that.'

Cess put a matter-of-fact hand on my knee and gave it a little squeeze before she stood up. Ness handed me a tissue.

As I finished eating breakfast, I felt something loosen in my chest, the tiniest breath of forgiveness – not for my father, but for myself.

Something softened between Cess and me after that day. We were still miserable. We hardly talked. But occasionally, as Ness buzzed around us, chatting and feeding us, we exchanged a look. It was hard to explain that look, because it contained so much. Exasperation at Ness. Adoration of her. Shared grief. Of course, as a narcissistic fourteen-year-old, I couldn't quite fathom the sadness Cess appeared to be feeling. It was clear in my mind that I was the principal mourner. My mother had died. Yes, she'd lost her sister, but she had had a lifetime with her. Still, for someone who spent much of my life alone, it was nice to not be alone in my grief.

22

Though it wasn't the norm, I accepted the fact that Cess and Ness were unmarried. It didn't bother me – if anything, I would have been appalled if either of them had decided to change this status. And yet, the fact remained that people talked. I'd have had to be deaf not to hear the local chatter.

'It's a dreadful shame,' I heard a man say outside Mass one day. 'Good sorts like those two – they'd make someone a damn good wife.'

'Still could,' another one said, 'but they'd have to get cracking, those good looks won't last much longer.'

'Nah,' yet another man said. 'Dykes, both of them. Wouldn't touch a man with a barge pole.'

One day, as I scribbled in my diary while Cess and Ness ate breakfast, I decided to ask them about it.

'Why aren't you two married?'

Cess looked up from her newspaper. She was wearing a light cotton blouse tucked into her stovepipe trousers. A navy chiffon scarf was tied around her neck and knotted at the side. She was eating a bowl of cereal, and her lips opened enough that I could see the milk pooling in her mouth.

The kitchen was immaculate in the soft morning light. Mum had had it remodelled a few years ago and she'd agonised over every detail. The walls were painted a soft pastel green, with polished timber cabinetry, and the fridge was chrome and glass. Above the stove, a collection of high-end kitchen gadgets sat neatly in place. The clock on the wall ticked softly, its brass hands glinting.

'I can't speak for Ness,' Cess said. 'But for me, it's because no man so wonderful exists that it would be worth my while.'

‘Certainly not,’ Ness agreed, sipping her instant coffee. Ness was wearing a floral tea dress that was cinched at the waist with a wide belt. Her dark, wavy hair was pulled back into a neat ponytail, with a few stray curls framing her face.

‘How do you know no such man exists?’ I asked.

‘You’re a smart girl, Mabel.’ Cess noticed ink on her fingers from the newspaper and wiped them on a tea towel. ‘I shouldn’t have to explain this to you.’

‘Explain what?’

Cess sighed and sat back in her seat. But I sensed her frustration wasn’t with me. ‘That marriage is for men. They get a free housekeeper, a whore, someone to provide them with children and to rant to about their troubles of an evening. And women get . . . what? Room and board?’

‘And someone who loves you?’ I countered. ‘Someone who loves you back?’

I’d read a lot of novels, and I had to admit this part quite appealed to me.

‘Love is wonderful, and some people do find that kind of love in marriage,’ Ness said. ‘But it isn’t the only place you find love. I’d rather work at the library and pay my own way. But you might feel differently, Mabel, and that’s your choice.’

Cess scoffed. ‘In fifty years this whole marriage malarkey will have gone the way of slavery, you mark my words. A stain on our history. The world is changing, there is no way women of your generation – intelligent, educated women – will continue to agree to the terms and conditions. Am I right, Mabel?’

I nodded vigorously, and Cess smiled at me proudly. Ness shook her head, chuckling.

A sense of warmth spread across me and through the room. For a fleeting moment, I felt like I was part of something. As though I belonged.

I was sitting in the bay window of my bedroom, writing in my diary, when I saw her. I was certain my eyes were deceiving me. That, or I was still sporting some sort of concussion from my fall. Because when I looked out my window, I saw Daphne Barton circling the little cul-de-sac below on her bike.

I rubbed the windowpane with my fist, then lifted my sash window. It was raining heavily enough that it felt unlikely that anyone would be out on their bike, let alone Daphne. And yet, when I poked my head out the window, there she was.

'Hullo!' she cried out.

She was still circling on her bike, drenched through. Under her wide-brimmed school hat, her hair was plastered to her face.

'Daphne?' I called. 'Is that you?'

'Corsets it's me! Who on earth else would be riding around like a lunatic in this rain?'

She had a point there. She did look comically determined as she rode her bike round and round.

'What are you doing here?' I called.

'What are you doing up there? As if I have to ask. Reading your book, right? Writing in your diary? Staring out the window? Boring. Now come down here and let's play.'

Come down here and let's play.

The fact that it was the first time I'd been asked to play was barely dampened by the fact that with my injuries, I wasn't sure how much playing I could do. Still, I didn't waste any time hobbling downstairs.

'About time,' she said when I got outside. She screeched to a stop in front of me.

'For what?'

She tapped the handlebars of her bike. 'For an adventure! Climb aboard.'

I looked at the bike. It was green, and small enough to belong to a toddler. Admittedly, she was as tiny as I was tall. She reminded me of a jockey or a gymnast. 'You're joking.'

‘I may be small, but I be mighty.’ She grinned, revealing her small, crooked teeth. ‘I’ll dink you.’

‘You’re crackers if you think I’m getting on that bike. I have a broken arm.’

‘It’s in plaster,’ Daphne said. ‘And I’ll be careful.’

‘Mabel?’ Cess called from the house. ‘What are you doing outside?’

‘Just . . . talking to a girl from school.’

‘In the rain?’

‘I’ll be in soon,’ I called.

‘Righto,’ Daphne said. ‘Hop on. Let’s go for a ride.’

‘I’m not getting on that bike.’

‘You will.’

‘Won’t.’

‘Will.’

‘Won’t.’

‘Will!’

I couldn’t help it, I was laughing. ‘Fine. I’m getting on. Get ready to crash and burn.’

‘Not gonna happen.’

She planted her feet as I sat on the handlebars.

‘See,’ she said smugly. ‘No crashing and burning here.’

‘Your feet are still on the ground,’ I replied. ‘As are mine.’

‘Not for long,’ she said, lifting her feet and placing them on the pedals. I heard a groan and the bars tilted.

‘Hell’s bells,’ Daphne murmured, and then we both landed sideways on the road with an almighty crash.

I felt weak from laughing. More than weak, I felt faint.

The rain had stopped and Daphne and I sat on the porch in fits of giggles. Miraculously, we’d both emerged largely uninjured from our fall, though I was starting to feel a little sore. I’d even let her give it two more

tries before Daphne was able to accept that perhaps she wasn't strong enough to carry me on her bike. Of course, any fool could see this.

'All right, all right,' she'd said, hiding her amusement under an irritated expression. 'So, I'm not as mighty as I thought. But we're both fine, aren't we? You'd get worse injuries from a pillow fight, am I right, Mabel?'

It was impossible not to laugh. I felt positively giddy – not just with the euphoric post-laughter energy, but also with that indescribable sensation of being in on a joke with someone, of being part of something scandalous and fun.

'Why did you come here?' I asked her. 'And how did you know where I lived?'

'I started at St Mary's a week ago. I have to say, Mabel, I understand why you didn't reply when I asked if you had lots of friends.'

The good feeling died inside me. Had she discovered what a friendless loner I was and come on a pity visit? And did that mean that kids at school were talking badly about me? Doing it in front of the one person who'd made me feel like a friend? The thought brought me quickly down out of the clouds and back to reality.

'The students there are real buttnuggets. I've been counting the days until you return to school.'

I snorted – both with relief as well as at the word 'buttnugget'. Daphne laughed out loud. 'Did you just snort?'

'Yes,' I admitted. 'I'm a dreadful laugh-snorter. Always have been.'

Now she squealed. 'A laugh-snorter! How perfect! I fart when I laugh.'

I laugh-snorted again. 'Really?'

'Sometimes. My brothers call it a "lart". A laugh-fart.' Daphne was laughing so hard she could barely get the words out. Then, with the most impossibly perfect comedic timing, she let squeal an enormous fart.

We became hysterical. Each time it appeared our laughter was close to subsiding, one of us snorted or farted and the whole thing started up again. It was intoxicating. And so we remained, larting and snorting until I thought I would burst open with happiness.

23

NOW

‘A lot of people know your story, Elsie,’ Libby says, placing her mug on the coaster I provided. ‘At least they think they do. But this is your chance to set the record straight. With so many stories about you out in the zeitgeist, where do you even start?’

I sit back in my chair and whistle. I haven’t the foggiest idea.

‘Well,’ I say, eventually, ‘I suppose I’d start at the beginning. With Kitty. Theories abounded about her cause of death. I’ve read it all. Out of all the deaths, that one has the most theories.’

Adeem glances at his notes. ‘According to Wikipedia, her cause of death was inconclusive.’

‘Actually, according to her death certificate, she died of polio when she was twelve months old. But, depending on where you look, you’ll find I smothered her with a stuffed toy in her crib, I tortured her by breaking every bone in her legs, or tossed her out the window of my second-floor bedroom . . .’

‘There were lots of theories about your mother’s death too,’ Libby continues. ‘Although it was officially ruled a suicide.’

‘Obviously everyone thinks I pushed her. Which I suppose I’d understand if she’d screamed. But if you do your research you’ll find the statistics are low on people going silently over a ledge after being pushed.’

‘Is there anything public opinion has got right?’

I consider this. ‘Some of the details of the final murder have been pretty close.’

Libby looks down at the papers in front of her. ‘The court records stated that “your attack was vicious and unyielding and proved intent beyond reasonable doubt”.’ She looks up. ‘So . . . that description . . . captured it, did it?’

I cast my mind back – to my grimacing face, the grotesque blood spatter, the dull thud of pummelled meat as I bashed and bashed and bashed.

‘If anything,’ I admit, ‘they downplayed that part a bit.’

I’m impressed to find that Libby and Adeem don’t seem too repulsed. I suppose one can’t be squeamish if one hosts a crime show.

‘We’ll talk about that in more detail later,’ Libby says, ‘but first I want to talk about Daphne.’

I feel something heavy land upon my chest.

‘Public opinion has had some pretty strong opinions about Daphne,’ Adeem says carefully. ‘How do you feel about that?’

I don’t know what to say. ‘How do I feel?’ I say finally. Shrug. ‘I don’t know. Sad, I guess.’

‘Why do you feel sad, Elsie?’ Libby asks.

‘Because,’ I say, ‘they couldn’t have got her more wrong. She wasn’t the person who brought me down. She was the only person who stood beside me. The one who gave everything and asked for nothing in return. She was the person who saved me.’

I feel myself getting choked up with emotion. Adeem and Libby lower their eyes.

‘The truth is, if I could have picked one part of my story for people to get right, it would have been Daphne.’

Late in the afternoon, Adeem steps out into the courtyard to take a call and Libby and I have a few quiet moments together.

‘Is he talking to a girl, do you think?’ I ask.

Libby nods. ‘He’ll be talking to his wife.’

‘Wife?’ I exclaim. ‘He’s barely old enough to drive.’

‘Tell me about it,’ Libby says.

According to Libby, Adeem and Meera have been married for six months, during which time Adeem has disappeared from all social circles to place himself at her beck and call.

‘Henpecked,’ I say.

She nods. ‘It’s sweet, really. Also very amusing.’

Meera, Libby says, is lovely, but also – how can she put it delicately? – high maintenance.

‘Do you . . . have a husband, Libby?’

‘God, no,’ she says. ‘I have a boyfriend, but if he called half as much as Meera, I’d take out a restraining order.’

‘Good girl,’ I say.

‘What about you, Elsie? Did you ever marry?’

I open my mouth just as Adeem comes in the back door.

‘Sorry, that was the wife.’ Adeem puffs out his chest, appearing pleased with the way that sounds.

‘How is it,’ I ask him, ‘that you are married, when you’ve barely escaped the womb?’

He deflates. ‘I’m twenty-three.’

I raise my eyebrows. He doesn’t respond, so I expect I made my point.

‘Anyway,’ Libby says, ‘now that you’ve excavated yourself from under Meera’s thumb, shall we continue the interview?’

‘It’s called devotion, Libby,’ he says, sinking back into his chair. ‘Though, I’ll admit, I never knew you could be so terrified of the person you love.’

‘Lucky man,’ I tell him. ‘In my experience, love has always been synonymous with terror.’

24

Later in the day, Libby, Adeem and I are interrupted by an agitated thumping at the door.

I glance at the clock. Just after 4:45 pm.

'Want me to answer it?' Libby asks. 'I can send them away if they are here to bother you.'

It's lovely of her to offer, especially as Adeem is too busy thumbing away at his phone to even notice the door. But given the time, I know who it is.

'It'll just be my tormentor, don't worry,' I say, heaving myself out of my chair. 'Just don't be fooled. She's like a grenade – cute and harmless to look at, but a weapon of mass destruction nonetheless.'

Libby looks amused enough to tell me she doesn't believe a word I say. I have half a mind to invite Persephone in. That would teach Libby to believe the best in people.

Though I'm loath to admit it, I'm happy to hear from her. I feel bad about shouting at her and would rather not have to keep thinking of her little tear-filled eyes. A couple of milk arrowroot biscuits and a game of Uno should do the trick.

Persephone has the audacity to pound on the door yet again before I reach it. I plan to remind her that she, of all people, should remember that I'm old and that it takes me a while to get to the door.

'For heaven's sake,' I say, throwing open the door.

'Elsa! Quick. Come and see.'

'Come and see what?'

'It's a surprise. Just come! Into the lane.'

'But I have guests.'

Persephone blinks. 'You do? *Who?*'

Impertinent child.

I glance into the laneway. No reporters that I can see. For pity's sake. 'You've got two minutes,' I say, and she squeals in delight.

'I'll just be a minute,' I call into the house, and Adeem and Libby shout back for me to take my time.

'Right,' I say, when we're in the middle of the laneway. 'What's this surprise then?'

Wordlessly, she reaches for her hula hoop, which was propped against the fence, and places it over her head.

'Oh! So you've –'

With her gaze forward, she puts a finger to her mouth, shushing me. The *audacity*.

I close my mouth.

She scrunches up her face in concentration, and gives the hoop a great whirl. Ridiculously, I find myself holding my breath as it begins to move. It is entirely inelegant. The hoop slips and slides and bounces off her chin. But, against all odds . . . it is spinning. There is something comedic about the stiff way she holds her head and neck. The child giggles uncontrollably.

'You did it!' Peter cries from his porch.

'She's been practising all day,' Roxanne says, appearing on hers. 'She's wanted to show you for hours.'

'Has she?'

Despite myself, I find this rather endearing. I give her a little whoop.

'Watch this,' she says, and begins circling her hips and sticking out her tongue, playing the fool. She laughs, delighted with herself.

'Quite the little clown you've got there,' I say to Roxanne, who nods.

Her laughter is contagious, filling the air as the hoop circles her neck again and again. Roxanne is smiling. So is Peter. Joan looks out of her window and nods, which is about as good as it gets for Joan. And, fine, I'm smiling too. I'm not entirely made of stone, as it turns out.

Adeem and Libby poke their heads out the door, presumably to see what all the commotion is, but instead of looking at us they peer toward the mouth of the laneway. I follow their gaze. A small group hovers there. Not

reporters, thank God. Just young people – the grubby kind. A stringy man in a tank top with dreadlocks and a chest full of ink. Two women with high ponytails and pants so short it's hardly worth bothering. Canvas totes. Plastic water bottles. The unmistakable musk of righteous youth and second-hand hummus. University students, I'd bet my pension.

'Thank you for coming to my show,' Persephone says grandly, and I look back at her in time to see her take a deep bow. The neighbours – and Adeem and Libby – give her a round of applause. 'For my next trick, I'll be –'

'Hey!' The dreadlocked man's throaty voice cuts through the joyful atmosphere. 'That's *her*!'

We all look over. The dreadlocked man is pointing at me.

'Holy shit, it is,' one of the high-ponytailed women says. The other woman, I notice, is holding a sign. She lifts it above her head as if she's in a crowd at a concert.

MURDER MABEL.

I hear Persephone sounding out the words. 'Murder Mabel? Who is Mabel?'

The woman is freckled and five-foot-nothing. I could eat her for breakfast and have room for a second course. And yet, I am afraid. Of her certainty. Her conviction. Her hatred.

And then the man is coming at me, fast.

'Can I help you, son?' It's Peter's voice, which both comforts and frightens me. I feel him step toward me but the man is closer.

He comes to a stop a few metres away from me. I'm relieved. Until he lifts his arm.

'Stop!' Persephone cries.

Everything after that blurs. I hear a scream – someone else's, or mine, I'll never know. Persephone flashes into my vision. I throw out an arm to shield her.

Then –

A sound like a car backfiring.

My ears ringing.

And blood. In my mouth. In my eyes. So much blood.

The world tips sideways and I'm falling, boneless, weightless. But even as I go down, one thought punches through the haze: The child. Where is the child?

25

THEN

It was a hot, blue-skied day. Daphne and I were lazing by the bay window of my bedroom, the soles of our bare feet pressed up against the glass. *The Platter Parade* was on and Daphne was singing along, very badly, to The Everly Brothers.

'Dream dream dream,' Daphne droned, in her God-awful voice. It was so bad that I was more than a little grateful when I heard a rap on my bedroom door.

'Knock knock.'

It wasn't like Cess to knock. Then again, it wasn't like me to have the door closed. So much about my having a friend was unfamiliar. So much so that when Cess opened the door, I felt shy.

'Hello,' she said with an odd brightness. Ness was by her side. 'We just heard you talking and thought Daphne might be here. You've been talking about her so much and we'd love to meet her.'

'Sure.' I glanced at Daphne. Daphne didn't seem shy at all. She leapt to her feet.

'Hullo, Cess, hullo, Ness,' Daphne exclaimed. 'It's a pleasure to meet you both.'

The pause that followed confused and embarrassed me. I understood, of course, that Daphne's family was working class. I saw it in her clothes, heard it in her accent. I knew that her parents were the type of people my

mum and dad would have called ‘salt of the earth’ but not the type of people who would attend one of their infamous parties.

My school, being Catholic, was open to all the families in our parish, but the only people we socialised with were the ones whom my father deemed to be of good standing. The people who came in our doors wore polished shoes, had combed hair. If I’d had more friends, I may have had a better understanding of this. Cess wasn’t as judgemental as my father had been – or even my mother, for that matter – but she lived in their world. She wasn’t immune.

If Daphne noticed the pause, she didn’t show it. She widened her eyes. ‘Wow,’ she said to Cess. ‘You look like Marilyn Monroe.’

Cess did look particularly glamorous that day. Her trousers, a soft pastel pink, had a sharp crease down the front, showing off the smooth lines of her slender legs. Her matching blouse, tucked neatly into her waistband, was a light floral print with tiny roses scattered across the fabric.

‘And you,’ she said to Ness, ‘are a dead ringer for Audrey Hepburn.’

‘It’s lovely to meet you, Daphne,’ Ness said. She made meaningful eye contact with Cess to tell her to snap out of it. ‘A real pleasure.’

‘The pleasure is mine,’ Daphne said, with mock formality. ‘I’ve heard lots about you.’

‘Can Daphne join us for dinner tonight?’ I asked.

‘Sure,’ Ness said. ‘Cess has made chicken and vegetable pie with mash.’

Daph gave a little fist pump. I laughed. ‘Cess’s pies are the best.’

Cess was still staring at Daphne. I willed her to stop.

‘Right then,’ she said finally. ‘I’ll go set an extra place, shall I?’

We nodded, and they disappeared from the room, closing the door behind them.

Daphne beamed. ‘They’re so nice!’

‘They’ve been best friends all their life,’ I told her.

‘Like we will be,’ Daphne said.

‘You think?’

‘Heavens, yes,’ Daphne cried. ‘Two little old ladies, wreaking havoc in the nursing home, you mark my words.’

Oddly I could see it.

'Sorry about the way they were looking at you,' I said.

Daphne scoffed. 'That? That was nothing. Besides, for chicken and vegetable pie they can look at me any old way they want.'

To her credit, Daphne seemed unbothered. I hoped it was true. Besides, she made a good point. A lot of people would accept worse for a slice of Cess's chicken and vegetable pie.

I went back to school a week before the doctor had suggested. While I didn't love school – show me a social outcast who does – I found I needed its structure. I needed the day to be broken into segments, rather than the long, indistinguishable stretch between sunup and sundown that I'd experienced at home and at the hospital. Besides, my arm was healing well and there was only so much wallowing around the house I could do. That's what I said to Cess and Ness, at least. The truth, of course, was that I went back to school a week early because I knew Daphne was going to be there.

St Mary's was a beautiful school. The main building was bluestone, with arched stained-glass windows, religious statues and crucifixes at every turn. Inside, children roamed the cavernous corridors while nuns floated after them, delivering prayers and reprimands as required to children they passed. Each classroom was more or less identical: rows of worn, wooden, chewing-gum-pocked desks facing a blackboard, and of course, a framed picture of Our Lady. Each lesson began with a sign of the cross and, in my case, a hope for the best.

On my first day back, Daphne was waiting for me behind the curling iron gates. 'Maybelline! Hullo!'

I stared at her. 'What did you call me?'

'Maybelline. It's a nickname. You know? The makeup brand?'

We fell into step as we walked into the building, toward our lockers. I couldn't decide if Daphne was utterly mad or entirely delightful. It was lineball. 'The story goes that Mabel Williams singed off her eyelashes in 1915 and then used the ashes and some Vaseline to make mascara. Her

older brother Tom started the brand and he named it in her honour. Mabel and Vaseline, get it? Maybelline. Cool story, hey?'

I must have been staring at her because she looked at me and said: 'What? It's a nickname, I thought you'd like it. Oh, forget it.'

The only nickname I'd ever known was Mad Mabel, and I was not fond of it at all. This felt different. Where Mad Mabel felt accusatory – unfairly so – this felt affectionate.

'I do like it.'

'Oh. Well, good. No guarantees I'll ever call you that again though, I'm afraid. My nicknames tend to change.'

Daphne's constant stream of chatter made me realise how quiet my life had been. How different it was, having her by my side.

We stowed our bags in our lockers and collected our books. Before heading to the first class, I took a breath and steadied myself.

'Don't worry, I'll be right beside you, okay? Every minute. If you feel sad about your mum, just squeeze my hand, okay?'

She slipped her hand into mine. I squeezed.

A few showed kindness that first day back.

Sister Margaret Mary, my home economics teacher, began class with a prayer for my family. Brother Ignatius, my maths teacher, offered a solemn nod and a firm hand to my shoulder as I entered the room. Countless kids opened their mouths to lob insults, then seemed to think better of it.

But only Mr Loukas said the words.

'I'm so sorry to hear about your mother,' he said after class.

I liked Mr Loukas. He was one of the few lay teachers – non-religious staff who taught alongside the Brothers and Sisters. He was young, maybe mid-twenties, beanpole thin, with a jelly roll haircut like Elvis. He wore patterned shirts – birds, boats, and once, tiny Christmas puddings – with a bow tie, waistcoat and a jaunty Panama hat.

'Are you sure you're ready to be back, Mabel?' he asked.

I shrugged. 'What would I do at home?'

He nodded. ‘Not to hijack your grief,’ he said gently, ‘but I lost my mother around your age. Long illness. I got to say goodbye. I can’t imagine what it’s been like for you.’

‘Thank you,’ I said.

The classroom was empty. That wasn’t unusual – when history bumped up against recess or lunch, I sometimes lingered by his desk, hoping to talk more about the day’s lesson. He always indulged me, even if it cost him his break.

He reached out, and for a moment, I thought he was going to hug me. Instead, he took my hand.

‘I’m here for you, Mabel,’ he said. ‘Night or day.’

It didn’t quite make sense – I only saw him during school hours – but the words landed like a life vest tossed into deep water.

That night, I lay in bed and fantasised about marrying Mr Loukas.

26

Everyone who knows my story is familiar with Bonfire Day. It was after school and Daphne insisted on walking me home, even though, as a boarder, she would just have to turn around and walk back again.

'What am I going to do at school?' she said when I told her she didn't have to. 'Homework? No siree, Bob! I'd rather go get into some trouble with you.'

Get into trouble. It was an expression, rather than an actual suggestion, and yet there was something exciting about the prospect. Everyone considered me a square, and with good reason. It was hard to get into much trouble alone. As it turned out, even the possibility of trouble was intoxicating.

But instead of going straight back to Rosehill, we just walked. For a while we talked and walked, and then we walked in silence. We found our way to the beach path and that's where we noticed the bonfire.

'Ooh, Maybelline, look – a bonfire!'

It wasn't unusual to see a bonfire at the beach at this time of day. Due to Rosehill's proximity to the beach, I often smelled them from my bedroom window, and heard the squeals and snorts of laughter from the children around them. They typically burned until sundown, at which point they were abandoned or doused by parents who finally showed up to rein things in. At this point in the afternoon though, it burned strongly, surrounded by neighbourhood children, still in their school uniforms.

Daphne grabbed my arm and started dragging me toward the fire. 'There's some kids from school there. Let's check it out.'

I dug my feet into the sand. As charming as she was, sometimes I wondered if Daphne came from another planet. Billy Harris was among the group, as were his younger brothers, all of them smoking cigarettes. The

twins, Dolly and Tammy, were also there. I also spotted Christos, the new boy at school. It was a surprise to see him because, being Greek and new to Australia, he seemed to be as much of a social outcast as I was. His parents owned a fish-and-chip shop, which armed people with endless jokes about him being a moussaka muncher, smelling of chip fat, or needing to do well at maths so he didn't short-change them when they collected their dinner on Friday night. However, unlike me, Christos was an exceptional football player. I assumed his newly favourable social status was because of this.

'Are you mad, Daphne? We can't just bowl up and start talking to them.'

'Don't be a ninny. Corsets we can.'

As she took off toward the group of kids, my instinct was to let her go alone. And yet, after the friendship Daphne had offered me, I knew the very least I could do was stand beside her.

She'd walked so fast that I didn't catch up with her until she was almost at the bonfire. By this point, the kids had all stopped talking, excited and appalled by the unexpected interruption.

'Hey,' Daphne said. 'I'm Daphne, this is Mabel.' She laughed. 'I mean, of course you know Mabel. She's hard to miss, right?'

'Hey,' I said weakly.

I stared into the fire, which contained a charred school diary, a wheel from a bicycle or pram, and general beach detritus – a yellow plastic pail and a glass Coca-Cola bottle. I wanted to crawl into it.

Christos broke the silence. 'Hey!'

He was drenched – shirt clinging to him, socks squelching in his shoes. His dark hair was slicked back from his face, except for one rebellious strand that curled forward and sent a slow drip trailing down his cheek.

'Phwoar,' Daphne said quietly. 'He's a bit of all right.'

I wasn't sure about that, but I was grateful that he, unlike the others, had acknowledged me. Until he said: 'How's the weather up there, Beanstalk?'

A ripple of laughter went around. Heat rose from my neck to the tips of my ears like a rash of shame.

‘Beanstalk,’ Billy repeated, sniggering. ‘I like it. Wait, does that mean you want to climb her?’

The twins howled. Billy’s brothers nearly choked on their smokes.

I stared at my feet, wishing I could vanish into the sand. A hundred comebacks crowded my throat, but none made it past my lips. The laughter scraped across my skin like grit. I could feel every inch of myself – too tall, too bony, too *there*. Then, I heard myself mutter, ‘If he’s interested in me, he’d better set his sights a little lower.’

It was sharp, and louder than I’d meant and I braced, certain I’d made it worse.

But something shifted. The laughter that followed wasn’t cruel. It was surprised. Pleased, even. Christos laughed too – a genuine, easy sound, not the snide bark of the twins or the hollow bray of Billy and his gang. Daphne hooted.

‘You win this round, Beanstalk,’ Christos said. He extended a hand as if to shake mine. ‘Well done.’

‘Shake his hand,’ Daphne whispered.

But I kept my gaze down and my hands tucked firmly by my side. I’d somehow survived this moment. I wasn’t about to tempt fate.

‘Anyway, since you’re here . . . we’re playing spin the bottle,’ Billy said to Daphne and me. ‘Want to join?’

‘You wish, Billy,’ Tammy said. ‘We were playing truth or dare. Fred, Christos and Johnny chose dare, that’s why they’re soaking wet. I chose truth – no, I’ve never kissed anyone. Dolly also chose truth, and the last time she lied was when she told Mum she liked her haircut.’

The twins giggled.

‘So it’s your turn, Beanstalk,’ Billy said.

‘Actually, it’s yours, Billy,’ Christos said.

‘Yeah, Billy,’ echoed the others.

It quickly became evident that he’d been responsible for some of the less favourable dares and the group wanted him to have his day in court.

‘Fine.’ He groaned. ‘Dare.’

‘I dare you,’ Fred said, ‘to kiss the Beanstalk.’

I glanced at Daphne in alarm. She looked as horrified as I felt.

‘Gross,’ Johnny said, his eyes eagerly trained on us.

‘All right,’ Billy said.

My stomach flipped, then seemed to bottom out completely. Billy was going to kiss me? In front of everyone? Was this some kind of punishment? A prank?

I didn’t have time to think. He pressed his dry, chafed lips against mine so firmly I nearly lost my balance. Then his tongue was in my mouth. It was an odd, unpleasant sensation, and I clamped my mouth shut and shoved him away. Billy stumbled, caught himself, and straightened with a scowl.

Fred and Johnny howled with laughter.

I wiped my mouth.

‘That bad?’ Daphne said.

‘She wiped her mouth!’ Dolly cried.

Billy shoved her to the sand. ‘Shut up, twerp.’

Christos helped Dolly up and Billy made a big show of wiping his own mouth with his sleeve, before spitting on the sand.

‘You’re a stuck-up bitch, aren’t you?’ Billy’s voice was quiet, which perhaps is what made it so scary. The laughter died on the breeze.

‘Hey,’ Daphne said sharply.

‘Billy,’ Christos warned.

But Billy wasn’t listening.

‘Who do you think you are?’

‘Let’s go, Mabel,’ Daphne said. I nodded and we turned to walk away.

‘Someone like you should be grateful for my attention,’ he called after us. ‘No one else would look at you twice, baby killer.’

I stopped cold.

‘That’s right,’ he continued. ‘We all know what you did to your baby sister, Mad Mabel.’

I turned slowly. I could see from Tammy and Dolly’s scandalised expressions that they knew exactly what he was talking about. Fred and Johnny too. But how? I’d only just found out about Kitty myself. How

could they possibly know? Only Christos looked genuinely unsure about what was going on.

My face became hot. But this time it wasn't humiliation. This time, it was rage.

'Wanna know my theory?' Billy said, smiling now. He'd found a vein. He was going to make me bleed out. 'I think you were jealous. You didn't want a baby sister stealing your toys . . .'

I turned and kept walking, faster now. But Billy trailed behind, nipping at my heels.

'Apparently she was the spitting image of your mother. Pretty as a picture.'

And then I knew. *Pretty as a picture*. It was an expression my father used, often. Never for me, obviously. Often he'd used it to describe my mother. Now, it seemed, he'd used it to describe my sister too, when he'd told the neighbourhood that I'd killed her. Was this the reason no one wanted to play with me? I wondered suddenly. Was it the reason I was known as Mad Mabel?

As I marched up the beach, something rose up in me. It wasn't sadness. It wasn't even anger – not in the usual way. It was something primal, something raw. It swelled beneath my skin like a creature demanding release.

I reached the car park stairs, fists clenched, Billy still jeering behind me. *So this is how it feels*, I thought. *This is how it feels to want to kill someone*. It struck me, suddenly and almost humorously, that up until now I hadn't really earned my nickname. But looking back, if I had to pinpoint a moment I went mad, it was then, on that beach. That was the day I became Mad Mabel.

27

NOW

‘Persephone!’

Roxanne is screaming Persephone’s name. It’s pure and ragged and for a moment, it’s all that exists.

I hear footsteps on the cobblestones. I assume this is the sound of my attackers running away. Peter is shouting for someone to call an ambulance.

I open my eyes, but they are filled with blood. I wipe liquid from my eyes and my nose and my mouth. I try to sit up, but the woman at my side – Libby! Libby! – stops me. ‘Don’t move, Elsie. The ambulance is coming.’

‘The child,’ I say to Libby, so softly I’m not sure she’ll hear. ‘Is she . . .’

I hear Roxanne’s desperate voice. ‘Tell me where it hurts, baby. Persephone? Tell me.’

The pause seems to last an eternity. But finally, she speaks. ‘I’m not hurt. Stop it, Mum. Is Elsa . . .’ Persephone appears in my vision line. ‘Elsa!’ She wraps her arms around me, nearly crushing me. ‘Elsa! You’re not dead.’

‘Neither are you!’ I say.

Peter drops to his knees beside me and clasps my hand. ‘Ambulance is on its way, Elsie. Hang in there.’ I lock eyes with him.

‘What hurts, Elsie?’ Roxanne says.

‘I don’t know. My wrist?’ I break my gaze with Peter and look at my wrist. It’s bent at a funny angle.

‘Where is the blood coming from?’ she asks. ‘Did they shoot you?’

I look down at myself. There's so much blood. Too much. My tailbone stings from where it hit the cobblestones, as does my left wrist, which I extended to break my fall. But I'm unaware of a wound that could be causing so much blood.

'I think it was a water pistol,' Adeem says.

I look down at the dark red liquid on my clothes. 'But . . .'

'Filled with blood,' he says. 'I've seen it before. Happens at family planning clinics every once in a while.'

'Real blood?' I say. It certainly smells and feels like it. 'Where would they get real blood?'

Adeem shrugs. This appears to be the end of his expertise on the matter.

'Right then.' I lie back against the cobblestones. 'Cancel the ambulance.'

'Nonsense,' Roxanne says. 'You had a fall. And your wrist is broken.'

'I'm fine!' I say more firmly. 'No ambulance.'

The Nguyens look on worriedly, and Joan stands a few metres away, not speaking, but watching with interest.

'Did you hit your head?' Roxanne says.

'No. Just my tailbone. And my wrist.'

The ambulance arrives, and they disregard my efforts to send them away. Even Persephone has to go in to be looked over. Peter gets in with me, which is kind of him. The Nguyens offer to look after Nugget, which is stupid of them.

Before they close the back doors, I notice Joan is standing quietly on her porch. Her normally suspicious, darting eyes are downcast. Perhaps I'm imagining things, but she almost looks like she's ashamed.

28

I hate hospitals. I hate the sickly lighting that makes my skin look the colour of sour milk. I hate the chipper nurses with their forced smiles and their breezy small talk, like we're at a bloody day spa. I'm sure they think we're a pack of whingers. And honestly? Fair enough.

One of these nurses wheels me to X-ray, chirping away about weekend plans as we go. My suspicions about her cheerfulness are confirmed when I throw the question back at her and she tells me she's off to the country to look after her father, who has Alzheimer's. 'He's been in better spirits lately,' she adds, 'since he doesn't recognise anyone at all.'

Kill me.

The doctor at X-ray confirms what I already knew. 'It's a clean break,' he says.

'Is that right?' I say pleasantly, instead of *No shit, Sherlock*. I can play this faux-cheer game too.

I come across Daphne as I'm wheeled back to my room. She's impossible to miss in a yellow feathered bomber jacket.

'Mother of God, Daphne, you look like Big Bird.'

She ignores me. 'I leave you alone for one afternoon and what happens?'

She kisses my forehead. Her shampoo, something citrusy and light, mixes with the scent of coffee from the cafeteria. 'Why didn't anyone call me?'

'Peter is here.' I smile. Daphne catches it.

'Good. But I should have been here.'

'And so you are.'

As I'm pushed back to my room, I fill Daphne in. 'Some kids with a vendetta came to the street with signs. When they saw me, they approached

with what I thought was a gun, but what turned out to be a water pistol filled with blood or something that looked and smelled like blood.'

'Bastards,' Daphne mutters.

'I fell backward, landed on my wrist. And here we are.'

'Did they catch them?' Daphne continues. 'If they did, I'd like five minutes alone with them.'

'Thanks, Daph,' I tell her. And I do appreciate the sentiment. There's no reason to point out that Daphne, being an elderly lady with the size and strength of a child, is unlikely to intimidate even the smallest of my assailants. Any such comment would probably just egg her on, anyway.

The nurses tell me I'm to be kept overnight in the hospital, for observation. I tell them that is a gross misuse of taxpayers' funds, and that I'll be perfectly fine to go home, but truth be told, I'm a little relieved when they insist. As much as I don't like hospitals, there's something comforting about the presence of others nearby. The fact is, I feel a little short of breath, a little shaky. Worse, every time I close my eyes, I see that dreadlocked man holding his arm out. And I think not of myself but of Persephone, and what could have happened to her. You didn't have to like the child to fear something like that. Although, if I'm honest, it's getting harder and harder to not like her.

'Stop thinking about it,' Daphne says. 'And for heaven's sake, do not blame yourself, do you hear me?'

Peter is waiting in my room – a four-bedder ward with thin curtains dividing it. He is in a corner chair, reading a newspaper.

'For pity's sake, you need to go home, Peter.'

'I am happy to stay with her now,' Daphne adds.

'I'll stay a little longer if it's all right with you,' he says, closing his newspaper.

A man in the room, behind a curtain, groans, then breaks wind.

I raise my eyebrows. 'Are you sure about that?'

'Actually, I am. I have nothing planned and besides, my mother would roll over in her grave if I left an elderly woman in hospital.'

I flare my nostrils. ‘Your mother would roll over in her grave if she heard how impertinent you’re being,’ I reply. ‘Elderly!’

Peter chuckles and goes back to his newspaper. I continue to huff and mutter under my breath, desperately clinging to my curmudgeonly facade. I know if I let the veil slip, even for a second, I might just weep at his kindness.

Persephone visits after she’s been assessed and released without a scratch on her.

‘She wouldn’t let me leave without coming to see you,’ Roxanne says, as Persephone climbs onto my hospital bed. ‘Literally wouldn’t let me leave. She’s hidden the ticket that I need to get my car out of the parking lot.’

‘I had to come and thank Elsa for saving my life!’

I snort. ‘Saving your life? What rubbish. I’d have used you as a human shield if I’d had a chance to think.’

‘Nice try,’ Peter says. ‘We all saw you push the child behind your back as that man approached. You’re a hero.’

‘See?’ Persephone says. ‘You saved me. I could have been killed!’

I roll my eyes. The man in the next bed lets out a great fart, as if in solidarity with Persephone.

‘Excuse you!’ the child cries, fanning the air in front of her nose. Roxanne, by the door, winces.

‘We should leave Elsie to rest,’ Roxanne says.

Persephone looks appalled. ‘But I need to sign her cast!’

‘Another time, darling.’

‘Why not now? I want to be the first one.’

‘I don’t think you’re going to have a lot of competition, Persephone,’ Roxanne says.

There’s a beat of silence. I suspect that Roxanne means because there are no other children around, but it comes out a little harsh.

‘I don’t know,’ Peter says, winking at Persephone. ‘I might beat her to it.’

‘Not if I get there first!’ Daphne says, and takes off, presumably in search of a Sharpie.

‘See, Mum?’ Persephone says, triumphant.

Roxanne relents – as if she ever stood a chance – and when a nurse produces a blue Texta, Persephone is the first to sign my cast.

‘Right then,’ Roxanne says, the moment she’s done. ‘You’ve signed the cast. Time to go.’

Roxanne *does* seem very eager to leave. I glance at Daphne, who I can see is thinking the same thing.

‘But why?’ Persephone whines. ‘We have the whole –’

‘Now, Persephone,’ Roxanne says.

I tell myself that the speed with which they leave afterward is a result of the flatulence of my roommate, but I have a sneaky feeling in my bones that it’s more than that.

29

Peter collects me from the hospital in an Uber the next morning. The car smells like stale air-conditioning and too much pine-scented air freshener. As the driver takes a turn too fast, I grip the doorhandle with my good hand, my body aching in more places than I care to count. The Uber driver says nothing, just taps the steering wheel along to a tinny pop song playing through his phone.

I brace myself for the media circus when we pull up to Kenny Lane. I expect flashing cameras, microphones shoved into my face, the aggressive hum of reporters circling like flies. Instead, the road has been blocked off with orange traffic cones, and a uniformed cop stands at the end of the lane, shifting his weight from foot to foot, looking bored.

'What's this?' I ask Peter as we step onto the kerb. The hospital may have let me go, but my body hasn't quite caught up with the idea that it's ready for freedom.

'I put in a call to the police,' Peter says, slamming the door. 'When people start getting injured, things have gone too far.'

I let out a short, incredulous laugh. 'Wow. And the police actually did something?'

Peter shrugs. 'Didn't hurt that Joan's nephew put in a call too. He's a partner in a law firm.'

'I'm surprised Joan would volunteer her nephew to help me,' I mutter, more to myself than to Peter.

'She's not so bad,' Peter says. His voice is soft, almost thoughtful.

I stop walking and turn to him, narrowing my eyes. 'Peter,' I say slowly. 'Are you and Joan . . .?'

'Just friends,' he says. His lips twitch, then he schools his face into something neutral. But there's a twinkle in his eye.

I feel a surge of something I shouldn't.

'You could do better,' I blurt out.

Peter smiles at me. 'You think so, do you?'

I lift my chin. 'I do.'

'Well,' he says, 'I'll take that under advisement.'

Ouch.

Peter walks me to my door. He offers to see me inside, but I decline. Daphne will be over soon, and besides, I need some time alone.

The Nguyens don't appear to be home, and I'm relieved not to have to collect Nugget right away. Ever since yesterday I've felt something building inside me. The moment I close the door, I can't hold it off anymore . . . I cry. I cry and cry and cry and cry.

To say it isn't like me to cry is an understatement of the highest order. Even on my very worst days – and my goodness, those days were bad – I wasn't one to cry. My thoughts follow a circular pattern, travelling from the humiliation of the neighbours' reactions to the horror of being assaulted to the fear of what could have happened to Persephone.

The pattern repeats, and awful as it is, I can admit there is a catharsis in it. So when there is a knock at my door, I feel irritated at having my misery interrupted.

My irritation, though, is almost immediately followed by anxiety. I can tell by the politeness of the knock that it's not Persephone. I'd told Peter that I was going to have a nap, so he wouldn't be likely to knock. And Daphne was at home having a lie-down herself, which ruled out all the likely suspects.

I tiptoe down the hall, feeling ridiculous. I've been a single woman all my life – I've unclogged drains, ousted spiders, and investigated suspicious noises without missing a beat. The fact that I am nervous about answering the front door in the middle of the day feels like a betrayal of myself, not to mention of all the women who paved the way before me. And yet, I find

myself stepping into my bedroom to try to glimpse my guest through the front window.

It's Roxanne.

'I hope I'm not disturbing you.' Roxanne smiles when I open the door, offering me a small posy of wild daisies. I recognise them from the Nguyens' garden. 'These are from Mrs Nguyen.'

I take them. 'That's kind of her.'

'Sorry if I frightened you,' Roxanne says. 'I imagine you're a bit spooked.'

'Not at all,' I say.

'Well, Persephone made me promise I'd come and check on you. You've got a devoted friend there.'

I smile, ignoring the little spot in my chest that aches at this. 'I'm fine. Would you like to come in?'

'Thank you.'

She follows me into the back room. As I mill around the kitchen, finding a vase and cutting the stems of the flowers, Roxanne paces.

'Is something on your mind, Roxanne?'

She stops pacing and drops into an armchair. 'I'm sorry, Elsie, but I have to ask you something.'

I place a small ceramic vase in the sink and turn on the cold tap. 'Go ahead.'

'I've read the news, obviously. And I've had a conversation with Joan. There's a lot of . . . information out there and I don't know what to make of it all. So, I thought I'd ask you.'

'Ask me what?'

She sighs. Steadies herself. 'Are you Mad Mabel?'

Roxanne is sitting forward now on the edge of her chair, her elbows on her knees. I get the feeling she is desperate for me not to be guilty. Desperate for me to be good. I remember this desperation. It used to radiate from my mother.

I turn off the tap and haphazardly shove the daisies into the vase. Then I cross the room and sit. 'I don't refer to myself as such, but yes, that's what

people call me. My full name is Mabel Elsie Waller. Fitzpatrick was my mother's maiden name.'

'But how can this be true?' she says. 'You seem like such a . . . a . . .'

She doesn't finish the sentence. I don't blame her. 'A nice lady' probably doesn't fit. Instead she says: 'My *daughter* has been spending time here with you!'

'Not at my behest,' I point out. It probably doesn't ingratiate me to Roxanne, but it is, simply, a fact. To soften it, I add: 'And hasn't she come back, unharmed each time?'

'You went to prison!' she cries. 'You were the youngest Australian ever to be convicted of murder in this country. We learned about it at school.'

'Actually,' I say, 'my lawyer fought hard to get me into a mental asylum, though admittedly it was nothing more than a prison with anti-psychotics. But yes, I was the youngest Australian, etc, etc.'

Roxanne sinks back into the armchair.

'I'm sorry,' I say. I *am* sorry. I'm sorry that along with everything else she has to deal with as a single mother to a monstrous child, she has to process this information. I'm sorry that she will feel unsafe now. Mostly, I'm sorry that Joan was right, because it would have been nice to have called her insane and laughed together over cups of tea.

Roxanne drags a hand through her hair. 'Persephone adores you.'

I fight the urge to retort, 'The feeling is not mutual.' Because I feel a *but* coming.

'But . . . under the circumstances, I think it's better if she doesn't spend time over here anymore.'

It hits like an arrow to the heart. 'Of course.'

'I'm sure you won't be upset,' she says, with an empty laugh. 'You'll get your peace and quiet back.'

'It's all right, Roxanne. I understand completely.'

'If it was just me, I would give you the benefit of the doubt. But it's not just me. And I have to be the most responsible mother I can be because of Persephone. To keep her safe.'

‘I understand,’ I repeat, several more times before Roxanne finally leaves. And I do understand. I understand that ever since I was a little girl, people around me have died, one after another. And I understand that, if it was my little girl, I wouldn’t want her anywhere near me either.

30

THEN

Here's a tip. If you ever feel that hot, bubbly rage – the rage that is black in colour rather than red – run. Run and run and run until you're out of breath and your body is weak and the anger drains out of you. This not only gets you out of trouble, it also leaves you too weary to conjure up any more rage. That's what I did on Bonfire Day. I ran from Billy, away from Daphne and the other kids, up the beach as far as I could until I couldn't run anymore. Then, I stood by a rubbish bin catching my breath.

'Mabel?'

I startled. 'Mr Loukas?'

Mr Loukas was barefoot, his trousers rolled up, a white fluffy dog at his ankles. A brown leather leash was draped across his shoulders like a beach towel.

'I thought that was you.'

It was jarring, seeing him outside the school grounds. I had not considered the prospect that his existence continued beyond the parameters of the classroom. I had certainly not considered his existence to include a white yappy dog.

'Are you all right?' he asked.

I nodded. Then shook my head. I felt my face contort and crumple, finally losing in my efforts to keep myself together.

Mr Loukas removed the leash from his shoulders and clipped it to the dog's collar. 'There's a bench over there. Let's sit.'

I hesitated. The sun was setting and the beach was bathed in golden light, but quickly sinking into darkness. Cess and Ness would worry.

'Come on,' he urged. 'Marilyn is a very good listener.'

'Marilyn?'

He nodded at the dog. 'Monroe. I'm a fan of beautiful women, what can I say? Come on.'

I followed him to the little bench, and we sat side by side. Marilyn immediately moved to the nearby rubbish bin and started sniffing.

I kept my gaze forward.

'What's going on?' he said.

'Where do I start?'

'Start where the pain is,' Mr Loukas said.

'The pain is everywhere.'

He turned toward me so his thigh grazed mine. 'Losing your mother is a huge blow at your age. You're grieving, Mabel.'

'It's not just that.'

'Oh?' He cocked his head. 'What else is going on?'

'All the kids call me Mad Mabel.'

Mr Loukas winced. 'That's not a very nice name.'

Marilyn yapped. 'Marilyn agrees,' he added.

'Before my mother died she told me I had a sister. Her name was Kitty. She told me Kitty died of polio when I was three and she was one. My parents never spoke of her because my father believes I intentionally gave her polio.'

Mr Loukas exhaled slowly, shaking his head. Marilyn continued yapping.

'I don't remember Kitty, and I definitely don't remember giving her polio. I didn't even know she existed until a few weeks ago. Now I find out that other kids know, and they also think I killed her. And I'm wondering if this is the reason I've never had a friend . . . because everyone thinks I'm a . . . monster.'

Mr Loukas didn't say anything. Marilyn continued yapping. She didn't appear to be the good listener that Mr Loukas had sold her to be. But Mr

Loukas wasn't bad.

'Mabel!' From off in the distance, I heard Cess's faint voice. 'Mabel! Where are you?'

'That's my aunt,' I said.

'Go,' he said. 'You don't want her to worry. I'll see you at school.'

'Okay,' I said, and I stood.

'Mabel?'

I turned back.

'Not everyone thinks you're a monster.' He smiled at me. 'Marilyn thinks you're amazing.'

'Mabel!' Cess called again, and I turned and ran, Mr Loukas's words bubbling inside me. No one had ever called me amazing before. I liked it. Even if it came from a dog.

31

The commotion in the street was loud enough that I could hear it over the shrieking cicadas. I was lying in bed. We lived in a sleepy cul-de-sac and it was a warm night, so my window was open. It was late, after 9 pm. Mr and Mrs Harris's voices were raised, as if they were having a disagreement.

'I think we should call the police,' I heard Mrs Harris say.

'Don't be dramatic, Lorraine.' Mr Harris was having none of it. 'He's probably just getting up to no good.'

'That's what I'm worried about!'

I got out of bed and walked to the window. My diary was open on the table. I'd written about the evening in detail before bed. I closed it.

'Give it an hour, and then I'll go down to the beach and have a look around. That's where the boys said they last saw him.'

'Maybe we should go and knock on the doors of some of his friends. See if anyone has heard anything?'

'It's after 9 pm. Everyone will be heading to bed! The last thing they need is for us to show up on their doorstep.'

'Well, I'm going to go to the Wallers'. Johnny said that Billy was with Mabel the last time he saw him.'

'You think he's off with Mad Mabel Waller?' There was a hint of amusement in Mr Harris's voice. 'I don't think she's exactly our son's type.'

'Have you got any better ideas?'

He mustn't have, because a minute or so later, our doorbell rang. I got back into bed as I heard the sounds of Cess talking to Mrs Harris for a few minutes, followed by Cess's footsteps on the stairs.

'Mabel?'

I sat up, pretending to blink awake.

‘Mrs Harris is here. Billy hasn’t come home yet and she thinks you were with him this afternoon?’

Cess’s tone makes it clear how unlikely she finds this idea.

‘I was.’

Her eyebrows shot up. ‘Really?’

‘Yes. Down at the bonfire.’

‘Oh. Well . . . Mrs Harris would like to talk to you.’

I put on my robe and followed Cess downstairs. Mrs Harris was in the foyer, pacing. She was barefaced and wearing house shoes.

‘Mabel, we’re looking for Billy. He hasn’t come home from the beach and Johnny and Fred say he was with you the last time they saw him.’

Mrs Harris was clearly anxious.

‘I saw him at the bonfire this afternoon, yes. But that was hours ago.’

‘My sons said Billy left the beach with you.’

‘Well . . .’ I thought of Billy following me off the beach, taunting me. *We know what you did to your baby sister*. ‘I wouldn’t say . . .’

‘You wouldn’t say what?’ she snapped.

My face became hot.

‘Lorraine,’ Cess said. ‘Mabel is trying to help you.’

‘Really? Because it feels to me like she’s acting cagey.’

‘Billy followed me off the beach. He was saying some upsetting things to me and I was trying to get away.’

Cess, I noticed, was looking a little worried now. Mrs Harris, on the other hand, looked irate.

‘So what happened?’

‘We got to the top of the stairs and I ran away.’

‘What did Billy do?’

‘I don’t know. I was running. When I stopped, he wasn’t there.’

Mrs Harris’s nostrils flared as she breathed in and out, slowly. ‘Did you do something to Billy, Mabel?’

‘No.’

‘Tell the truth now.’

‘No,’ I repeated, at the same time Cess said: ‘Enough, Lorraine.’

‘I bumped into Mr Loukas at the beach right after I left the other kids. Ask him. I didn’t do anything to Billy.’

Mrs Harris still seemed to be digesting this when blue and white lights flashed behind her in the cul-de-sac. We all turned as an officer emerged from his patrol car and began speaking to Mr Harris.

Mrs Harris hurried outside. Cess and I followed.

‘What is it?’ Mrs Harris said. ‘What’s happened?’

Mr Harris lifted his head, but for a moment he didn’t speak. The policeman’s hat, I noticed, was in his hand.

‘What is it?’ she said. ‘Tell me, Damian.’

Mrs Harris was shaking. Mr Harris was eerily still.

‘They’ve found him,’ Mr Harris said.

32

NOW

‘Elsa! *Psst*. Elsa!’

I’m in the kitchen attempting to prep my evening meal without the use of my left hand, when I hear the extraordinarily loud whisper. I’d spent the day indoors, not even going onto the porch for fresh air. It felt safest that way. No need to worry about Persephone seeing me, after Roxanne asked me to keep my distance. No need to worry about seeing Peter and making him feel like he needed to do more for me. No need to worry about seeing Joan. Good fences make great neighbours, isn’t that the saying? Neighbours are not friends. Besides, I have Daphne. She is the only friend I need.

Unfortunately, Daphne is at home. She was tired. Again.

‘Elsa!’ the voice repeats, even louder now. ‘It’s me. PERSEPHONE.’

I put down my knife and follow the sound, which is coming from the front of the house. Nugget is at my heels. Mrs Nguyen had dropped the little monster off a few hours earlier and she hadn’t left my side.

‘For pity’s sake, child, I know it’s you. Hold your horses, would you?’

I walk into my bedroom. I’d left my bedroom window open a crack for fresh air. Persephone is sitting on one of my wrought-iron chairs, her face pressed up to the open window. ‘How did you know?’

‘The options weren’t exactly endless,’ I tell her. ‘There’s also the fact that, despite multiple warnings, you continue to call me Elsa.’ I slide the window open a little farther with my good hand.

‘How is your hand?’

‘My wrist,’ I say. ‘It’s fine. Makes getting dressed a little difficult though.’

Persephone nods, though her gaze is far away.

‘What is it, child?’

‘Why did those people spray you with blood?’

I take a moment. ‘I suppose they don’t like me.’

‘But they don’t even know you!’

I sigh. ‘Sometimes we form judgements about people we don’t know. I do it. You probably do it too.’

‘But I don’t squirt them with blood,’ Persephone says.

‘No,’ I agree. ‘Nor do I.’

‘Maybe we should start?’ Persephone grins.

I snort. ‘Yes. Perhaps we should.’

Persephone’s grin remains for several seconds and I can tell she’s imagining squirting people with blood. I find myself doing the same. Joan, for example, would be fun to take down with a water pistol. Her nephew would have a field day with the legal letters after that.

‘My mum says I’m not supposed to bother you anymore,’ Persephone says quietly.

I sit on the bed. ‘Yes, she told me that too.’

‘But I’m not bothering you, am I?’

I feel something move in my chest. ‘No, child.’

‘I just thought . . . since I was lonely with no one to play with, you might be lonely too.’

Much has been made of my above-average strength in my life, but I don’t think I’ve ever needed to exercise as much strength as I do right now, to stop myself from weeping.

‘What about kids from school?’ I ask. ‘Why don’t you play with them?’

Persephone’s face lights up at this. ‘Actually, I made a friend at school today. A new girl. Her name’s Delly.’

‘Delly,’ I repeat. ‘Short for . . . Delilah?’

‘No, just Delly.’

It takes a herculean effort not to let my smile falter at the absurdity of a child called Delly. ‘Well, great.’

‘I asked Mum if I could ask Delly over after school one day, but she said no because she has to work.’

She starts picking at the chipped paint on my windowsill and I put a hand on hers to stop her. She misunderstands the gesture and grips my hand in her own.

‘But she doesn’t go to work until later!’ Her voice becomes whiny. ‘Delly’s mum could pick her up before dinner!’

‘You’ll have to speak to your mother about that, darling.’

Persephone is quiet for a moment. I find myself wondering what time Roxanne goes to work.

‘Persephone? Dinner!’

The child and I both startle at the sound of Roxanne’s voice. We immediately drop hands. ‘Coming, Mum!’

She turns back to me, uncharacteristically shy. ‘I liked it when you called me darling, Elsie.’

‘Well,’ I say. ‘Keep calling me Elsie and I might do it again.’

33

I am putting on my revitalising face cream – an exercise as fruitless as ironing crepe paper – when I hear the pounding of a fist against a door. I glance at the clock on my wall – 11:02 pm. I'm irritated to realise that my reaction is fear rather than annoyance. I hadn't appreciated what a privilege it had been, not feeling fear.

I part my curtain an inch. Outside, Roxanne's motion sensor light flickers on. A man stands at her front door. Tall, dark hair, broad shoulders. From the look of him – jeans, fitted jumper, tattoo peeking above the collar – he's one of Roxanne's gentleman callers. A late-night delivery, if you will. A booty call.

Shamelessly, I squint through the darkness for a better look. The man's attractive, in a brooding, brothel-door kind of way. Roxanne probably summoned him on one of those apps the young people use. She probably entered in his measurements and he appeared like magic. Tap, tap, and he arrives at your doorstep. Like pizza. Or syphilis.

Across the street, Joan's nose is pressed to her window. Nosy old bat. I can't blame her. We take our entertainment where we can get it. If Daphne were here, she'd be making popcorn.

He pounds again. Still no answer. She's certainly making him wait. I'll say this – it's bold, inviting a man over while your child sleeps in the next room. But I suppose single mothers take their chances when they can. Frankly, I'd have chosen a good night's sleep.

I'm drawing the curtain when a hallway light clicks on. Ah, she's letting him in. Showtime.

'So you are home!' the man yells. His voice cracks the silence like a whip. 'Get. Out. Here. Now.'

Oh dear. Not a booty call, then.

I make eyes at Joan who stares back blankly. Peter's house is in darkness, of course. I wonder if I should call him. Call me old-fashioned, but it feels to me like the kind of thing that a man should take care of. I may be progressive for my age, but since women still have to carry the burden of everything else, the least men can do is take out the trash and deal with late-night male visitors! But Peter's house remains in darkness. Probably dosed up on knock-off sleeping pills from Aldi.

I'll call the police, I decide. Women can do that, I suppose. They may be the least responsive unit in Victoria, but they might make haste if they learn a man is staking out a house with a child in residence. But just as I'm about to withdraw from the window in search of my phone, Roxanne's front door opens and my stomach drops like a stone. There, in a pair of pale blue shortie pyjamas, holding a small yellow comforter blanket, is Persephone.

Jesus, Mary and Joseph.

I grab my dressing-gown on my way out the door. Nugget, who'd been asleep on the hallway floorboards, scampers after me. Perhaps for once, the little mongrel will be of some use? As I charge across the cobblestones, I notice the faces of Mr and Mrs Nguyen in their front window. Just watching. *Thanks, neighbours*.

'Where is your mother?' I hear the man ask Persephone.

She blinks into the light, curls wild around her head like a halo. It's the first time I've seen her look small.

'Who are you?' she says, before spotting me over his shoulder. 'Elsa!'

'Hello, child,' I manage. My voice shakes, but I'll blame that on old age.

The man turns. He looks familiar. Of course he does. It's the bloody Italian Stallion.

'I remember you,' he says, eyeing my bare feet, nightie and the dog like I'm the lunatic.

'You'll let me past,' I say crisply. 'I'm the babysitter. I need to be inside.'

'Then why are you out here?'

‘I live across the lane,’ I improvise. ‘Popped home for my dressing-gown. You let me past.’

When he doesn’t budge, I weigh my options. Go home and call the cops, or stay and risk whatever he’s planning. I don’t love either.

‘Sir,’ I say. ‘In case you haven’t noticed, every window on this lane has a nose pressed to it. Joan’s probably already called the police. She calls them if a bin is put out early. We’re the most-policed street in Bayside, thanks to her.’

He glances from window to window – to Joan, to the Nguyens. Still nothing from Peter. I’ll let him have it tomorrow. And then, blessedly, a siren wails in the distance. Could be a fire truck, a garbage truck, or the bloody ice-cream van – but it’s enough. The man steps forward and peers down the lane.

I don’t waste any time. I surge forward, grab Persephone’s arm, and drag her inside. Nugget makes it inside a second before the door slams shut. Immediately Persephone throws her arms around me and starts to cry. And damn it, I do too. Just a little.

34

THEN

Billy was found in the bushes at the bottom of the concrete stairs that led to the beach parking lot. He was semi-conscious when the group of swimmers found him – talking, but not making much sense. He didn't remember what happened. He didn't know his last name.

Someone called an ambulance and he was taken to Alfred Hospital. There, we were told, he was put into an induced coma with a suspected brain injury. While this meant no one had any answers, it didn't stop everyone from pointing the finger at me.

'She was in love with him. She tried to kiss him and he rejected her. Big mistake, Billy.'

'Apparently people saw her push him from the top of the stairs.'

'Mad Mabel strikes again.'

I was used to being an outcast, but this was different. Rather than being someone to ignore, or disdain, now I was someone to be reviled. Someone, perhaps, even to fear.

I don't know what I would have done without Daphne. She was by my side all day that first day back after Billy was found. Anytime anyone made a comment she practically leapt out of her skin in her desperation to defend me.

'Were you there, Eileen? Then how do you know what happened?'

'You seem very sure of yourself, Rosalie. Got something to hide?'

No one paid her any attention, but it was nice, having someone on my side for once.

After school, we went to the library. Obviously, we had no desire to hang out at the beach anymore, and we didn't fancy wandering the streets, so it seemed like a good option.

Ness was organising books on the book cart as we walked in, and she waved at us. We waved back and then I guided Daphne to the back corner where the beanbags were. This was where I liked to sit.

'Will we borrow books?' Daphne said. 'Or stay and read for a bit?'

'Actually,' I said, 'I want to show you something. My favourite book.' I found it on the shelf easily, having borrowed it so many times before. 'It's *Anne of Green Gables*. Do you know it?'

'Do I know it?' Daphne exclaimed, loud enough that a woman turned around and shushed us. 'Corsets I do. Redheaded orphan girl is adopted and goes to live in a whimsical Canadian town? Then falls in love with that dreamy boy Gilbert Blythe? Marvellous book.'

'Isn't it? But the best part is Anne finding her bosom friend . . .'

'Diana Barry!' Daphne exclaimed.

A cranky librarian popped her head around the corner and glared at us. We waved our apologies.

'So you've read it?' I said. 'I was going to recommend it to you.'

'I'll read it again,' Daphne said, taking the book out of my hands. Then she frowned. 'Remind me, didn't Anne and Diana have a little ceremony? Where they declared to always be friends?'

I nodded. I knew the scene by heart.

Daphne reached for my hands. 'Shall we do it?'

I tried to act nonchalant. But my heart was racing. 'All right.'

'Do you know what Anne and Diana said?'

I pretended to think about it before I nodded, but of course I knew exactly what they said. I knew it verbatim. Truth be told, I probably could have recited any part of the book verbatim, but this part, I definitely could.

'Ready?' I said.

Daphne nodded.

‘I solemnly swear to be faithful to my bosom friend, Daphne Barton, as long as the sun and moon shall endure,’ I said, staring into her clear eyes. ‘Now you say it and put my name in.’

‘I solemnly swear to be faithful to my bosom friend, Mabel Waller, as long as the sun and moon shall endure.’

I was embarrassed by the tears that appeared in my eyes, until I saw the tears in Daphne’s. She laughed at our silliness, which started people shushing from across the room, which only made her laugh louder. I snorted. She farted. Then Daphne threw her arms around my neck.

There was a lot of stuff going on, and in many ways, my life had never been worse. And yet, when I look back, there’s no question that it was the happiest moment of my life.

35

Two days after Billy's accident, Daphne and I were in the school bike shed. It was the end of the day, and it was the first time I'd ridden my Huffy Cruiser since my accident.

The bike shed had mostly emptied out. Daphne and I had stayed hidden in the school library like criminals until most of the kids had left. After managing to avoid confrontations all day, I was eager to finish the day that way.

I was bent over, unchaining my bike, when I heard footsteps approaching.

'Mabel?'

I stood straight.

Christos was leaning against the doorway. His tie was loose, his hands were tucked casually in the pockets of his navy school blazer. His hair, usually neatly slicked into place, had become ruffled during the day and a curl or two had sprung up by his ears.

'God, he's dreamy,' Daphne whispered.

'Shhhh!' I said, turning back to my bike. I didn't want to look at him. I didn't want to look at the twins or Fred or anyone who'd seen what had gone down at the bonfire. I felt like they'd seen me naked. But worse. They knew about Kitty. They saw how I reacted to Billy's question. I was sure they all believed the worst about Billy's accident.

'I've been looking for you all day,' he said.

I stood, holding my bike by the handles. Daphne held her bike the same way. I thought she might take her bike and wait outside, or at least move a short distance away to give the illusion of giving us privacy. But she didn't budge.

'Why? More tall jokes?'

Christos smiled. ‘No. But if you have any, I’d listen.’

I rolled my eyes. ‘Sorry. Wouldn’t want to talk down to you.’

He laughed. ‘You’re funny, you know that? Not many girls are funny.’

‘Hey!’ Daphne cried.

‘It’s true,’ I said. ‘At least not a lot of the girls we know.’

‘It’s nice,’ Christos said. ‘Anyway, I was looking for you because I wanted to apologise.’

‘Apologise?’ Daphne cried. I gave her a look. ‘Sorry,’ she said, ‘pretend I’m not here.’

‘Why do you want to apologise?’ I asked.

‘I’d heard that your mother had passed away, but I had no idea about your sister. What Billy said was really low. I probably shouldn’t say that, given what happened to him, but it’s the truth.’

Daphne and I exchanged bewildered looks. Christos was apologising to me? I wasn’t sure anyone had ever apologised to me before.

‘Also, I’m sorry I didn’t step in when Billy kissed you. You clearly didn’t want him to. My mother taught me better than that.’

Daphne’s eyebrows had disappeared into her hairline.

‘And, for what it’s worth, I’ve told everyone that you didn’t do anything to Billy. That said, if you did do something to him, I wouldn’t blame you. It would be a community service.’

I smiled.

He started unchaining his own bike.

‘Anyway, I’m heading your way, want to ride home together?’

‘Yes,’ Daphne said, nudging me forward. ‘You do.’

I frowned at her.

‘Don’t worry about me,’ she said. ‘Go on! Off with you. Christos is waiting.’

I hesitated only a second. ‘All right,’ I said. ‘Sure. Why not?’

For some reason or another, Christos and I never got on our bikes. Instead, we pushed them as we walked along. I was grateful that Christos seemed to

be a talker. He kept conversation going easily – not with as much intensity as Daphne did, but in a comforting way that allowed me to relax.

'My whole family calls my uncle Beanstalk,' Christos was saying, guiding his bike casually with one hand, 'because he's tall. I thought it was a funny nickname. I definitely didn't mean anything like Billy suggested.'

I had no idea what to say to that, so I just nodded.

'I think he likes you, for what it's worth. Billy, I mean.'

'Nonsense. Are you crazy?'

'Nope.'

'Why would you say that?'

'Because he wanted to play spin the bottle the moment you came up at the beach. I'm sure you know that we hadn't been playing that before you arrived.'

'Of course I knew.'

'Because you're smart. Which is one of the things he likes about you. Billy, in case you hadn't noticed, isn't.'

I rolled my eyes, but I could feel the heat creeping up my neck. We continued walking along.

'I get it,' Christos said after a while. 'I'm no genius, and I like the smart girls too. I think it's an evolutionary thing, for our survival. If we're not smart, we have to bag a smart girl.'

'I doubt he'll be bagging anyone now,' I said.

He laughed. 'Yes, I think you're right.'

We walked a little farther in silence. Then, as we turned the corner, I asked: 'Do they really believe I hurt Billy? And my mother? And my baby sister?'

Christos shrugged. 'I have no idea what people believe. But I would guess they don't care if you did or not.'

'Then why –'

'For whatever reason, you're the common enemy. People need one. For bonding. And for keeping themselves out of the firing line. Also evolutionary, I think.' This time he didn't laugh. 'But very unfair.'

We'd reached the point where I needed to turn left to go to my place, and Christos needed to continue straight.

'You're smarter than you think, Christos,' I said.

He smiled shyly. 'If it makes a difference, Mabel, I don't believe you killed anyone. You're not a killer. It's as obvious as the nose on your face.'

His brown eyes were so full of compassion, I had to look away.

'See you at school,' I said.

I started wheeling my bike toward my house. I'd only walked a few paces when he called out to me.

'Mabel?'

I turned around.

'If Billy survives, and you do decide to kill him? No one will hear it from me.'

He held up his hand in a Scout's honour. And, despite all odds, I found myself chuckling the rest of the way home.

36

It was standing room only at St Mary's church. The pews were packed tightly with women, older folks, families – all with hands folded, eyes staring at the altar, some bored, some entirely hypnotised. The room reeked of furniture polish, perfume and Brylcreem; the stained-glass windows threw strange, fractured patterns across the wooden floor.

I stood just inside the side double doors, behind the baptismal font and some older kids. It felt prudent to stay out of people's eyeline.

Billy's accident was all anyone could talk about. Rumour had it that he would be brought out of his coma any day now, and only then would they know if he had permanent brain damage. Mr and Mrs Harris, Johnny and Fred sat in the front row, heads bowed. His name would be mentioned, no doubt, during the time prayers were offered to the ill and deceased. There had been a vigil last night where people in the parish had been invited to say the rosary and light candles.

I'd heard the whispers on my way in, from parents and children alike. *There she is. Can you believe she turned up? The audacity of it.* I hadn't wanted to come, obviously, but Cess had insisted.

'You've nothing to be ashamed of, Mabel. You'll come to Mass with your head held high.'

And so I came, but I stopped short of sitting among the parishioners. From my spot at the back, though, I had a good view. I was searching the pews for Daphne when I spotted the back of a familiar head. I looked away – which was ridiculous, as it was the back of his head. But he'd been on my mind a lot since the day on the beach – during a quiet moment in class, or when I lay in bed at night. I wasn't sure what to make of these thoughts, nor did I have any expectations that they would come to anything; all I knew was that they kept creeping in. I had, I suspected, my first crush.

Mass had only just started when he absented himself from the third row to offer his seat to Mrs Gregory, who'd arrived late. I averted my gaze as he strolled toward me at the side door, but when he tapped my elbow and pointed outside, I had no choice but to look him in the eye.

'Outside,' he said.

I assumed there was an errand in need of doing. It wasn't uncommon for a child or two to be sent to the presbytery during Mass to collect boxes of flyers about parish events that needed to be distributed at the end of Mass. Given my size and strength, I was a popular candidate for these sorts of jobs. It was also possible, I supposed, that the Harrises had spotted me, and I was being asked to leave.

There were enough possibilities that I simply nodded and followed. We didn't talk, and no one paid us any attention as we slipped out the side door, down the church steps, and around the back to a little nook that was hidden from the view of the street. It was the same nook where Frank Sweeney and Geraldine Hobbs famously kissed after midnight Mass on Christmas Eve. I registered this fact with interest but without notions. I was fourteen years old, a social pariah. We may have been spending time together, but the idea that he – or anyone – would want to kiss me was absurd.

Except . . . apparently, it wasn't.

It happened so fast. One moment we were walking with purpose, the next, he stopped, catching the crook of my elbow so I spun to face him. He smiled as he walked me slowly backward into the nook.

It was so different from my kiss with Billy. I felt hyperaware of everything, the warmth of his mouth, the soft bump of his teeth against mine. His hands – first on my sides, then my hips. His warm chest, pressed against me; my cold back, pressed against the wall of the brick church. It was the strangest feeling. Almost like I was a performer in a show, watching myself from the outside. I wondered how I looked to him, how I felt. It felt likely, given the throaty, satisfied noises that emanated from him, that I looked and felt good.

It felt like it went on forever. Three days, three weeks. Then, it was over.

‘You liked that,’ he said. Not a question. No inflection, no doubt. There was something about his confidence. I nodded stupidly.

He grinned at me. ‘Same time next week?’

I nodded again. ‘Yes, Mr Loukas,’ I said.

37

NOW

Persephone grips me tightly around my waist. I find myself holding very still, taking in the sensation of it – the rare, unexpected comfort of another person's touch. Her cheek presses against my stomach, damp and hot with tears. She is trembling. I am trembling too. Nugget runs in circles around us both.

'There, there, child,' I say, my voice softer than I expect. 'It's all right. Everything's all right.'

I smooth a hand over her hair. 'Where's your mother?'

'I don't know,' she says, sniffling. 'I looked in her room, but she wasn't in her bed.'

'Which one is Mum's room?'

Persephone points, and I walk to the door and flick on the light. The bed is an unmade island of rumpled sheets. A pile of folded laundry is balanced on a chair in the corner. No sign of Roxanne. I even check the cupboards and under the bed just to be sure.

'Let's check the rest of the house,' I say.

There are not a lot of places to look. We check Persephone's room, the bathroom, kitchen, laundry and courtyard.

'Right,' I say. 'She's definitely not here.'

'Told you.' A trace of smugness comes to her tearstained face. In light of her recent trauma, I let it go.

'Has she ever left you home alone before?' I ask.

Persephone considers this. ‘I don’t think so.’

‘Where is the phone?’

‘I don’t have one,’ she says. ‘Mum has one, but it’s not on charge. She must have taken it.’

‘What about the landline?’ I ask.

Persephone screws up her face. ‘The what-line?’

I sigh. ‘I need to go home and get my phone.’

‘Why?’

‘Because we need to call the police.’

‘No!’ Persephone cries. Her tears are instant, bubbling over like a shaken soda bottle. ‘Please, Elsa. You can’t call the police. They will arrest my mum for leaving me home alone.’

She clings to my forearms, her fingers clutching with surprising strength. Her eyes are wide and pleading.

I sigh. ‘Persephone, we need the police to come and arrest that man.’

‘But he’s gone! Can’t we just wait for Mummy to get home?’

I feel a headache coming on. I’m too old to exercise this kind of judgement call so late at night.

‘Wait there,’ I tell her and go to the front room, peering out the window.

The neighbours’ faces have disappeared from their windows, the sirens have receded. There’s no sign of the Italian Stallion.

I return to the front door and check that it’s locked, then push a chair in front of it.

‘Is he gone?’ Persephone asks, yawning.

‘It appears so,’ I say. ‘Come on, why don’t you show me your room?’

Persephone’s room is a mirror image of mine, with its original fireplace and large sash window looking out onto the street. But where mine is filled with old books and fading photographs, hers is alive with colour – walls covered in butterfly decals, glow-in-the-dark stars dotting the ceiling like a night sky. It’s sparsely furnished, just a single bed with pale pink linen, and an armchair in the corner.

I sink into it, expecting her to hop into bed. Instead, she clambers onto my lap, her limbs all awkward angles. I feel like I’m cuddling a baby goat.

Her head rests against my shoulder, warm and feather-light. I have a strange sensation that I might cry.

'Did you know that man?' I ask her.

'No.'

'In that case,' I say lightly, 'I'd say he's just some silly fellow. Probably had too many drinks and knocked on the wrong door.'

'But he asked for Mum.'

'Yes,' I say. 'Yes, that's true.'

She yawns deeply, and her body becomes slack. 'Elsa, will you stay here? Until my mum gets home?'

I know Roxanne told me she thought it was best if Persephone didn't spend time with me, but I don't see what other option I have, short of leaving the child alone in the house after what had happened.

'I suppose I'll have to.'

'Pinkie promise?'

She holds out her baby finger, forcibly entangling it with mine.

'What on earth are you doing?'

'Say: pinkie promise,' Persephone instructs, her tone firm despite the sleep creeping into her voice.

For the love of God.

'Pinkie promise.' I remove my finger. 'Now I think it's time you went to bed.'

I have to push her into a standing position, then she scurries over to her bed and slips under the covers.

'Want to hop in?' she asks me.

'No,' I say. 'The chair will do fine.'

'Mummy hops in with me.'

'Well,' I say, adjusting my nightie as I settle into the chair. 'I'm not Mummy.'

I flick off the light and lean back into the armchair, which is surprisingly comfy. The tension in my temples eases just a little as I let my eyelids close.

Persephone lies on her side, her hands steepled beneath her cheek, eyes fluttering closed.

‘I love you, Elsa,’ she murmurs sleepily.

I open my eyes and see that she’s watching me in the darkness. For pity’s sake.

‘Sleep well, child.’

Her eyes close, and her breath evens out. Only then do I allow myself the smallest of smiles.

38

Keys rattle in the lock, jolting me from sleep. For a moment, I forget where I am. But as the front door creaks open, instinct takes over and I shoot to my feet, running out of the room with impressive speed for an elderly woman. Nugget, who'd been asleep in the hallway, also leaps up and starts barking maniacally.

By the time I get there, Roxanne is peering around the door which is blocked by the chair.

'What the –?'

The dog is still barking. I can't think straight. 'Nugget, would you knock that off?'

By some miracle, she does. I move the chair from the door and Roxanne comes inside.

Roxanne looks bewildered. 'Elsie? What are you doing here?'

'Mama?'

From where we stand we have a clear view to Persephone's room, so when we look we see her sitting up in bed, rubbing her eyes. Her voice is thick with sleep.

'Hi, baby.' Roxanne walks into Persephone's room and sits at her bedside, smoothing a hand over her daughter's hair. 'Sorry I woke you. I wasn't expecting to see Elsie, and it gave me a fright.'

Persephone lies back down. 'A man came here. Elsie protected me. I asked her to stay with me until you got home.'

The air shifts. It's hard to see Roxanne's expression in the dark, but I can tell from the way her spine straightens that this isn't just a misunderstanding. She meets my eye, then quickly looks away.

'Well,' she says, her voice carefully level, 'I'm home now. So why don't you go back to sleep?'

She pulls Persephone's quilt up over her shoulders. I wait for Roxanne to get up but she stays there, watching her daughter sleep. It continues long enough that I leave the room, with Nugget at my heel, and wait for her in the kitchen.

Roxanne's kitchen is laid out identically to mine – cabinets and stove against the wall, a long low island bench in front, no window – though this one has been renovated more recently, the '80s or '90s judging by the peach laminate cabinetry. Her fridge – which is covered in notices from Persephone's school and a photograph of the child that looks to be a couple of years old – is in need of a new seal. It sags open enough that the interior light shines through the crack.

I'm contemplating putting the kettle on when Roxanne arrives in the kitchen.

'If you'll allow me to explain,' I start, and then Roxanne puts her arms around me. I stop.

'Thank you. If something had happened to her . . . I don't know if I could have survived it.'

'All right.' I pat her back awkwardly. I'm still in my nightie and bare feet. 'I've had just about enough hugs for one day.'

She lets me go. Her eyes are watery and she looks bone-tired. 'You must think I'm a monster, leaving her at home alone at night.'

I pull out a stool from the island bench and sit. 'I don't think you're a monster,' I say. 'I'd possibly say that you had poor judgement –'

'And you'd be right to say that. I showed incredibly poor judgement, leaving Persephone home alone. I have no excuse, other than that I was desperate.'

'Where were you, Roxanne?'

She sits on the stool beside me. 'At work.'

'At *work*?'

'I clean office buildings. My shift starts late at night when everyone's gone home. The money is really good – one or two nights a week keeps the

wolves from the door. But if I pay a babysitter overnight rates, I end up with nothing.' She doesn't look at me. Her expression is blank. 'I told myself if I put her to bed before I left and then got home before she woke up, it would be fine. It's a safe little laneway.' She peters off. 'Anyway. It was stupid.'

Yes, I think. It was very stupid. But who hasn't done something stupid in their life?

'Well,' I say. 'What's done is done.'

She nods, her eyes closed. Then she looks over at me. 'The man. Tell me about him. What did he look like?'

'Tall, dark hair. I saw him the other day, hanging around. I called him the Italian Stallion. Only in my head, obviously. I heard a loud knock just after eleven and I looked out the window and saw Persephone open the door.'

Roxanne closes her eyes. 'I told her never to answer the door.'

'She was half asleep, I doubt she thought about what she was doing. Besides, he wasn't going anywhere.'

'What did you do?'

'I came out in my nightie and said I was the babysitter, that I'd just popped home to get my bathrobe. It took a bit of doing, but I finally convinced him that if he didn't leave, the police would come.'

Roxanne lowers her forehead to the counter.

'You're tired,' I tell her. 'So am I. Why don't we all get some sleep and we can talk more in the morning, if you'd like to.'

She lifts her head, but her eyes remain closed. 'All right. Good idea.'

I slide off my stool. 'Just one question before I go.'

She exhales slowly. 'Shoot.'

'Would you like me to kill him?'

Roxanne opens her eyes. 'Could you make it painful?'

'I'm Mad Mabel,' I say, all mock-offended. Then I smile. 'Painful deaths are my specialty.'

39

I'm still in bed the next morning when there's a knock at the door, though it's after 9 am. I'd only got a couple of hours of sleep in Persephone's chair the previous night, so I'd allowed myself a lie-in.

Nugget, who had the audacity to jump onto my bed during the night, rouses and starts yapping with such furore her little legs lift off the ground.

'Will you shut up for once in your life?' I say, putting a hand on her head. It has the desired effect and she stops. 'Shh. Good girl.'

I swing my legs out of bed and am looking around for my dressing-gown when Daphne, impatient, lets herself in with her key.

'There you are,' she exclaims, appearing in my doorway. 'Thought you might have died.'

'No such luck.'

She lifts her glasses – which are cobalt blue today, to match her mohair roll-neck jumper – from around her neck and balances them on her nose. 'You look dreadful. Why are you still in bed?' she says. 'Are you ill?'

'Pop the kettle on,' I tell her. 'Have I got a story for you.'

It's rather novel and exciting to have a story to tell Daphne – one that doesn't include her. So much of our lives have been intertwined that it's rare there is something that she doesn't know about. She seems just as delighted as me.

'Goodness gracious!' she exclaims. 'Just when we think we're ready to shrivel up and die, life gets exciting again. Whatever next?'

'Who knows?' I say, and then my washing machine plays its little song, making it clear that next, I have to hang out my laundry.

We had just hauled the washing basket out to the clothesline when there is another knock at the door.

Daphne grips her chest. ‘The Italian Stallion?’ she whispers, her eyes bulging. ‘Better get a baseball bat.’

‘For pity’s sake,’ I say. ‘It’s not the Italian Stallion. Besides, I don’t have a baseball bat.’

I grab the broom.

But it’s Roxanne at the door.

‘Do you have a minute?’ she asks.

‘We’re elderly ladies,’ Daphne cries. ‘We have all day.’

We invite her in and offer her a cup of tea. She declines the tea and instead joins us in the courtyard. I am surprised and a little charmed when she starts helping to hang the clothes.

‘Did you contact the police?’ I ask.

She nods, shaking out a pair of slacks and pegging them by the hems.

‘And? What did they say?’

‘They said I could go down to the station and give a statement.’

‘All right.’ I search the basket for my smalls. As nice as she is, I’m sure that Roxanne could do without hanging out my undergarments. ‘When are you going to do that?’

‘I’m not.’

I gasp.

‘Why the dickens not?’ Daphne asks.

‘There’s no point. I already have an AVO against Shane.’

‘An AV what?’ I peg a bra at the back of the line, out of the way.

‘An apprehended violence order. A restraining order, essentially. But it isn’t worth the paper it’s written on. Every time he breaches it, I go to the police and make a report and nothing happens. Every time we move, Shane always finds us.’

Roxanne digs into the basket and stands up holding a pair of giant beige underpants. Must have missed those. She hangs them dutifully, using three pegs. Daphne snickers.

‘And Shane is . . . ?’

‘Persephone’s father.’

‘Ah,’ I say. ‘And . . . I take it he was violent?’

She nods.

‘Scumbag,’ I say.

‘Motherfucker,’ Daphne cries.

‘Yes,’ Roxanne agrees. She reaches for the last item in the basket, my cream blouse, shakes it out and hangs it.

‘So what now?’ I ask. ‘Will you have to move?’

She laughs, without humour. ‘This is my sixth move since I left him. He still found me. Where do I go now? The moon?’

I collect the basket and we go inside. In the back room, she sits on my sofa and pulls a cushion into her lap. I offer her tea again and she declines, so I bring her a glass of water and put it on a coaster on the coffee table.

I sit in the armchair. ‘How did you meet him?’ I’m prying, which is probably rude, but what the hell? I’m curious.

‘Shane and I met when he was injured in a car accident. I was twenty-three and he was thirty-three. I was working as a nurse at the local hospital in a small town outside of Sydney. I’d just lost my mother. Ovarian cancer. My father had never been in the picture. I had a few cousins, but none lived nearby. My community was mostly the nurses at work. Anyway, Shane was in a bad way – broken ribs, black eyes, bruises all over him. I fixed him up and he asked me out to dinner. Shane was the charming sort, believe it or not.’

She picks up the glass of water from the coffee table and takes a sip. Then she puts it back down. ‘He came on very strong, with romantic gestures, like surprise weekends away, flowers, gifts. And the sex, *my God*. He was a *man*, if you know what I mean.’

‘I do indeed,’ I say.

Daphne chuckles.

Roxanne blinks. ‘Anyway . . . I was renting an apartment in town when we met. A few months after we’d started dating, I went to Sydney for the weekend for a friend’s birthday and returned to find he’d packed up my things and moved them into his house.’

‘Uh-oh.’

She nods. ‘Red flag, I know. But part of me liked it. I had no family and in a way it made me feel safe, to have someone. What an idiot.’

‘Hindsight,’ I remind her, ‘is twenty-twenty.’

‘I guess. But there were other signs along the way that I should have paid attention to. Like . . . he didn’t give me a key to his house. The one he’d called *my* house. He said I could just come and go with him, or, if I went out without him, wait for him to get home to let me back in.’

‘Sounds very odd,’ Daphne says.

‘That was just the beginning. Next thing I knew he’d got rid of my car! I went into the garage one day and it was gone. He said it wasn’t safe, and in fairness to him, he was probably right. It was an old bomb – the only thing I could afford. He told me he got his uncle to tow it to the junkyard and that he’d ordered me another one. A Mercedes! I was so excited about the Mercedes that I didn’t complain about his dumping my car. But the Mercedes never arrived. It was hard to object since he drove me to work and back every day.’

‘The controlling type,’ Daphne says. ‘Probably terrified you’d catch the eye of another fellow.’

Roxanne picks up her water glass again but doesn’t drink. ‘He always managed to make everything sound romantic and as though it was *for* me. He said he would always take care of me, and I liked the sound of that. But I became quite isolated. And before I could address it, I was pregnant with Persephone. You can see the trajectory I was on. Trapped, reliant on a man. Powerless.’

I shake my head. ‘Exactly how he wanted it.’

She nods. ‘The first time he hit me was when I got a taxi to a prenatal appointment. He was meant to drive me but he couldn’t so he told me to reschedule. But there was no reason I couldn’t go. So I called a taxi. I was getting sick of him telling me what to do. When I got home after the appointment he was there. I remember being really annoyed. He’d said he couldn’t make the appointment, so why was he home? I started to ask him about this and he slapped me across the face, hard.’

I look at Daphne. Her eyes are full of tears. Her right hand rests against her right cheek.

'It was a hard slap. It hurt a *lot*. I ran out of the room, but then I didn't know what to do. I couldn't leave.'

'Let me guess,' I say, 'he apologised in the morning and said it would never happen again?'

'Actually, no. He never apologised. He didn't bring it up at all. And I didn't either. I was too afraid. But that was when I started planning to leave. We finally got away when Persephone was six months old. But he keeps coming back.'

'What does he want?' I ask.

She shrugs. 'Control? To punish me for having the audacity to leave him? To feel powerful?'

'Persephone?' I ask. 'Does he want her?'

She contemplates this. 'As far as I can tell, his interest in her is only insofar as it hurts me. He's never attempted to get custody of her or anything. That's one thing to be grateful for, I suppose.'

'Buttnugget,' Daphne mutters. 'Dickweed!'

I give her a look and she stops.

'So what now?' I ask Roxanne.

She looks exhausted. 'Find a new place and hope to hell he doesn't find us. Save some money because moving isn't cheap. I can't do night cleaning anymore, obviously.'

'Can you clean during the day?' I ask.

'I can,' she says, 'and I do. But the night cleaning pays the best.'

We drift into silence. I try to avoid Daphne's gaze but I feel her raising her eyebrows and nodding at me. I sigh.

'What if Persephone stayed here on the nights you worked?' I say, under duress.

Daphne beams. 'What a great idea!'

'I have a spare room,' I continue. 'You could drop her here after she's had her dinner and she could scuttle home in the morning when she wakes up.'

Roxanne stares at me. ‘No. No, I couldn’t ask that of you.’

‘Corsets you could!’ Daphne cries. ‘She insists!’

I roll my eyes. ‘I insist,’ I drone.

‘But . . . you think she’s an irritating little despot!’

I open my mouth to disagree, but her statement is factually accurate. And yet, I’ve always prided myself on the fact that I don’t do things I don’t want to. It makes me infinitely less likeable in the moment, but as I’m not known for my likeability, I figure I don’t have a lot to lose there. For this reason, I know I must mean it when I say:

‘If you’re happy to have Mad Mabel as a babysitter, looking after an irritating little despot is the least I can do.’

I stand in the hallway outside the spare bedroom, a cardboard box in one hand. The door is closed as usual. Even Nugget has learned not to scratch at it. I only go in there occasionally, privately – when no one’s around to see.

I was glad Roxanne agreed to let me watch Persephone. Not because I’m itching to care for a child – God forbid – but because it’s a practical solution to a messy problem. And I am, above all things, a pragmatic woman who likes solutions.

Still, a pulse of unease beats beneath my ribs. If Persephone is going to be staying in that room, there’s some work that needs to be done.

I rest my hand on the doorknob. The house is quiet. I inhale deeply, then push the door open and walk in.

It’s a proper mess. Unlike the rest of my house – tidy, spare, scrubbed within an inch of its life – this room is cluttered and full to bursting. It smells faintly of dust and furniture polish. The wallpaper is faded. The air in the room is stale and unmoving.

And he is everywhere. His face looks out from every surface. Dozens of photographs – some framed, others stuck up with curling Blu Tack – cover the walls and line the dresser, the desk, even the top of an old Singer sewing machine I never use. There he is in the front garden, holding a hose.

Carrying a ladder. Wearing his ridiculous fishing hat, bought on special, of course. Laughing. Always laughing.

It's a shrine, no two ways about it. A shrine to Peter.

It occurs to me that I owe Persephone my thanks. If she'd told anyone what she saw in here, I'd probably have been hauled off to jail, or a home for the insane. But I'm not insane. Despite popular opinion, I never have been. I'm simply . . . alone. Peter has been a bright spot in my little world for quite some time. A fixed point. Someone to care about, from a distance. Someone who, it seems, cares about me . . . even a little. I have no intention of pursuing a relationship with him – heaven forbid. I'd never invite such an opportunity for rejection. But here, in this room of my house, it feels safe to indulge such a fantasy. A fantasy of loving, and of being loved back.

I pop the cardboard box on the floor and sink into the worn chair by the window. I reach for the nearest frame, one of the more recent photos – Peter on his front porch, mug in hand, squinting into the sun – and gently lay it in the box. The next picture follows, and the one after that. My hands are slow, careful, like I'm packing up a person. In a way, I am.

Nugget wanders in and lets out a small sigh before curling up beside the box. I glance down at her. 'Don't look at me like that. It's for the best.'

She closes her eyes. I turn back to the wall and keep going, one picture at a time.

'It's time,' I say quietly. To myself. To Peter. 'Time to put you away.'

40

THEN

‘Where are you off to?’

Cess and Ness were drinking martinis on high stools at the bar in the front room. Cess smoked a cigarette. *Bandstand* with Brian Henderson was playing on the television. A few minutes earlier I’d heard them dancing and laughing.

Cess looked up from her drink. ‘Wow. You look lovely, Mabel.’

I wanted to be coy, to roll my eyes, but I couldn’t pull it off. I’d spent an inordinate amount of time choosing the cream silk blouse with the Peter Pan collar and lace-edged sleeves, the navy circle skirt, white bobby socks and penny loafers.

Cess and Ness were still staring. ‘My goodness. You’ve grown into your looks. You look quite . . .’

‘Striking,’ Ness said.

‘That’s it,’ Cess said. ‘That’s exactly it. Striking.’

‘Really?’ I could barely hide my delight. I even did a twirl. ‘I’m going to the movies.’

‘What fun!’ They were beaming at me. I had the feeling they weren’t on their first martini. ‘With who?’

‘A friend,’ I said, actually coy now. I touched my hair, which I’d curled and pulled into a ponytail.

They exchanged a split-second glance, then Cess whistled, tapping her cigarette ash into the ashtray. ‘A boy *friend*?’

‘Do tell,’ Ness said. ‘What is his name?’

‘Who says it’s a “he”?’ I said.

Cess and Ness chortled. ‘Those rosy cheeks do, darling,’ Ness said.

I was glad Cess and Ness were having a few drinks, because the truth was, I didn’t want to tell them who I was seeing. Nor did I want them to realise that I wasn’t, in fact, going to the movies. Cess and Ness were fairly liberal, but I suspected they’d have more than a few questions if I told them I was going to Mr Loukas’s house.

‘Sooo,’ Cess said. ‘Who is it? Or is it a secret?’

I had an idea. ‘Let’s just say I’m going to see my Gilbert.’

Ness let out a squeal. ‘I love it. Your very own Gilbert Blythe! And you are the most perfect Anne Shirley!’

‘You two and that book!’ Cess said, rolling her eyes. ‘You just make sure Gilbert gets you home by ten, all right, Anne Shirley?’

‘I will. I promise.’

‘Is that your mother’s scarf?’ Cess said, as I turned to leave.

I reached up to my throat, grasping it. I’d seen it in my drawer and knotted it around my neck on a whim. Suddenly I felt self-conscious. ‘Is it . . . okay?’

Cess put out her cigarette and slid off her stool. ‘It needs to be a little more to the side. Let me just . . .’ She came and stood in front of me and untied it and re-knotted the scarf while I stood there like a mannequin, breathing in Chanel No. 5 and cigarettes. ‘There. Suits you.’

I checked my reflection in the mirror above the fireplace. Cess had done a good job.

‘Right then,’ Cess said. ‘Don’t keep Gilbert waiting on our account!’

I gathered my cardigan and bag, and they waved me off.

They didn’t have to worry about me keeping Mr Loukas waiting. I couldn’t wait.

After that night, Mr Loukas and I met up regularly. We had our usual places. At his house, if the coast was clear. In the shed at school where the

sporting equipment was kept. In that little nook at the back of St Mary's.

I'd read about romance in novels, of course. But it was different in real life. Books couldn't fully capture the potency of a look that lasted a beat too long or describe the burn of a hand brushing past you in a room full of people.

He told me he was in love with me. That he'd never felt that before. I wasn't sure if it was true. Even if it wasn't, I won't deny that hearing it was like a drug. No matter how often he said it, I wanted it more.

No one had ever told me they were in love with me before. No one had ever told me they loved me. Even people who I believed loved me – my mother, Cess, Daphne – didn't actually say the words.

It had never bothered me. Words were just that – words. But it turned out there was something pretty special about those particular words. And I would have done just about anything to hear them again.

41

It's true what they say about getting the things you always wanted – it's never what it's cracked up to be. I'd spent my entire childhood yearning for a best friend. I'd never even bothered yearning for a lover. Suddenly I had both. It was hard to fathom that someone in my position could ever feel anything other than joy. And so, it came as a surprise to me that, on occasion, I did feel bored.

'Want to go to the beach?' Daphne said.

It was a hot Saturday afternoon, and the bees were having a fine old time buzzing around in Mum's lavender. Daphne and I lay on our backs on the grass in the shade of the oak tree.

'Nah,' I said.

'We could have a hit of tennis?'

'Just the two of us? Boring.'

I knew I was being difficult, but the heat made me irritable and everything Daphne suggested seemed like too much effort. And yet, her spirits would not be dampened.

'We could walk down to the train station?' she suggested.

Back then, the train station, insofar as our interest in it, had very little to do with catching trains. It was a chance to interact with the boys away from the watchful eyes of parents and teachers.

I rolled to face her. 'Are you mad?'

'No. Come on. Billy won't be there, he's still in hospital. You might even see Christos!'

I rolled onto my back. 'So? I don't even like Christos.'

'Oh yeah? Then why are you blushing?'

'I'm not,' I said, but my cheeks felt hot.

‘So if I looked in your diary, I wouldn’t see lovey-dovey stuff about Christos?’

‘No!’ I said. ‘Gross.’

I hadn’t told Daphne about my relationship with Mr Loukas. He had insisted that we keep it between us for now, which made sense, and besides, I had a feeling Daphne would disapprove of the age difference. Anyway, there was something delicious about having a secret. Made it feel even more romantic.

But Daphne wasn’t giving up. I sighed. ‘Fine, we’ll go to the station.’

Daphne jumped up, delighted.

‘But,’ I said, ‘if we’re going to the station . . . maybe we should tart ourselves up a little?’

Daphne scoffed. ‘Nonsense. Look at us! Any boy would be thrilled to have us, just as we are.’

You had to admire her chutzpah.

‘Still,’ I said, ‘it might be nice to put in a little effort, don’t you think?’

She considered this. ‘Do you have any makeup?’

‘Nope.’ I grinned at her. ‘But I know where to find some.’

*

Daphne warmed up quickly to the idea of putting a little effort in before we went to the station. By the time I was sitting at the dressing table in my parents’ bedroom in front of the mirror, she might have even been mistaken for someone who was enjoying herself.

She opened the drawer. ‘This is a beautiful dressing table. You should put it in your room, Mabel.’

My mother’s cosmetics were exactly as she’d left them – Max Factor, Rimmel, Revlon, neatly laid out in rows, next to a zippered bag full of brushes. As Daphne laid them out on the tabletop, the scent of my mother rose into the air, then settled over me – a featherweight cloak of grief and memory.

‘No peeking,’ she said, covering the oval mirrors with a large towel. ‘Wait until I’m finished. I’m going to make you look marvellous, darling.’

Daphne tied a scarf around my hair, then went to work with Mum’s Max Factor Crème Puff Powder, her blush, her lipliner, lipstick. She layered on eyeshadow and bossily told me where to look as she applied several coats of mascara. She tilted my head this way and that, considering me, before digging back into the palate for another colour, or into the drawer for a different brush with which to blot and blend.

‘I know quite a bit about makeup, did you know that?’ she said, as she applied what must have been the fifth coat of lipstick.

It was a blessing that I couldn’t reply. While Daphne professed to know quite a bit about a lot of things, as yet I hadn’t seen this knowledge translate to any sort of skill in any particular area. Proving this point, she picked up a blusher brush and started patting my eyelids with it.

‘There,’ she said, pulling back to admire her work. ‘Now, time for hair.’

It was fair to say that Daphne never did anything by halves. She went to work on my hair, brushing and teasing and pinning and spraying, until my mother’s can of Cedel hairspray ran dry.

It was impossible not to think of my mother as I sat there, surrounded by her scents and her things. It made me sad, but it also felt precious, and intimate. I found myself holding very still, willing it to never end.

‘Right,’ Daphne said finally. ‘Ready to see the new you, darling?’

‘Ready, darling.’

With a flourish, she removed the towel from the mirror. ‘Ta-da!’

For a moment, I just took it in in silence.

My lips caught my eye first. They were shiny and pink and . . . at least twice their normal size.

And my eyes – covered in pearly blue shadow and ringed in black, gloopy liner.

Two bright pink circles sat high on my cheeks.

And my hair. My hair. It had been scraped back off my face and was plastered down flat. It looked – I reached up to touch it – and felt wet.

Behind me, in the mirror, Daphne's face became uncertain. 'I used this stuff.' Daph held up my father's Brylcreem.

Words escaped me.

'It's possible,' Daphne said thoughtfully, 'that I may have gone a little heavy on the blush.'

She pulled a tissue from her sleeve and spat on it. I leapt off the chair.

'What's wrong?'

'I look like a clown!' I exclaimed. 'And my hair. What have you done to my h–'

I couldn't finish the sentence; I was overcome by a propulsive burst of laughter. My stomach muscles spasmed.

Daphne was also laughing. 'Blimey, you're right! You're a clown before it puts on its wig!'

'With two black eyes!'

We fell to the floor, snorting and rolling around like farm animals. When Daphne let out a fart, I thought I might die laughing.

It went on and on – each time one of us got it together, the other set us off again. We laughed so hard and for so long that we didn't hear the front door open, or the heavy footfalls on the stairs. We didn't hear anything at all until he was standing in the doorway.

'What the hell is going on in here?' my father roared.

And just like that, the laughter stopped.

42

NOW

Adeem and Libby arrive promptly at 9 am the next morning.

Libby looks fresh and bright, while Adeem's shirt is buttoned crookedly and the few strands of hair he has bear the telltale snarl of someone who slept with it wet and tried to fix it by adding more water. As for me, I'd had a good night's sleep – unlike two nights before – and I was ready, even eager, for the conversation.

'Did you two drive here together?' I ask.

'I picked Ads up en route,' Libby says. 'Didn't trust him not to be late. He's not a morning person.'

I give him the once-over. 'Indeed.'

As if on cue, he yawns.

'I just put on a pot of coffee,' I tell him, as we all shuffle down my hallway. 'That will sort you out.'

Adeem looks embarrassingly grateful. 'Thanks, Elsie. White with one.'

I decide, without consultation, to leave out the 'one'. He is far too young to become one of those men with a stomach that hangs over his belt.

'Coffee for you, Libby?'

'Tea,' she says. 'Don't worry, I brought my own.'

Libby produces a gold-edged box of loose-leaf green tea and a straining device. I am, naturally, appalled. After the ingenious invention of the tea bag! Only this generation. Next they'll start boiling water on the stove for their bath instead of turning on a hot tap. But each to their own, I suppose.

She makes her own cup of tea because I refuse.

When we all have a hot beverage, we move to the round table. Adeem takes a sip of his coffee, then frowns, perhaps registering the lack of sugar.

‘Well,’ Libby says. ‘We have a lot to catch up on. The last time we saw you, you were attacked.’

‘Indeed.’ I hold up my wrist. ‘Would you like to sign my cast?’

‘We got some footage of the attack,’ Adeem says. ‘With your permission, we thought we could use it in the show.’

‘Ads,’ Libby says. ‘Too soon.’

‘It’s fine,’ I say. ‘I’ve been a sideshow all my life, why not now?’

We talk a little more, then Libby suggests we begin.

‘It is what we’re doing here,’ I say, even though I’d have been just as happy to talk more about Libby and Adeem and what was going on with them. Young people are more interesting than I’d given them credit for, I’ll admit.

Adeem is staring into his coffee now, as if he might see his future in it.

‘If I may,’ Libby says, ‘I’d like to ask some questions about your father.’

I feel my body stiffen. ‘You may.’

‘A lot has been written about your relationship with him,’ Libby says gently.

‘Yes,’ I say. ‘And some of it isn’t too far off the mark. Although, I will say, he was never physically violent with me. He preferred mental to physical torture.’

‘Shall we talk about that?’ Libby says.

‘If we must,’ I say, and Libby reaches for the phone to press Record.

I look at Adeem. ‘I didn’t add sugar. It’s bad for your health.’

The look of betrayal is such that I almost feel bad. Almost.

‘Ready, Elsie?’ Libby says, and I nod.

‘Ready.’

43

THEN

My mother always said my father could silence a room just by entering it. There was no question it was true. But my mother said it as though it were a magical power, which wasn't true. Anyone could silence a room by using fear and intimidation. It was a weak trick of the unskilled, or for those who lacked charm. But I didn't figure that out until years later.

The day he appeared in the doorway after Daphne had given me a makeover, he certainly stunned us into silence. Looming over us in the doorway, my father looked even taller than his six-foot-four stature – tall enough that his head almost touched the top of the doorframe. He'd only been gone a couple of months, and yet it felt like I was looking at a stranger. As far as I was concerned, he belonged in a different world – the world before Mum died.

He took a few steps into the bedroom and put down his suitcase. 'You haven't answered my question, Mabel. What the hell is going on?'

'I . . . I . . .'

'I . . . I . . . I.' Dad adopted a childlike voice in an attempt to impersonate me. 'I look like a tramp?'

My father had always taken every opportunity to make me feel stupid or small. And yet, the petty cruelty of this stunned me to the verge of tears.

Daphne stared at Dad with such pure and utter contempt that for a moment my fear of my father was trumped by fear that Daphne might

attack him. I was considering standing between them when Cess's voice floated up the stairs. 'Elliott? Is that you?'

As she appeared behind my father, I felt my heart rate start to slow. Cess did a double take as she took in my makeover, then turned her attention to Dad. 'It is you. When did you get here?'

She sounded uncharacteristically warm, which had the effect of disarming my father for a second. I saw him notice her, and I registered something vaguely inappropriate about it. She was wearing fitted red and black checked capri pants with a gauzy white silk blouse. I'd once heard my father comment to my mother that Cess's clothes were inviting scandal, but as he contemplated her, he seemed nothing but appreciative.

'A minute ago,' he said, before gesturing toward Daphne and me. 'And look what I find in my bedroom!'

Cess didn't miss a beat. 'Yes, I gave her full permission to spend time in here among her mother's things. It's good for her, while she's grieving. I knew you wouldn't have a problem with it.'

My father scoffed. 'Making herself over like a common whore? Actually, I do have a problem with it.'

'For heaven's sake, Elliott, little girls have played dress-up since the beginning of time, you know that. Mary and I used to do it! In any case, if you want to blame anyone, blame me, not the child.'

My father didn't respond to this; he was distracted by Ness, who by this time had come to investigate what was going on. 'I wondered where everyone was,' she exclaimed.

My father acted as though aliens had entered the room. 'Will anyone else be coming into my bedroom? The postman, perhaps?'

'You know my friend Vanessa, Elliott,' Cess said. 'She's been helping me take care of Mabel while you were away.'

'Is that right?'

'Yes,' Cess said. 'It's no small job, caring for a child who is recovering from an injury and has just lost her mother.'

My father glanced from Cess to Ness and back again. His body had become eerily, utterly still. Cess's tone, I noticed, had become icy.

Something had happened, I sensed. It felt like another conversation was being had, one I didn't totally understand.

Finally, my father spoke. 'You're right,' he said. 'It is a big job, caring for a child. Too big for you to handle. But I'm back now, so there'll be no need for either of you.'

I felt the blood leave my body.

'That's all,' my father said, dismissing her. To me he said, 'Clean up this mess, Mabel, and take that stuff off your face.'

He looked at Cess. 'I'm leaving. I'll give you seven days to pack up your things and get out. When I return I don't want to see any evidence of you.'

With that, he turned and left.

Cess started pacing. Ness sagged against the wall.

I stayed exactly where I was, as if stillness could anchor Cess to the house. As if by holding still I could stop everything in my life from changing yet again.

44

How shockingly unfair it was, being a child. How barbaric, not only to have so little control over your own life, but also to have no control over who was controlling you. Cess and Ness were leaving. My father was coming back. My mother was dead.

I remained in bed all weekend. Daphne came over and chatted without pause for hours while I stared at the wall. Cess made my favourite dinner – her famous chicken and vegetable pie with mash – but even that wasn't enough to summon me to the dinner table, so she left it on a tray outside my bedroom, despite her hard-and-fast rule that all food needed to be consumed at the dinner table.

The grief was all-consuming. It wasn't that life before had been perfect. It had only been a couple of months since my mother died and I still felt the loss of her in my every breath. And yet, in the strange bubble of time I'd spent with Cess, Ness and Daphne, I'd felt safer and more peaceful than I'd ever felt.

My father had undone all of it in a matter of minutes.

I understood Cess and Ness weren't happy about it either. But unlike me, who languished in bed, Cess got busy. Apart from when she delivered meals, I hardly saw her, but I knew she was there because I heard her voice wafting up the stairs as she took endless phone calls, and visited with unfamiliar people.

'I'm not going to school tomorrow,' I said to her on Sunday night. She'd come to take my dinner tray and say good night. I'd been unable to even summon the strength to roll to face her.

'You can't just lie in bed for the rest of your life,' she said from the doorway.

'Why not?'

‘Because that would be a waste of a brilliant life.’

There was something about the pragmatic, straightforward way that Cess spoke. She said what she meant, and she meant what she said. It made even her simplest comments so powerful. More profound than a million words could have been from my mother.

‘Why do you care anyway?’ I asked.

‘Why do I care? What kind of comment is that?’ she said crossly. ‘Why do you think I care?’

I had no idea, obviously. ‘Duty?’

‘Look at me, Mabel.’

Reluctantly, I rolled over. She stood in the doorway, backlit.

‘I care because you’re my niece. My sister’s daughter. The only blood relative I have left. You’re the only member of the next generation for me to pass the flag to when I go. That makes you the single most important person in my life. Maybe you call that duty, but I call it family.’

‘My father is my family,’ I said. ‘And I’m not the single most important person in his life.’

‘Which is exactly why I’ll never leave you with him,’ she said softly.

She sounded so sure of herself. I wanted to believe her with every fibre of my being. But I knew, even at that young age, that life rarely worked out the way you wanted. ‘But it’s not up to you.’

‘If that’s what you think, darling, you don’t know me very well.’

I nodded, and even managed a smile, and Cess wished me good night. I didn’t tell her what I was thinking. That if she thought she was going to outsmart my father, she didn’t know him very well.

45

NOW

At 3:45, there is a knock at my door.

'Someone's at your door,' Adeem says.

'I'm old but I'm not deaf, Adeem.'

It's not entirely true, though. I was down twenty-five percent hearing on the left side at my last audiologist appointment. But that wasn't the point.

The day has passed in what feels like minutes. No one has eaten. Libby and I have drunk four cups of tea. Adeem has barely looked at his phone.

Adeem still looks confused. 'Then why aren't you getting up to answer it?'

I point at the clock. 'It's 3:45, which means Persephone has just arrived home from school. As such, I'd bet my bottom dollar that what she has to say is that she'd like some afternoon tea. And as I a) don't have any snacks, and b) don't have any time, I think it's best that I leave it, don't you?'

Adeem has no retort other than a shrug. We are about to continue with the interview when I hear an unfamiliar voice.

'Ms Fitzpatrick? It's Detective Inspector Carlaw and Detective Wills. Are you home?'

Adeem, Libby and I blink at each other.

'I'd better get that,' I say, and I shuffle to the front door.

These detectives are not in uniform, but they are in a marked police car, which is parked in the laneway. This has not escaped the attention of my

neighbours, who are out in the street, trying to act casual.

I'm impressed to see that these detectives are both women. Mid-forties at a guess. Tall too, and very attractive. A big step up from Baldy and Hairy.

'I'm Detective Inspector Lise Carlaw,' one of the detectives says, before gesturing to her partner. 'This is Detective Sarah Wills.'

Wills is almost eye to eye with me, which I don't come across often.

'Good for you,' I say. 'Breaking those glass ceilings.'

They stare at me. It has to be said, they have none of the charm of Baldy and Hairy either. 'What can I do for you?' I ask, eventually.

'We'd like you to come down to the station to answer some questions,' Carlaw says, stony-faced. 'About the death of your neighbour Ishaan Patel.'

You've got to be kidding me. 'I already spoke to constables' – I scan my memory for the names of the officers I call Baldy and Hairy, but I do not find them – 'to some other police.'

'We understand,' Wills says. 'But we have some updates on the case that we'd like to discuss with you.'

'What updates?' I ask.

'We'd rather discuss this at the station,' Carlaw says.

Adeem and Libby appear behind me in the hallway. 'Is she under arrest, Detective?' Libby asks.

I stare at her in disbelief. Is she trying to give them ideas?

Carlaw's facial expression doesn't move. I wonder if perhaps it *can't* move? Some kind of stroke or something? 'No, but –'

'Then you're under no obligation to go anywhere, Elsie.'

'That's true,' Carlaw says to me, 'though it won't look good in court if you're not seen to be assisting the police.'

In court. I feel a shudder go down my spine.

'Detectives,' Adeem says, 'Elsie is an elderly woman who has recently been released from hospital. I don't think a court in the land would have an issue with her denying such a request.'

Adeem sounds rather powerful, speaking like this. I'm quite impressed. I find myself giving him the thumbs-up, even as I say: 'I'll go.'

'You don't have to, Elsie,' Libby says again.

‘I know. But frankly, I’m curious to hear these updates. It’s fine. Can we reschedule the rest of the interview?’

They tell me that we can, and we lock up the house and follow the detectives into the street. Nugget follows close behind.

Roxanne and Persephone are in the laneway when I get out there, as is Joan. I’ll admit there’s something humiliating about following detectives out to a police car, especially in front of Joan.

‘Are you going in the police car?’ Persephone says. ‘Can I come?’

‘No, darling,’ I say. ‘Afraid not.’

I steal a look at Joan, expecting a smug expression. Instead, she looks something approaching concerned.

‘Where are you going?’ Roxanne asks.

‘The police have a few questions,’ I say. ‘About Ishaan’s death. I’m going down to the station.’

‘Alone?’ Roxanne says. ‘I don’t think you should go alone. I’ll come with you.’

‘Don’t be ridiculous,’ I say. ‘Who will look after Persephone?’

‘I’d be happy to watch the child,’ Joan says.

I don’t know who is more surprised – me, Roxanne, or Joan herself. Persephone looks so appalled at the prospect that while I’d have liked to have some company, I decline her offer.

‘I’ll be quite all right on my own,’ I say. ‘Though I’d be much obliged if someone could take Nugget.’

Roxanne and Persephone agree to take the dog, and I turn toward the police car.

‘Would you like me to tell Peter?’ Joan offers as Wills opens the back door of the car.

I look over my shoulder. Peter doesn’t need to be bothered with my mess, yet again. I open my mouth to say this. I want to say this. But I don’t. Instead I say, ‘Thank you.’ And Joan nods.

46

I'm taken to an establishment that bears the Victoria Police logo but looks more like the admin building of a life insurance company. The floor is covered in sad little carpet tiles, the desks are arranged in dull grey cubicle clusters, and there's not a single intimidating officer looming over a mugshot line-up. I spot a few people in uniform, but most are in business casual, loitering near the printer or whispering secrets in the stationery cupboard. I don't see a single box of doughnuts or a back-room cell for the drunks.

I take note of all of this because I know Daphne will want to know about it all, in detail. At this point I might have to make something up to avoid disappointing her.

I'm led to a room with a boardroom table and a large window with a view of the city.

'Tea?' Wills offers. 'Coffee? Water?'

She hits me with a stare so piercing I almost check my shirt for holes. My eyes flick to her forehead, where a large, Y-shaped vein is throbbing. If it pops, I'm running for cover.

'I'm fine,' I say. 'Just to clarify, am I under arrest?'

'No,' she repeats. 'You're just giving an official statement. We'll be recording it if that's okay with you?'

'I suppose it is,' I say.

We do the usual faffing about. They test the recorder, state their badge numbers, and ask for my date of birth, which always earns me a look. Then comes an uncomfortable amount of foot-tapping while they locate the On button.

'Right then,' Detective Wills says. 'The reason we brought you in is that we found DNA on your shoe that matches that of your neighbour Mr Patel.'

I stare at them. ‘So?’

‘So . . . we wondered if you’d have an explanation for that.’

‘I’m not an expert in DNA, Detective,’ I say. ‘But if I had to guess, I’d say it’s because we were neighbours. We exchanged words. Gestures. Fluids, occasionally – when he sneezed in my direction, or I flung a garden gnome too enthusiastically. Also, I found him the day he died, remember? So, yes, I’d expect a bit of DNA crossover.’

‘That’s fair,’ says Carlaw. ‘But the autopsy also showed your DNA under his fingernails.’

I shift in my chair. ‘Yes. I told the officers who stopped by that he scratched my arm the day before. He went for his dog – I was holding it – and caught me in the scuffle.’

Wills nods. ‘You did say that.’

The pause stretches like gum.

‘Here’s the thing, Ms Fitzpatrick,’ Wills says. ‘You had a contentious relationship with Mr Patel. There are witnesses who say you threatened him. At the time of his death, he had your DNA under his fingernails, and your shoe had his DNA on it. And you – conveniently – were the one who found the body.’

‘Yes,’ I agree.

‘Well. From our perspective, it looks suspicious.’

Of course it bloody does. I realise now that brutal honesty in my first police chat might not have been my wisest move. But hindsight, as they say, is a smart-arse.

‘I don’t have to admit anything,’ I say crisply. ‘May I ask what the autopsy showed? Officially.’

Their faces shift. I can see Wills fighting the urge to snap ‘we’re the ones asking the questions’, but she refrains.

‘Inconclusive thus far,’ she says. ‘We’re waiting on toxicology, but that’ll take weeks. In the meantime, we’re exploring all angles.’

‘And by all angles,’ I say, ‘you mean this one angle – because you found out I’m Mad Mabel, the alleged killer of yesteryear.’

Wills doesn't answer right away. Her vein pulses like she's moments away from a medical emergency.

'As we said,' she eventually manages, 'with the DNA involved, there was reason enough for a follow-up. There's a lot to cover.'

'Fine,' I say, sinking back in the chair. 'I'll have that tea now. Strong. Milk. Two sugars. And if you've got a biscuit, bring it. This might take a while.'

I answer the detectives' questions. Their tedious, never-ending questions. They follow a circular rhythm: When did Ishaan and I start feuding, what was the nature of it, how bad did it get, what did I consider doing to bring it to an end? And around it goes.

I repeat my answers until I want to smash my head against the table.

When there is a knock at the door, I am delighted, if only for something to break up the monotony.

'Ms Fitzpatrick's lawyer has arrived,' the young woman at the door says.

Wills and Carlaw look at me. 'Did you call your lawyer?'

I can only imagine my facial expression.

'I would have,' I say, my voice all posh-like. 'But I used my one phone call to ring Beyoncé instead.'

Carlaw, naturally, doesn't so much as crack a smile.

'She didn't call a lawyer,' Carlaw says, and starts to close the door.

I needn't have worried about the story being too boring for Daphne, because what happens next feels like something out of a fever dream. A young man in an expensive-looking suit blocks the door with his foot, moments before it closes, and peers into the room.

'Actually, it wasn't Ms Fitzpatrick who called me,' he says, 'it was my aunt.'

'Your *aunt*?' I ask, confused but enjoying the drama.

And then she pops her head around the door. 'This is my nephew, Elsie,' Joan explains, beaming from ear to ear. 'I'm not sure if I mentioned

it, but he is a partner in a law firm.’

47

THEN

A week after my father found Daphne and me in his bedroom, I came downstairs to find him sitting at the breakfast table, peering down at a folded newspaper that sat beside his plate of scrambled eggs.

Cess stood at the stove, an apron tied over her pedal pushers and sleeveless beige fitted top with a pussy bow.

'Good morning, Mabel,' she said with faux brightness.

'Good morning,' I said.

My father didn't look up from his newspaper. He was dressed for work, in suit and tie, his jacket resting on the back of his chair, his shirtsleeves rolled to the forearms.

I looked at Cess uncertainly. 'Sit, Mabel.'

There was a place already laid out for me and she gestured for me to sit as she tipped a medley of scrambled eggs and tomatoes onto my plate. 'How are your eggs, Elliott?' she asked.

He kept his gaze on the paper. 'Fine.'

She served her own meal and sat opposite me. 'Good. Once you've eaten them, you can pack your bags and go.'

Cess ate a mouthful of eggs.

My father looked up. 'Excuse me?'

Cess took her time to swallow her mouthful, making my father wait.

I felt like I'd walked down a laneway just as someone else was getting mugged. Desperate to leave. Afraid to move.

‘I’m not leaving Rosehill,’ she said, touching her serviette to the corners of her mouth. ‘Neither is Mabel. You are.’

She leaned back casually in her chair, reaching for the document on the counter, which she then placed on the table next to my father’s plate.

‘What is this?’ My father glanced at the document but didn’t read it. His body language oozed calm, but his cheeks coloured ever so slightly.

‘There’s a lot of legal jargon in there, but I’ll précis it for you,’ Cess said. ‘As you know, Mary, as my parents’ oldest child, inherited the house from our parents when they died –’

‘Of course I’m aware of this, I –’

Cess continued speaking as if he wasn’t there. ‘My parents’ will also states that upon Mary’s death, the house should pass to her oldest child, if they are of age, and if they aren’t, it passes to me until such time as they are. You’re number three on the list, and only inherit Rosehill if there are no other living relatives.’

My father glanced at me. I was frozen, entirely motionless. Even my breathing had stopped.

‘If you read the paperwork you’ll see it’s very clear,’ Cess said calmly.

‘Ridiculous.’ My father rolled his eyes and picked up a piece of toast from his plate. ‘What would you know about legal documents, Cecily? I’ll get Stan to go through it today.’

‘Actually, Stan was the one who pointed it out to me. If you recall, he was the one who drew up the paperwork for my father before he died. I think his word was “incontestable”.’ She smiled. ‘It will all be explained to you at Mary’s will reading.’

My father reached for his briefcase, took out his glasses, and started flicking through the document.

‘Pages three and four are the important ones,’ Cess said cheerfully. ‘Page five says you’ll still own the prosthetic business my father built, so don’t feel too sorry for yourself.’

While my father read the document in silence, Cess raised her eyebrows in triumph. But I was far too nervous to be triumphant.

Finally, my father stopped flicking pages and sat back in his seat. ‘Well, how do you like that, Mabel? Your beloved aunt is throwing us out onto the street.’

Cess waved her hand. ‘Nonsense. Mabel is welcome to stay until she turns eighteen, at which point the house will become hers. I’m only throwing you onto the street.’

My father removed his glasses. ‘Correct me if I’m wrong,’ he said coolly, ‘but your father’s will doesn’t grant you custody of my daughter as well as the house, does it?’

Panic started: a low rumble in the distance.

‘If not, Mabel and I are leaving. Come on, Mabel.’

I stared at Cess in horror. This, I assumed, was not part of her plan.

‘Don’t look at her, you stupid girl,’ my father snapped. ‘Go pack a bag. We’re leaving.’

I started to stand.

‘Sit down, Mabel,’ Cess said. To my father, she said: ‘Mabel isn’t going anywhere. As I’ve been acting as her guardian since her mother died, you’ll need to apply to the courts to reclaim her. I should warn you, though, as a father, with your work and travel schedule, and without a current place of residence, you don’t stand a chance.’

My father and Cess locked eyes. The silence stretched out for several seconds.

‘Aren’t you clever?’ my father said finally. ‘I’m impressed. Your sister was far too stupid to pull off such a thing.’

Cess didn’t respond, and she even managed to keep her face fairly neutral, though I could see the comment enraged her.

I didn’t have the same restraint. ‘My mother was not stupid.’

My father stood. ‘You’re all stupid if you think I’m not going to end up in the house.’

‘The law disagrees with you,’ Cess said.

‘Actually,’ he says, ‘the law states I do have a claim to the house. If there are no other living relatives.’

He let that comment settle between us for a second before he reached for his briefcase. Then he picked up a piece of toast and popped it between his teeth. And then, with a wave, he was gone.

'He'll be on the phone to lawyers as we speak,' I said to Cess once we heard the front door close.

'Probably,' she agreed. 'Good luck to him. The paperwork is ironclad.'

'Was that a threat, what he said about him having a claim to the house if he was the only living relative? You don't think he'd actually . . .'

'No!' Cess stood and started clearing away the dishes. 'He just didn't want to lose face. Don't you worry about that. Anyway, you're staying here with me! That's good news, isn't it? Didn't I tell you to trust me?'

'You did. But –'

'Mabel.' She stopped doing the dishes. 'Look at me.'

I did.

'I promised you I wouldn't leave you with him, didn't I?'

I nodded.

'I'm promising you again. He can contact his lawyers, file the paperwork, become a High Court judge for all he wants, but I won't let it happen. Do you believe me?'

'Yes.'

And I did. I believed, in a way I never had before, that I was loved.

48

Billy came out of his coma on a Tuesday, just under a month after his accident. He didn't remember what happened to him on Bonfire Day. In fact, there were whole chunks of time that he didn't remember. The doctors said these memories might come back, or they might not.

He returned to school six weeks after his injury. On the whole, it looked like nothing had changed. He looked the same, he sounded the same. But he was also different. Stupider, certainly. And on occasion he'd be hit by a sudden blankness that rendered him silent for ten, maybe fifteen seconds. Afterward, we could see he was unaware of what had happened, and no one ever told him. They were afraid. Because that was the other thing about Billy after the accident.

He was meaner.

Sundays had become my favourite day of the week. Cess and Ness joked about how pious I'd become, such was my desperation to get to Mass each week, and they commented on how much more care I was taking with my presentation, styling my hair carefully and trying out new outfits. It was clear they suspected a boy, but they didn't pry, nor did they seem to notice when I slipped out the side door shortly after Mr Loukas during the service. Afterward, I always waited outside the back double doors, re-tucking my skirt and fixing my hair, ready to hand out flyers to unsuspecting parishioners as they poured out the doors.

It felt like the perfect crime, and yet I couldn't shake a feeling that if anyone saw me, they would know. I'd read books where women and girls had described feeling 'dirty' after interactions such as this, and in a sense that was how I felt. As though something physical covered my skin,

something that could be seen and felt and touched, something that should be washed off. At the same time, ‘dirty’ didn’t quite describe the part of it that felt wonderful, the part I never wanted to wash off in case it never happened again.

Each week, Daphne joined me outside the church as the people spilled out to help me distribute whatever flyers needed handing out – about the parish car boot sale, or the youth dance, or the choir auditions.

‘Talk about dull,’ she said one Sunday, reaching into the box of flyers.

I grinned. ‘Not for me.’

I waited for Daphne to ask why, but instead she went pale.

‘What?’ I said. ‘What is it?’

She pointed to the top of the stairs where a woman in a twinset and pencil skirt was exiting the church. She had platinum-blond hair tucked under a burgundy felt cloche hat and her stilettos were of a height that my mother would have called ‘highly inappropriate’ for church. Still, it was clear the woman was unconcerned about what was deemed appropriate, given she had linked her arm with my father’s.

My father: a widower of a couple of months. And Susan.

I stared at them as they came down the stairs, chatting to other parishioners, their arms linked in a way I’d never seen my father’s arms linked with my mother’s. Her hand was in the inner crook of his elbow, and he covered her hand with his own. A girl of about six, with blond hair and blue eyes like a baby doll, walked to one side of my father. I thought I might be sick.

My father looked at me. I wanted to look away, but I found myself staring back. Susan, seemingly unaware of any of this, extended her gloved hand for a flyer.

‘Whoa, Mabel,’ Daph said to me once they had passed. ‘Talk about a death stare.’

‘My father’s?’

‘No. Yours.’

‘Oh,’ I said. ‘Well, looks can’t kill.’

‘I don’t know,’ Daphne said.

‘They can’t,’ I say. ‘Or he’d already be dead.’

49

People love talking about how ‘kids are different these days’. The inference, of course, is that kids were better off in the old days, a time before the internet, before fast food, a time when they read books, ate vegetables and played outside from dawn till dusk. I say fiddlesticks to that. Kids are the same surly, irrational, resilient, narcissistic beasts they’ve always been, forging their way in the world while being simultaneously pummelled and delighted by life. The horrors and the delights were a little different, that’s all.

My horror, obviously, was the fear of being thrust into the care of my father. My delight? My little romance with Mr Loukas, obviously. My ‘Gilbert Blythe’.

Unfortunately, in the end, that turned into a horror as well.

It fell apart the day we’d made a plan to meet in the school sports shed. The meet-up was arranged in class – a handwritten note – and the cloak-and-dagger of it thrilled me and took my attention from the things I didn’t want to focus on – my father and whatever he was planning to get Rosehill back.

‘There you are.’

It was after school. My instructions had been to let myself inside and then hop into the cupboard that held the hockey sticks. That part had been a challenge. The cupboard, not dissimilar to a broom cupboard, was not only too short for me, but it was also filled with hockey sticks. I tried contorting myself inside without much luck, but abandoned the exercise when he walked in.

‘Did I overestimate the size of that cupboard?’ he said, grinning. ‘Or did I underestimate the size of you?’

I shrugged. I felt girlish at the sight of him, and at how pleased he looked to see me.

He walked inside and the door closed, bringing complete darkness apart from the daylight that shone through the cracks. Neither of us spoke, which was typical of our interactions. We exchanged a few words here and there, but mostly we let our bodies do the talking. After all, what would I say? I felt like I was playing a role but didn't know the lines.

It was silent in the shed, apart from the sound of our lips smacking together, and the occasional satisfied noises from Mr Loukas. I liked it when he made those noises – it felt like getting an A on my history paper. But when he tugged my shirt out of my skirt, and slid his hand underneath and over the top of my bra, I wasn't so sure I did like it. That had never happened at his house, or around the back of the church.

I should have stopped him. But strange as it sounds, I'm not sure I knew I was allowed to. Stupidly, I made my own satisfied noise in the hopes it would wrap things up. A mistake, because he responded by pressing himself against me, forcing my back against the metal cage of basketballs with an almighty clang.

He tugged up my skirt. Oh, the thoughts that went through my head! Fear, obviously. Panic. But also resignation. I had, I believed, signed an invisible contract by entering the shed. The contract said I understood and agreed to whatever was going to happen. If I didn't understand – which I hadn't – more fool me. The train was going to leave the station with or without me.

As he slipped his hand into my underwear, my brain went in search of the pleasure I read about in my mother's romance novels, but I didn't find it.

'Who is in there?'

It was hard to know whether to be relieved or even more terrified. It was the voice of Brother Stanislaus – our principal. I pulled my skirt down and tucked myself around the side of the basketball cage in the couple of seconds it took for Brother Stanislaus to open the door.

'Oh,' he said. 'Is it you making all that racket?'

‘Yes, sir,’ Mr Loukas replied. ‘I was just trying to grab a basketball so I can shoot some hoops at home. But the cage is locked.’

It was quiet for long enough that I was worried. I pictured Brother Stanislaus’s disbelieving face. ‘The cage is always locked. If it wasn’t there’d be no balls left.’ He chuckled. ‘Strictly speaking they’re for use on school grounds but I’ll make an exception.’

I heard Brother Stanislaus’s shoes on the concrete floor and I scrambled back as far as I could go. I held my breath. I didn’t know that I could hold my breath for so long. Truly. I thought I might explode by the time the key jangled in the cage. A few moments later, the pair vacated the shed, and I finally let my breath out.

Then the keys jangled again and my heart ceased to beat. Brother Stanislaus had locked the door. With me inside.

I assumed Mr Loukas would come back for me. I knew he didn’t have a key, but I thought he would return to see if he could help in some way or help me construct some kind of excuse to tell Cess as to why I was going to be so late.

It was dark outside before I accepted that once again, I was on my own.

The shed was old and cobwebbed and made from tin, the walls of which had seen better days. I crawled the perimeter, kicking at the curled edges of the tin to see if it would bend. It didn’t take long for me to bash a corner out. The hockey sticks came in handy for that. The noise of wood against metal wasn’t insignificant, but no one came to investigate it. I’m not sure why I was surprised.

I was covered in dirt and sweat when I finished crawling through the gap. I didn’t know the time, but it felt like early evening. I should have gone straight home. But my legs had another plan for me. I headed to his house.

I wasn’t going to chide him for leaving me there and not returning, I decided. I was going to let him explain. There would be a reason he’d left me there, I was certain of it. Once he saw me, he’d be relieved that I was

okay and we could share in the scandal of almost being caught by Brother Stanislaus. Talk about crazy!

I must have looked a fright when I knocked at his front door. I made a rudimentary attempt to brush the dirt off my clothes and rake my hands through my hair. I was still trying to disentangle my fingers from my hair when the woman came to the door.

'Yes?'

She was a pretty woman. Mid-twenties, burgundy circle skirt, crisp white shirt. Dark brown hair cut into a pageboy. She wasn't unfriendly so much as curious. As if she'd never seen a human girl before. But it only took a couple of seconds for her expression to morph from curious to suspicious.

'Are you looking for someone?'

'Yes,' I said uncertainly. 'I was looking for . . .'

I hesitated. He'd told me never to tell anyone about what we did.

Her brown eyes pinned me in their stare. 'Who are you looking for?'

Later I realised I should have made something up. But at the time I thought I had no choice.

'I'm looking for Mr Loukas,' I said.

50

NOW

Bailey Andrews, Joan's nephew, drives me home from the police station.

Bailey has a very nice car – a Range Rover – with cream leather seats and individual temperature control. He asks me several times if I'm too hot or too cold, and shows me how to adjust it. I feel like I've arrived at a fancy hotel. Joan sits in the back seat with me and Bailey drives, which feels a little odd, as if we have a chauffeur.

Bailey is not a criminal lawyer, he explains to me, though he knows some defenders who could represent me if it is required. In the meantime, the most important thing to remember is that I don't have to speak to the police, and I shouldn't speak to them, unless I am under arrest. Even then, I only have to tell the police my name and then I can request a lawyer.

'I highly doubt it will come to that,' he says. 'I spoke to the detectives and all the evidence they have is circumstantial.'

'Thank you,' I tell him. 'I appreciate your help more than I can say. I am interested, though, in why you are helping me.'

Bailey meets my eye in the rear-view mirror. 'Because,' he says, 'my aunt told me to. And I am terrified of my aunt.'

I glance at Joan, who chuckles. 'Quite right too.'

'In that case,' I say, 'my question should be directed to you, Joan. Why are you helping me?'

Her smile fades, and she gets a flustered look about her. ‘How is your wrist, Elsie? Peter said your wrist was broken.’

Odd woman. I wonder whether to repeat my question, but I decide to let it go.

‘Yes, broken.’ I hold up my wrist, which is wrapped in a neat little cast, signed by Persephone in electric-blue text. ‘But I’m perfectly fine.’

‘It was very brave of you, intervening with that intruder there. At your age.’

I’m grateful that she added the last sentence, or I might have found myself in the bizarre position of receiving a compliment from Joan.

‘I saw you confront that man who was bashing on Roxanne’s door the other night. None of the rest of us was game to do it, but you did.’

Only now do I realise that Joan, in her way, is in fact answering my question.

‘Before I moved into Kenny Lane, Bailey did a little research on the street. He told me you lived there and I’ll admit, I was afraid of you.’

‘I got that sense,’ I tell her, remembering her scurrying away from me every time I said good morning.

‘I had been hoping you’d move away, or perhaps die.’

I nod. Any offence I feel is offset by how charmed I am by this sort of honesty.

‘So when Ishaan died, I thought it was suspicious,’ she says, ‘which is why I told the police about your past. None of the neighbours were concerned. You’re incredibly beloved in Kenny Lane, Elsie. That says something. I should have paid attention to that.’

I feel a buzz of something, against all odds. A burst of adrenaline that comes after a moment of kindness. *Careful, Elsie*, I tell myself. *Next you’ll be thinking that perhaps Joan isn’t so bad*.

‘Peter has been singing your praises since I moved in, which I didn’t understand. I assumed you had him hoodwinked. But it’s not just him. The Nguyens think you’re wonderful, Roxanne adores you, and of course little Persephone. You’re her hero. She was talking about you after you left in the police car. She said you’ve saved her life twice: the time the man came to

the door, and the day those people sprayed you with the water pistol when you pushed her behind you to keep her safe. It doesn't sound like the kind of thing a killer does, to me.'

I want to tell her it's nowhere near as simple as that. There's no reason a murderer couldn't kill one person and save another. That being a murderer is nowhere near as binary as people think. Sometimes murderers are bad people. Sometimes murderers kill bad people. Sometimes murderers are good people who make bad decisions. But Joan seems to be on a roll, so I decide it isn't the time.

'In any case, I believe I owe you an apology. I think it was my speaking to the police about your past that kicked up this ruckus, and so the least I can do is attempt to sort it out. Or,' she says, 'get Bailey to sort it out.'

'I just hope it's not too late to sort out,' I say.

'Nothing's too late,' Joan says. 'Not with Bailey on the case.'

Bailey blanches. 'As I said, Auntie Joan, I'm not a criminal –'

'He's being coy. Don't listen to him, Elsie.'

We pull into Kenny Lane. 'You'll have to drop in and tell Peter you're all right,' Joan says. 'He's been worried sick all afternoon.'

'Silly man,' I say. 'He doesn't need to worry about me.'

'He thinks very highly of you, Elsie.'

Silly as it is, my frosty heart warms at this. 'And I have a feeling you think very highly of *Peter*, Joan.'

She withholds a smile, poorly. It makes her look almost pretty. I have a strange feeling she is asking for my blessing.

'If you're happy to spend your weekends at Aldi,' I tell her, 'I think you and Peter will make each other very happy.'

Her smile vanishes, replaced by her typical stern face. 'For pity's sake, Elsie, if that man comes home with another two-man tent –'

And just when I thought I'd heard and seen it all, I find myself feeling fond of Joan.

51

Roxanne promised she'd have Persephone over by 7 pm, freshly bathed, fed and pyjama-clad. At 7:35, there's still no sign of them. Punctuality, it seems, has joined common sense and properly made furniture on the growing list of things that no longer exist.

'Calm down, Elsie, for pity's sake,' Daphne says. 'You're making me nervous.'

It's true that I'm a little on edge. I wasn't the sort of girl who babysat in her youth. I didn't have younger siblings (well, not for long, and not in any meaningful way). And truth be told, I've never been particularly fond of children. The evening has disaster written all over it, probably in permanent marker.

'It's one child,' Daphne says. 'We can manage.'

'One demon child,' I reply.

'We were demon children once,' Daphne says.

'And look how we turned out!'

We chuckle.

'It'll be fun,' she says. 'And if not, it will make a good story.'

Daphne loves a good story. She's only just recovered from the excitement of me being hauled off to the police station, not to mention the soap-opera-level twist of being rescued by Joan's nephew.

'Why do I always miss the excitement?' she'd wailed.

'I don't know,' I'd told her. 'But next time you disappear, take me with you. I'd like to miss a few exciting bits myself.'

I walk to my front door – which is open because I've developed the bad habit of hoping people might actually arrive. 'What on earth are they doing?' The lights are on. I can see the flickering silhouette of a small,

hyperactive person doing laps of the living room. For all I know, Roxanne is taking a bloody nap.

Which would be fine, except for some reason that escapes me entirely, I baked an apple pie. A whole one. I even made a trip to the supermarket for vanilla ice cream. I'd envisioned Persephone and me sharing a bowl before reading a book. But at this rate, she'll arrive just in time to brush her teeth and be tossed into bed, and the pie will sit there, untouched, like a monument to my misplaced optimism.

At 7:40 pm, I declare to Daphne that I'm going over there, and march out into the laneway. I've barely knocked when Persephone answers the door, sopping wet, wrapped in a towel.

'Elsa!' She launches herself at me, wrapping her arms around my waist. Her towel drops to the ground, but she continues holding on to me. After a moment or two I idly pat her sodden head. 'El*sie*,' I correct.

She pulls back, leaving a wet patch on my blouse. 'El*sie*.'

'Persephone, PUT YOUR JAMMIES ON THIS INSTANT!' Roxanne calls.

The child winces, as do I. A moment after she's scampered off into her bedroom, Roxanne appears, dressed in black leggings and a blue jumper and hideous plastic clogs. Her hair is looped in a tumbling waterfall atop her head. 'Oh, Elsie. Sorry. I couldn't get Persephone out of the shower. Persephone!'

'I thought you started work at 8 pm.'

'I do.' She looks at her watch. 'Shit!'

I sigh. 'Go get ready. I'll get her ready for bed and take her back to my place.'

Roxanne looks confused. 'I'm ready.'

I give her the once-over.

'I'm a cleaner, Elsie. I work in an empty office. No need to wear my finery to work.'

I hold up my hands. 'All right, all right. In my day, people wore uniforms but times change, evidently. Off with you then.'

'Are you sure?'

I glance into Persephone's bedroom and see her jumping on her bed in her shorts, the towel now covering her head.

'Get out of here before I change my mind.'

Roxanne tosses me the keys and, a moment later, is gone.

'I need a poo!'

I've always prided myself on being the kind of elderly lady who hasn't forgotten the hardships of being young, and who never underestimates the new challenges that younger folk face that haven't been a part of my own experience. The type who never insinuates that our generation are the golden ones and younger people are simply not hardworking enough, or are too hardworking, or let their children rot in front of screens. I recall the pressures of being a penniless young woman working several jobs. As for raising a child, while it isn't something I'd experienced, it's plain to see it is every bit as difficult as people report.

With that said, I'd completely underestimated the impossibility of putting a small child to bed. Daphne, who'd also underestimated this, absconded an hour ago, ignoring my threats and pleas.

'Elsa?'

'Knock yourself out!' I call from my sofa.

I've given up the will to argue. I've also given up the will to keep correcting her when she calls me Elsa. The child can call me *Horace* as long as she goes the fuck to sleep.

I'd set Persephone up in the second bedroom, which I'd spent the afternoon putting the finishing touches to so it now resembled an ordinary room. In the two hours since I'd read her a book and put her to bed, Persephone has required four additional stories, three glasses of water, Hippy her stuffed hippo (who I'd had to retrieve from her house), and a wee. Just when I thought there was nothing left to request, she asked for a back rub. *A back rub!* The hide of her! I imagined my mother's face, or Cess's, if I'd ever asked for such a thing. She didn't even wait for a response, just rolled onto her tummy. For the love of God. Under duress, I

agreed to do it ‘for a minute’ – but the minute stretched to forty-five, and was accompanied by instructions of ‘harder . . . harder . . . owww, not that hard! You have long nails, Elsa.’

If I was the praying sort, I’d have started praying for death to come swiftly.

Eventually she quieted down and I slipped out of the room and made a cup of tea. Just as I lowered myself into my armchair, a poo.

As I live and breathe.

I wonder if Roxanne will hold me to my offer of babysitting. With no money exchanging hands, and no contract signed, it feels like it would be difficult to enforce. Yes, I wanted to help the woman out, a single mother and all, but an old lady has her limits.

As I finish my tea, I listen to Persephone rattling around in the bathroom, flushing and taking an outlandish amount of time to wash her hands. Finally I hear her little feet on the floorboards as she takes herself back to bed. I glance at the clock. 11:33 pm. Mother of God.

I take myself off to bed shortly after midnight, amused – and mildly horrified – that after everything I’ve endured in my life, it’s a seven-year-old child who’s managed to break my spirit. For the first time in a very long time, I feel an affinity with my infamous nickname, Mad Mabel. Thankfully (for Persephone), as I pass the spare room and catch sight of her sleeping soundly – head at the foot of the bed, feet on the pillow – I manage to access some softer, more charitable emotions for the child.

I leave the door ajar and lumber back to my room, where I fall into a deep, heavy sleep the moment I hit the bed. When I wake, it’s dark, and quiet enough that I can hear Persephone breathing in the next room. The clock reads 3:33 am. I’m just about to roll over when something shifts beside me in the bed. I leap backward and fumble for the lamp switch.

And there she is. Persephone. Fast asleep on top of the blankets, one arm slung around my waist like I’m a giant teddy bear. For pity’s sake. Roxanne could offer triple rates and a Christmas bonus and still not find a

babysitter willing to take this gig. I push back the covers and walk around to her side of the bed. I try to scoop her up, but the second I do, my back spasms.

'Mother of God.'

'What . . . what's happening?' Persephone mumbles.

I wince. 'Nothing, child. It's just me, Elsa. You need to go back to your own bed.'

'No. I sleep with you.'

She curls deeper into the mattress, nuzzling into my pillow. Unlike earlier, she falls asleep in seconds. Before I can even formulate a plan, she lets out a little snore.

Perfect.

I stand there, considering my options. When tiredness takes over, I grab the comforter from the end of the bed and drape it over her, then go back around to my side and slide in under the blankets. Not a full minute passes before she wriggles across and flings an arm over me again.

Silly child, I think. *You silly, precious child*.

The wave of emotion barrels through me without warning. It arrives too fast to dodge, too heavy to bear. Suddenly, I'm weeping. Not sniffling. Not dabbing the corners of my eyes like they do in the movies. I'm crying in great, helpless gulps.

And still, she sleeps.

Of course she does.

52

When Adeem and Libby arrive the next morning, Adeem has a Tupperware container full of brownies with him.

'Meera made them,' he says as he hands the container over.

'How thoughtful,' I reply, setting it down on the counter. 'She must've heard I've been through the wars.'

'Well,' he says, counting on his fingers, 'the first time we came, you were assaulted. The second time, you were arrested.'

'Brought in for questioning,' I clarify, peeling open the lid of the Tupperware. 'There's a difference.'

'Glad to hear it,' Libby says. 'Let's aim to get through today without anyone being hospitalised.'

'Ambitious, but I like it.'

While I plate the brownies – which are thick and glossy, with just the right amount of crackle on top – Adeem sets up the tripod in the living room. Libby hovers at the kettle, fiddling with her ridiculous tin of loose-leaf tea. Today it smells like lemon and something else – myrtle, maybe? – and I'll admit it's not unpleasant. But I have too much self-respect to start drinking infused flowers at eighty-one.

'I was watching the footage back last night,' Adeem says as Libby and I return to the table. 'You're a fantastic storyteller, Elsie.'

'Thank you,' I say drily. 'The material, admittedly, is quite compelling.'

'One comment which the media grabbed onto was a note in your diary where you said you were' – Libby glances at her notes – 'delighted Mr Loukas was dead.'

She looks up.

'Well . . .' I start.

‘It’s an interesting word choice, “delighted”,’ Adeem says. ‘Not “glad”, not even “happy”. “Delighted” is a word you’d use to describe how you’d feel about looking after someone’s kitten.’ He shoots a look at Libby.

‘I’m not looking after your kitten, Ads. I’m allergic.’

‘What is a word *you’d* use,’ I ask him, ‘to describe how you’d feel if someone who betrayed you in the worst way died?’

He thinks about that. ‘Pleased?’

‘Thrilled?’ Libby suggests.

‘Overjoyed?’ Adeem is getting into it. ‘Elated? Jubilant?’

‘Jubilant?’ I say, exchanging a glance with Libby. ‘Wow, Adeem. Makes “delighted” look tame.’

He rolls his eyes. ‘Just talk, would you, Elsie. And pass me a brownie.’

53

THEN

Mere seconds after I asked for Mr Loukas, he appeared in the hallway. At first, I felt relief – after the shock of the unfamiliar woman at the door, it was comforting to see a familiar face. But the feeling didn't last. Not once I saw the way the woman was looking at him.

'Jim, what's going on?' she said, her voice oddly high-pitched. 'Why is this girl coming here?'

I understood that I'd done the wrong thing by coming to Mr Loukas's house, even if I didn't understand why. I assumed that Mr Loukas would do the explaining, but instead he looked at me, as if confused himself, and waited for me to answer. My cheeks burned.

'I . . . I . . .'

'Mabel is one of my history students,' Mr Loukas said finally. 'Mabel, are you all right? Why are you covered in dirt?'

Mr Loukas and the woman looked at me expectantly. I felt like I'd been caught shoplifting. Except the person I'd been shoplifting with now seemed to be an undercover cop.

'I . . . I was playing hide-and-seek,' I said finally. 'There was a great hiding spot in one of the garden beds. Anyway, I lost track of time and I . . . I knew this was your house and I thought you might have a phone. I wanted to call my aunt and let her know I'm okay and I'll be home soon.'

The woman looked unconvinced.

‘We don’t have a phone,’ she said, her gaze flicking between Mr Loukas and me.

‘No,’ Mr Loukas said. ‘Sorry about that, Mabel, we don’t.’

He wasn’t looking at me. He was looking everywhere but at me. I wanted him to look at me, to communicate something with his eyes. Something that said that this woman was no one and that he would explain it all later. Why didn’t he communicate that? It made me hate him a little.

From the way the woman was looking at him, I suspected she hated him too.

‘Never mind,’ I said. ‘I’ll just make my way home myself then.’

I expected Mr Loukas to come after me, to offer to drive me home. His car was parked in the driveway. Surely that would have been the right thing to do, given the darkness and the late hour? In the car he’d explain himself and I’d pretend I wasn’t going to accept his explanation, but after he grovelled I probably would. But none of that happened. Instead, I made my way back down his front path.

‘Wait!’

I stopped. But it wasn’t Mr Loukas coming after me, it was the woman. She charged down the path and grabbed my arm.

‘What’s going on between you and my fiancé?’

Her French manicured nails dug into the flesh of my arm. It hurt a lot, but I didn’t cry out. It gave me a noble feeling to endure it stoically.

‘Tessa!’ Mr Loukas started, but she lifted her other hand, palm toward him, even as she dug her nails farther into me.

‘Well?’

I wanted to respond, if only to get her to let go of my arm, but the word ‘fiancé’ had short-circuited my brain.

‘Right,’ she said finally. ‘How old are you?’

‘Fifteen.’

She exhaled, rolled her eyes. ‘Not his youngest, at least. Though the last girl was much prettier than you.’

She let go of my arm and waited for the hurt and shock to appear on my face before continuing.

‘He said he was in love with her. That he couldn’t help himself. He left the school in Adelaide and moved here, and like a fool, I followed. But clearly it wasn’t a one-off. And if he went for someone like you, he isn’t picky. I guess it’s an illness. A fetish.’

She turned and walked back to the house. The door slammed. And I remained there in the darkness.

I needed to leave; Cess would be worried. But . . .

He had a fiancée.

He had had a relationship with another student. One who was much prettier than me.

He wasn’t my Gilbert. I wasn’t Anne.

He was my teacher. I was an illness. A fetish.

I hated him, I realised. Or maybe . . . maybe it was something worse than hate. Something darker. Something heavier.

I walked past his Datsun, canary yellow, in the driveway, and found myself giving it an almighty kick. The impact of my shoe against the rubber was wonderfully soundless, so I did it again. And again. Unfortunately, as well as being soundless, it was ineffective at causing damage. So I retrieved my compass from my bag and stuck the needle deep into the tyre until I heard the hiss of the air releasing. It felt good. I wanted to puncture something else. I pulled out the needle and looked for a moment at its sharp end.

She may have been prettier. But I was Mad Mabel.

I ran all the way home. When I got there, Cess was not happy.

‘Where in heaven’s name have you been, child?’ she cried. ‘Look at the state of you! What have you been doing, crawling in the dirt?’

She hugged me roughly, as if she couldn’t decide whether she was relieved or angry. Ostensibly, she was both.

‘I’m sorry. I lost track of time.’

‘Doing what?’

She'd forgotten herself. Normally Cess was at pains not to comment on the fact that I was socially inept, not the kind of child who got caught up with the neighbourhood children, but this comment revealed her true understanding.

'I went to the library,' I said. 'And . . . I tripped over a garden bed as I left.'

I noticed her looking at the marks on my arm where Mr Loukas's fiancée had dug in her nails. 'That's how I hurt my arm.'

She looked up at my face. She didn't believe me. But she didn't push it.

'Well, get in the bath. Your dinner is cold and don't think I'll be heating it up.'

I apologised again and went upstairs for my bath. I scrubbed myself clean. And when I emerged, I found my meal on a tray outside my bedroom door. It was piping hot.

54

The next day, I rode my bike to school as usual. Daphne met me at the gate as usual. I sat in my classes as usual. What wasn't usual were the words that ran on a loop in my mind from the moment I awakened.

The last girl was much prettier than you.

I'd always prided myself on my smarts. But I wasn't smart at all. I was a fool.

All morning, long vignettes of the evening before popped into my mind unbidden: Mr Loukas pushing me against the basketball cage, Brother Stanislaus bursting in, me bashing at the shed wall with the hockey stick. And then, Mr Loukas's blank look upon finding me at his door.

I felt jittery. Every time someone came into the classroom my heart began to race. Daphne noticed my jumpiness, and she patted my hand.

'Are you all right, Mabel?'

I told her I was. But by the time history class came around – the period before lunch – I was on the verge of hysteria. I'd been so stupid. I'd found a bosom friend, hadn't I? Why had I thought I could have a boyfriend too? Why would anyone be interested in me? Why had I been so greedy?

I sat in the back row, which was unlike me. I didn't even have to look up to know, when the teacher entered, that it was a substitute. Oddly, it made me even more anxious than before.

'Where is Mr Loukas?' someone asked.

The substitute didn't know.

A few people cheered. Mr Loukas was well liked, but it was always a good day when a teacher was away – less work, more time to mess about. I didn't mess about, though. I read the allocated reading and answered the questions. I did the extra questions that were given to those who finished

early. I didn't look at anyone, even Daphne. I doubted I'd ever be able to look anyone in the eye again.

An assembly was called after lunch.

'We've had some sad news about Mr Loukas,' Brother Stanislaus started. I lowered my head. I knew, even before Brother Stanislaus said it, that he was dead. What's more, I was glad.

55

NOW

It's dark when Adeem and Libby leave. They offered to leave earlier – several times, in fact – but I insisted we press on. There was a lot to get through, and we were in flow.

Finally at 10 pm, Adeem said he needed to go home or his wife would think he was having an affair.

'Browbeaten,' I mutter as I let them out. Adeem rolls his eyes. Libby chuckles.

I wave them off with a plan for them to return in a few days, then I go back to the living room. The house feels different with them gone. The cushions are still indented from Libby's arm, and I can smell the remains of Adeem's cheap aftershave. But I don't fluff the cushions or open a window. I like the feeling of my house after guests. Apart from Daphne, and more recently Persephone and Roxanne, my house hasn't felt this kind of energy.

I take myself off to bed, oddly buoyed by my afternoon despite the content of the discussion. As I lie in the darkness, I think about baking something next time – carrot cake, perhaps. Though Adeem's wife probably wouldn't appreciate that given the size of his waistline. Then again, if she's worried about him straying, perhaps she'd find it comforting? He's a nice enough chap, but unlikely to tempt the ladies if his waistline grows any more.

I must drift off with this thought, because when I wake, it's 4 am, and Nugget is yapping. I hear scratching outside on my porch. Possums, most

likely. I rap on the window, and the noise stops – both Nugget's barking and the scratching – and I fall back to sleep.

I sleep in until 8:30 am, and when I wake it's without the sense of dread of the previous few days. I know it's speaking to Libby and Adeem that has made a difference. Not just the catharsis of talking, although I like that part too, but the sense of taking my power back. For so long I'd accepted that I was powerless over the truth of my story, and perhaps I was, but at least now I was doing what was in my control to set the story straight.

I slide out of bed and into my robe. I'm tying it around me when I notice movement outside my window. I peer out. Peter is standing outside my house, and not just Peter. Joan is there too, and Roxanne and Persephone. They're lined up, looking at my house. Odd people. I have slept late, I suppose. Perhaps Persephone told everyone I died?

I pull up the sash window and wave. 'Bad news! I'm alive!'

I throw them a smile, adding a burst of conviviality in the hope it will send them on their way. Frankly it's a little unnerving waking up to find the entire street anxiously focused on your home, as if preparing to bid at an antiques market.

They don't smile back. Humourless bunch.

I close the window and go outside. From the porch, I survey the sombre faces of the neighbours. Peter and Joan stand side by side, synchronised in their hand-wringing. Mrs Nguyen watches from a few paces back, beside Mr Nguyen, who is smoking a cigarette and glancing away. Roxanne, I notice, looks ashen.

Persephone is the only one who looks delighted to see me. I find myself thinking of a charmingly stupid dog. If she'd been closer, I might have given her a pat.

'Mad!' Persephone cries.

'Confused, actually,' I reply, 'as to why you're all staring at my house.'

'No!' She laughs, pointing. 'Look. Mad!'

I turn, following her pointed finger. Then I understand. How foolish of me.

The scratching I'd heard in the early hours outside my bedroom window. Not a possum, apparently. Painted on the lavender brick wall of my home is a word in sloppy letters. Blood red.

MAD.

56

THEN

Brother Stanislaus didn't give us all the gory details, just that Mr Loukas had been changing the tyre on his Datsun when the jack tumbled out and the car crushed him. He died instantly, we were told, and wouldn't have felt pain.

'Good riddance,' Daphne said under her breath.

I stared at her. It was an odd comment. Daphne didn't know about me and Mr Loukas. Why would she say good riddance?

'What did you say?'

'I didn't like him,' she said. 'Call it a gut instinct.'

'Shhh,' one of the teachers said to us. 'Brother Stanislaus is talking. Heads to the front.'

We looked to the front. As I sat cross-legged on the gymnasium floor, I realised Daphne's instinct was right. Mr Loukas wasn't the great love story I'd dreamed of. He was a teacher having a relationship with a student. I wasn't even the first.

I'm not going to lie, it was some consolation to me that now, I knew I'd be the last.

*

Cess and Ness practically pounced on me the moment I got in the door after school. I was still holding my schoolbag.

‘Mabel, will you come in here, please?’

They were in the front room, to the left of the foyer, both standing. It was early for Ness to be back from the library. I decided there was no point beating around the bush.

‘You heard about Mr Loukas?’

Cess nodded. Her posture was tight – her shoulders raised, her body stiff. ‘It was on the radio. He was your history teacher, wasn’t he?’

‘Yes.’

‘I know you liked him. You must be upset.’

Cess spoke lightly, carefully. As if every question contained another question.

‘I guess I am.’

I don’t think I’d ever felt as uncomfortable in Cess and Ness’s presence before.

‘His fiancée was interviewed,’ Ness said. ‘She was sobbing about how they were about to start their lives together. How they’d been looking forward to starting a family.’

I’ll admit, this stung. I thought of Tessa glaring at Mr Loukas, her French manicured nails digging into my arm. My expression must have betrayed this, but Cess did away with her light tone.

‘Where were you last night, Mabel? And don’t play me for a fool.’

She watched me carefully. When I didn’t respond, she added: ‘You came home late, covered in dirt, with no good explanation. Your shoes are scuffed to the high heavens and you have scratches on your forearm. The next thing I hear on the news is that your teacher was found dead last night. The one teacher I’ve ever heard you mention.’

There wasn’t a question. So I didn’t respond.

Ness took over, more softly. ‘Did something happen between you and this teacher? Something more than a normal teacher–student relationship?’

I jumped at the opportunity to turn the questioning around. ‘What are you suggesting?’

Cess threw up a hand. ‘I think you know what she’s suggesting.’

They waited, but I was mute. Finally, Cess sighed. ‘Darling, if something did happen between the two of you –’

‘Something did,’ I said. ‘I was with him last night. The scratch is from his fiancée’s nails, where she grabbed me after finding out. I thought he loved me. But she said I wasn’t the first student. Apparently, he liked them young. Apparently, the last one was prettier than me.’

It came out as a long stream. Once I started, I couldn’t stop. I was crying. Cess closed her eyes.

‘I didn’t kill him,’ I said. ‘I promise. But I’m delighted he’s dead.’

Ness inhaled deeply and started pacing. Cess’s shoulders dropped. Finally, Cess shook her head, took two steps toward me, and hugged me, hard. ‘I suppose I’m delighted too,’ she said into my ear. ‘Otherwise, we’d have had to kill him.’

57

It took ten days for Mr Loukas's autopsy results to come in. When they did, they put a swift end to the theory that the car had inadvertently fallen on him while he was changing a tyre. The word on the street was that the scrapes to his shoulders and the back of his legs, and the deep wound behind his left ear, were cause for suspicion. That day, his death was officially deemed a homicide.

Everyone had a theory.

'He was hit in the head with something heavy,' Daphne said. We were on our bikes on the way to school. Daphne had started riding her bike to my place before school just so we could ride there together. She was slightly ahead of me, her hair flapping around under her straw hat. 'Dragged to the jacked-up car, pushed underneath, and then *wham*.' She kicked her leg. 'Jack goes out, car comes down. Pretty clever, really.'

'Not that clever,' I said, 'since the cops figured it out pretty quick.'

It wasn't surprising that everyone was talking about it. Mr Loukas was a beloved teacher. He was a young man, and it was an unexpected death. But where I'd hoped that with each day, people's interest in his death would wane, instead each day brought with it a new piece of information – whether fact or made up – or a new theory.

I slowed down, then got off my bike, preferring to walk. I held the handlebars and pushed.

Daphne got off her bike too. 'Mabel? Are you okay?'

I nodded.

'What's wrong?'

I lowered my voice and glanced around. 'I saw him the night he died.'

'You did?' Daphne also lowered her voice. 'Where?'

'We met in the sporting equipment shed.'

Daphne's eyes grew into saucers. She understood what kind of thing happened in the sporting equipment shed. 'You and Mr Loukas?'

'It had been going on for a while,' I said. 'But that night, Brother Stanislaus showed up.'

Daphne gasped.

'Shhh,' I said. 'It was fine. I hid and he didn't see me. He and Mr Loukas left. Afterward, I went to Mr Loukas's house. I thought we'd laugh about what had happened. But a woman was there. His fiancée!'

'I heard he had a fiancée,' Daphne said. 'Snake.'

'She said he'd had other relationships with students. Can you believe it?'

Daphne shook her head, muttering all sorts of curse words as we approached the school. It was nearly time for the bell and students hurried through the gates. Brother Stanislaus stood out the front, which he did sometimes to greet the students and remind them to pull up their socks and straighten their ties.

'I was so upset,' I said to Daphne quietly. 'I punctured his tyre when I left.'

'Did you puncture anything else?' she said, equally quietly. 'I wouldn't blame you one bit if you did. And I will never tell a soul, I swear.'

Every person, I thought, should have a friend like Daphne.

'The truth is,' I said, then stopped talking when we noticed two uniformed police officers approaching Brother Stanislaus.

'What do you think is going on?' I whispered to Daphne, who shrugged.

We weren't the only ones wondering. Students lurked nearby in groups of two or three, clearly trying to catch a word to fuel the day's gossip. Billy Harris was loitering nearby, I noticed, in one of the groups of nosy kids.

Brother Stanislaus talked to the officers for a moment or two, then glanced around, his gaze locking on Daphne and myself. A bad feeling overcame me.

'Mabel,' Brother Stanislaus said. 'These policemen would like to talk to you.'

‘What?’ I looked at the policemen – both middle-aged, thickset, stern-looking. One of them, the moustachioed one, was familiar-looking. I thought I recognised him from one of my parents’ dinner parties. ‘Why?’

‘We need to take a statement from you down at the police station,’ the moustachioed police officer said.

Daphne moved closer to me. Her eyes were wide and worried.

‘Why do you need a statement from me?’ I asked.

‘Because we understand you visited your teacher’s house on the night of his death,’ the same policeman said, unnecessarily loud.

There was an audible intake of breath from students nearby. Brother Stanislaus took my bike out of my hands.

‘It won’t take long,’ the other police officer said. ‘Car’s just over here.’

‘Wait . . .’ I said, bewildered, ‘don’t I need an . . . adult with me?’

Brother Stanislaus paused. Clearly, he hadn’t thought to ask this. But the police seemed unconcerned.

‘We have parental consent,’ the policeman said. ‘This way, please.’

It felt like every student was watching as I was led to the car, all of them barely able to conceal their delight. Brother Stanislaus, having handed off my bike, was trying to corral students through the gates, without much success.

‘Parental consent,’ I repeated as they opened the back door of the police car. ‘Who gave you consent?’

But of course I already knew. The policeman put a hand on my head as I climbed into the vehicle.

‘Your father,’ the officer said, and the door slammed shut.

The police talked about football most of the way to the station, making no attempt to engage with me. I was no stranger to loneliness; I’d thought I’d been familiar with its every variety. But as I travelled, alone, in the back of the police car, I discovered that there was a new, particularly potent breed of loneliness. Being alone, and frightened.

I looked out the window. I thought we'd go to the local police station, but instead we went all the way into the city. The building was four storeys high. We parked in the basement.

'How will I get back to school?' I asked when the policeman opened my door. 'Can I call my aunt?'

The policemen were still talking about football and were only half listening. 'You can make a call after you've given your statement,' one of them said.

We rode the elevator to the top floor. I don't think I'd ever yearned for a person as much as I yearned for Cess in that moment. It was so powerful that when the door opened, I was sure I heard Cess's voice.

'I've spoken with my lawyer, who is on his way. He has advised that you may not speak with my niece – a minor – under any circumstances without my permission. Do you understand?'

'Her father has given permission, ma'am.'

The policemen had finally stopped talking about football. I saw them exchange a look. 'This way, please,' one of them said, attempting to move me down the corridor.

I dug in my heels and looked around. I wasn't imagining it. Cess was here.

'Her father?' I heard Cess exclaim. 'Her father doesn't live with her. The only claim he has to her is biological, and frankly, given how intelligent she is, I've long suspected that my sister was spending time elsewhere . . .'

'Cess?' I called.

'Mabel?'

The policeman grabbed my shoulder and tried once again to direct me down the corridor, but I broke away and ran toward her voice. Around a corner, I saw a desk and three exasperated-looking police officers. Then I saw Cess.

'Mabel!'

There was a desk between us. Immediately Cess bent down and began to crawl under it.

‘Ma’am? Ma’am, you can’t come in here . . . ma’am?’

Cess ignored him, crawling under the desk to get to me. On the other side, she got to her feet, and ran.

That feeling I’d had earlier, the intensely lonely one? The feeling I had then was the exact opposite. It wasn’t just the fact that she’d crawled under the desk to get to me. It was the fact that in that moment, I believed she would have done anything.

There was another thing about that moment too, and it was what she said to me when she got her arms around me. Not ‘are you all right?’ or ‘what happened?’ In true Cess style, she cut right to the chase and said, loud enough for everyone to hear:

‘I’m going to kill your father.’

We both began to cry.

58

The cops didn't ask me to give a statement again. Cess said it was because her lawyer scared the bejesus out of them, and she might have been right, but after going to the trouble of coming to my school in a police car, it felt strange that now they didn't need to talk to me at all.

In any case, the damage, as far as my reputation went, was done. News of the relationship I'd had with Mr Loukas had spread far and wide since Tessa had given her statement, which included my visit there that night. Judgement was swift. I was labelled a tart, hussy or harlot, depending on who was talking.

The journey from social outcast to harlot was more treacherous than I could have anticipated. Before, I'd been merely unfortunate and possibly dangerous, but now I was a woman of loose morals, a victim of my own poor choices, which offered a convenient justification to anyone who wanted to pass judgement.

There'd been a time when I hadn't thought my life could get any smaller. I'd been wrong. There were no more bike rides, or bonfires, or long walks. The mothers stopped looking at me at Mass, even Lucy Ormonde, one of my mother's closest friends, who'd hugged me every time she saw me since my mother's death and called me a dear girl. The fathers, on the other hand, started looking at me, eyeballs wide and curious that the strange tall girl was the one to cause all this ruckus – it was always the ones you didn't expect.

Mr Stephens, the father of Dolly and Tammy, spat at me while passing me on the street. Cess said it likely had nothing to do with me, that Mr Stephens had always been vulgar and hadn't been raised to understand that one shouldn't spit in the street, but I wasn't so sure. It felt directed. Intentional. I'd come to notice the difference.

Billy Harris, unsurprisingly, wasn't one to quietly ignore what had happened. Whenever I passed him in the corridor he'd make a kissing noise, and ask if I was looking for a new boyfriend, or did I only like older men? One horrible day he even followed me into the girls' bathroom between classes, pushed me into a cubicle, and put my hand on his crotch – a kindness, he said, because I was probably missing it. I stopped using the school bathrooms after that.

I did what I could to stay out of people's way. I volunteered to reshelve books in the library at lunchtime, I picked up litter after school. Unfortunately, I couldn't cease to exist, which appeared to be the only possible way I could avoid the wrath of the community. My name was on everyone's lips, all the time. Apparently, there was no need to whisper it anymore. I heard it in the schoolyard, in the library, on the street. At least I wasn't invisible anymore. I was everywhere.

Mad Mabel.

Mad Mabel.

Mad Mabel.

*

Through the aftermath of Mr Loukas's death, and all the accusations that came with it, Christos was the only person who kept talking to me. In fact, he made a point of talking to me, more than he had before. His friendship made me feel wonderful and terrible all at once. Wonderful, because I was unused to having anyone stand beside me like that, other than Daphne. Terrible because Christos suffered for his solidarity with me, and any hard-won inroads he had made in the social sphere appeared to be lost. Instead, as he walked the hallways, he received the same taunts that all the Greek kids did. Mostly from Billy Harris.

'Wog.'

'Dirty Dago.'

'Moussaka muncher.'

They weren't especially clever or funny slurs, though you wouldn't know it the way Christos laughed. I knew he did it to not allow anyone the satisfaction of hurting him, but he was pretty convincing. Sometimes, he even clapped back.

'Jeez, Billy, somewhere in the world there's a tree working hard to produce oxygen so that you can breathe. I think you should go and apologise to it.'

I snickered.

'What did you say?' Billy said, getting up.

'Oh, you didn't understand?' I said. 'I'd explain but I don't have the time or the crayons.'

Now Christos laughed.

Billy just looked confused.

It was nice having someone to hang out with, other than Daphne. Christos and I sat by each other in class. We walked to and from school. At school, we ate lunch on the bench outside the library, and Christos would tell me about what he was eating.

'This,' he would say, 'is my mum's spanakopita. Best spanakopita in the world.'

Every meal his mother made was 'the best in the world', and indeed, I hadn't tasted a bad one. 'Is that so?'

He grinned.

'Come over for dinner sometime,' he said one day. 'Then you can try Mum's moussaka.'

No one had asked me to come over for dinner before. Certainly not a boy! And now here was Christos, suggesting it as if it were completely normal. I wondered what Cess would say.

'I'd love to,' I said quickly. 'Especially if the moussalata is half as good as the spanakopita.'

'Moussaka,' he said with a laugh.

I snorted. 'Sorry. Moussaka.'

Christos looked me dead in the eye. 'Did you just . . . snort?'

I couldn't help it, I snorted again. Christos burst out laughing. 'You did it again!'

'Hey, it's not as bad as Daphne,' I said. 'She farts when she laughs.'

Christos doubled over laughing. It was like a drug. I was addicted.

We spent the entire lunch period laughing. A few people stared, one made a rude comment. Christos and I just laughed. It wasn't until we were walking back to class that he said: 'Is Daphne your friend?'

I nodded.

'You should tell her to join us sometime.'

I said I would. But I didn't.

The first time Christos kissed me was at the beach. There was a little cove that he knew about that you had to climb over the bluffs to get to, which meant it was secluded and we were the only ones there. He brought fish and chips and a bag of Greek sweets his mother had made. I brought a blanket that we lay on in the afternoon sun.

It was so different from Mr Loukas. Then, I couldn't talk at all. With Christos, I talked and talked and talked. I couldn't stop. I told him about my father, and how much I hated him. I told him about Cess and Ness, and how much I loved them. I told him about my mother, about Kitty. He told me about Greece, about his brothers, about his parents and cousins and uncles.

When we finished the fish and chips, he asked me to close my eyes while he fed me the treats his mother had made. They were delicious, as I knew they would be. More delicious, though, was the feeling of his fingers brushing my lips. It was bliss. It was agony.

I opened my eyes. 'Good?' he asked.

'Very good.'

He grinned. And I knew I'd found him.

I lay down. He did too.

I'd finally found my Gilbert Blythe.

59

It's fair to say that my life hasn't been short of horrors, but there is one particular moment that stands out in my mind.

It was the end of the school day, and I was getting my bike out of the shed. I'd hung back to allow the majority of kids to get their bikes, to avoid running into people. Usually, Christos would have waited for me, but he had left earlier because he had a shift at the fish-and-chip shop.

The problem with this was that, when Billy showed up, no one was around.

'Mad Mabel.'

I was bent over, unchaining my bike. An image of him forcing me into the toilet cubicle crossed my mind.

'Want to go to the sports shed?' he said. 'Isn't that where you and Loukas used to do your thing? Or will any shed do? The bike shed works for me.'

I stood and attempted to wheel my bike around him toward the shed door.

'Hey!' he said. 'I was talking to you. Don't walk away from me.'

He grabbed the wheel of my bike, stopping me. 'You're not going anywhere.'

He stood between me and the door. Billy was taller than me, and stronger. He pulled my bike toward him, pulling me with it. I let go of the bike and turned toward the back of the shed, but he grabbed my shoulder. I heard my bike clatter to the ground.

It didn't make sense to fight him, I knew this much. Instead, I let him spin me by my shoulder, and using this momentum, I surged toward him, propelled by my full body weight. His face morphed from mild amusement to surprise, then finally, fear, as he fell backward. Unfortunately, that was

the moment that Christos appeared behind him. Billy's head connected with Christos's on the way down . . . then Christos's head connected with the asphalt.

60

NOW

As a person who has experienced her fair share of painful emotions, I speak with some authority when I say that you'd be hard-pressed to find a more painful emotion than humiliation. With my neighbours gathered in front of my vandalised house, I fight the urge to shoo them away like stray cats.

I've always taken pride in being a good neighbour. A low-maintenance neighbour. A neighbour who said good morning, who kept the garden presentable, who even – on one occasion – scaled a fence in a rescue effort. I'd kept my head down and my nose out of trouble. It was in my interests to do this, of course, to maintain my anonymity. But now it appeared that both my anonymity and my status as a low-maintenance neighbour were under threat.

'It'll be kids,' Peter declares. 'They watch too much rubbish on those devices these days. They need to play more sport, that's the problem.'

'I hate sport.' Persephone scrunches up her nose. 'Too sweaty.'

Peter nods sagely, as if this proves his point.

'Yes, just kids mucking about,' Roxanne says. 'We're lucky it didn't happen to the whole street.'

Odd people. They all know very well it's not kids who've watched too many screens and it's not a random act of vandalism. Perhaps they've all gone mad?

‘I’ve got some turps somewhere, Else,’ Peter says. ‘I’ll clean it up for you.’

‘Nonsense,’ I tell him. ‘I’ll do it.’

‘It’s no trouble,’ he says. ‘Joan will help, won’t you?’

She nods enthusiastically.

Knock me down with a feather.

‘Probably worth speaking to the police, anyway,’ Roxanne says. ‘I can come with you, if you like.’

I’m touched by the generosity of my neighbours, especially as it’s clear to everyone that this isn’t going away. If anything, interest is growing. Which means, more than likely, there will be a next time.

The neighbours don’t deserve to have their lives upended like this. All of these people, my neighbours, deserve to be safe. And as long as I live on Kenny Lane, I am putting all of them at risk.

61

When Persephone asked me if she could have one of her friends over for a playdate, I'll admit I didn't jump at the opportunity.

'It's bad enough having one small child to look after,' I told her, 'two of you will put me in an overdue grave!'

The child had laughed heartily and now I find myself entertaining her and her little friend Delly. *Delly!* Ridiculous name. Nugget, judging by her incessant barking, is just as unhappy about it as I am.

'Grandma? Grandma? GRANDMA?'

It takes four attempts for me to realise that Delly is addressing me.

'Did you just call me Grandma?' I ask, appalled.

Delly raises a defiant eyebrow. *What of it?*

Bold as brass, Aunt Cess would have said.

'She's not your grandma!' Persephone says, howling with laughter. 'She's not even *my* grandma!'

'Then who is she?'

'*She* is a fool,' I say, 'for agreeing to have you two for afternoon tea.'

Another round of giggles.

It pains me to say it, but Delly is a dear little girl, with thick black hair in pigtails with red ribbons and an absolute belief in herself that I haven't seen even in grown white men. I've spent the entire afternoon watching her, wondering what she is going to do or say next. Persephone is watching her too. Watching them together, I find myself thinking about Cess and Ness. And Daphne and me.

'I'm going to call you Grumpy Granny,' Delly says after a moment.

'Me too,' Persephone says.

They roll about in hysterics. Pieces of work, both of them. And yet, I'm not offended in the least. In fact, as I make my way to the kitchen to put the

kettle on, I find myself chuckling.

'Can we make an apple pie, Granny?' Delly says.

'Yeah, Granny!' Persephone echoes.

'No. You've already had an ice cream, a bowl of grapes and some popcorn.'

Delly and Persephone are already pushing stools up to my kitchen counter. Persephone gets my apron off the hook on the back of the pantry door and puts it on.

'For pity's sake,' I say, getting the pastry out of the freezer.

'I like your granny,' Delly whispers to Persephone as they roll out the pastry a few minutes later.

'Me too,' Persephone says. 'You're the best granny in the world, Elsa.'

'An honour,' I mutter with faux grouchiness.

But my heart hurts because I know that being the best granny in the world isn't just about baking or sleepovers. The best granny in the world wouldn't let her presence put them in additional danger. The best granny in the world would make sure the child – and her mother – was safe.

With great honour comes great responsibility.

Persephone had gone home, as had Delly. They'd eaten the entire apple pie, bar one slice that I'd saved for my dessert. After Roxanne came to take Persephone home I noticed the plate that I'd left the remaining piece of pie on was empty.

I chuckle. You had to admire the audacity.

'R.J. Kenton Real Estate, Sailor speaking, how may I help you?'

'Sailor?' I exclaim. 'Did you say your name was Sailor?'

'I did. Who am I speaking with?'

I don't like to be judgemental, but frankly, I'm appalled. What will people call their children next? Builder? Teacher? Archaeologist? As far as I'm concerned, calling your child Sailor was a declaration that you had far too much time on your hands, and anyone who attempted to name their

child that should be issued the name Eustace or Darold by the government as punishment.

'My name is Elsie Fitzpatrick,' I say, 'from 2 Kenny Lane. I'd like to speak to Rebecca Kenton, please.'

I'd discovered a fridge magnet in my letterbox a few weeks back and thought, Well, I may not require the services of a real estate agent, but then a fridge magnet is a fridge magnet, isn't it? For the last week it has held up a self-portrait of Persephone sporting a very high ponytail that resembles a penis. I'd found it very off-putting, and ended up placing the magnet directly over the penis/ponytail. This morning, as I reached for the fridge door, I realised that I *did* require the services of a real estate agent after all.

'May I ask what it is regarding?' the woman asks, an idiotic question if ever I've heard one.

'I'll give you three guesses.'

I'm being a smart-arse, but mother of God . . . I was tired. Until a few weeks ago, Kenny Lane had been home. It had been a quiet place. A safe place, for me and for the neighbours. It wasn't that place anymore, because of me. It may not have been my fault. But I had the power to change it.

I wait, but she doesn't even have one guess. A sense of humour wouldn't hurt, I think. Especially with a name like Sailor.

'I'd like to put my house on the market,' I say.

62

THEN

As Christos's head cracked against the asphalt, I screamed.

It felt so dramatic, so indulgent, so girlish. Like a woman in a horror film about to be devoured by a zombie.

'You psycho!' Billy screamed at me. 'Look what you did!'

He stepped back, giving me a sight line to where Christos lay. Billy kneeled beside him. 'Christos? You okay, man?'

Christos opened his eyes and touched his temple, dazed.

'She tried to kill you,' Billy said.

'Who?' Christos looked confused. 'Mabel?'

'Yes, Mabel,' Billy said. 'Who else do you know going around killing people?'

'Sorry, man.' Christos sat up slowly. 'You're right. Of course it was Mabel.'

I felt that in my core, somewhere near my heart. Billy looked smugger than he'd ever looked.

'It's not as if you'd be able to knock over two guys with a single push,' Christos continued. 'Whereas Mabel can do it easily.'

Christos glanced at me, and I saw something like . . . mischief in his eyes. It took a few seconds for Billy to understand.

'I could knock you down with my little finger,' Billy said, getting to his feet. You could see how enraged he was at the idea of being knocked down by a girl. 'Anyway, she knocked you down worse.'

‘She knocked *you* down,’ Christos said, getting to his feet. He wobbled a little. ‘With enough force that you fell into me and knocked me down.’

Christos made the noise of someone withholding a laugh. It set me off and I let out a snort.

Billy seethed. ‘You better not tell anyone, Christos. Or you, Mad Mabel.’

Christos made a salute. ‘Scout’s honour.’

‘Better stay away from me,’ I said as Billy wheeled his bike out of the shed. ‘Since I go around killing people. Wouldn’t want you to be next.’

He scowled, but he picked up his pace on the way out the door. Christos and I managed to hold in our laughter until he was gone, but when it came, I’m pretty sure he could have heard it from back at his house.

After the incident at school, Christos insisted on walking me home.

‘You are the one who was injured! I should be walking you home!’

He rolled his eyes. ‘Come on. A little bump to the head isn’t going to stop me being chivalrous.’

He threw me a wink, and I felt so shy I had to look away. We walked in silence for a moment.

‘Why did you come back anyway?’ I asked him. ‘I thought you had a shift at the fish-and-chip shop.’

‘I do,’ he replied, blinking against the afternoon sun. ‘But I felt like I needed to come back. Call it a feeling. You know?’

I wasn’t sure I did. ‘A feeling?’

‘A gut instinct that something was going to happen.’

‘So you came back to check on me?’

The idea that he was thinking of me – worried about me – felt foreign and almost impossibly lovely. He had always been kind to me, but this was something more.

‘Yep. I should have known that you’d have it covered.’

He started to grin, then winced and pressed his fingers lightly to his temple.

‘You okay?’ I asked. ‘You hit your head pretty hard.’

‘I’m fine,’ he said. ‘Stop worrying.’

But as we approached the turnoff toward my place, he kept wincing, and his usually olive skin seemed almost ashen.

‘I think I’ll walk you home,’ I said. ‘Just to make sure you get there okay.’

‘I’m fine,’ he insisted again, though his voice lacked its usual confidence. ‘I just have a bit of a headache, that’s all.’

‘Because you hit your head. Which was my fault.’

Christos refused to accept that it was my fault, but he let me walk him back to the fish-and-chip shop. The scent of hot oil and salt announced we were close, as did an angry-looking dark-haired woman standing out the front, her hands clasped.

‘Uh-oh,’ Christos muttered. ‘My mother.’

Christos’s mother wasn’t smiling. She stood upright, her hands tightening, her knuckles white as she fiddled with her flour-stained apron.

The moment she saw him, she stepped forward, her voice sharp. ‘Where have you been, Christos? You’re half an hour late.’

‘He hit his head!’ I blurted before Christos could answer, hoping to shield him from her wrath. After everything that had happened today, the last thing I wanted was for him to be in trouble with his mother too.

After assessing her son, presumably for injury, her dark eyes flickered to me. ‘And you are?’

‘Mabel Waller, ma’am.’

I saw the recognition in her eyes and braced myself. I knew my reputation preceded me, but I had hoped that, being new to the community, she might not know who I was. Her expression hardened.

‘I see.’

She turned back to Christos, pushing a few loose hairs back into her bun. ‘What happened to your head?’

‘I fell. In the bike shed. I’m fine, but it made me a bit late.’

‘You fell?’ Her eyebrows rose. ‘You’re not a clumsy boy, Christos.’

‘It was my fault,’ I admitted. ‘I pushed Billy and Billy fell onto Christos.’

Her gaze returned to me, sharper and cooler this time. ‘Is that right? I hear you have a bit of a reputation for causing trouble.’

‘Mum,’ Christos started, but she cut him off with a single glare.

‘Don’t talk back, Christos.’ Then she switched to Greek, her voice rising in rapid, clipped words. From the way her eyes darted back to me now and then, I knew at least part of what she was saying was about me. Probably all of it.

Christos turned his back on his mother, his expression apologetic but resigned. ‘Just go, Mabel. I’ll see you tomorrow.’

‘I’m so sorry,’ I said softly.

‘Not your fault.’ He managed a small smile, even as his mother continued her tirade beside him.

‘I hope your head is okay,’ I murmured as I pulled my bike upright.

I was still within earshot when his mother’s voice cut through the air in English, cold and firm. ‘I don’t want you hanging around with that girl again, do you understand?’

I didn’t wait to hear Christos’s reply. I pedalled away quickly, wondering if Christos would listen to his mother. And wondering if I could stand it if he did.

63

NOW

Libby and Adeem arrive early the next morning. There are no treats from Meera this time, no small talk. We only have one more day to finish filming and they are all business.

'We've had some interest from sponsors,' Libby says excitedly, 'but they want a finished product, so we have to hustle.'

And so, I follow their lead, making cups of tea efficiently without too much chitchat. But secretly I'm disappointed. I'd come to enjoy their visits, and I liked the chitchat the best.

'Just confirming,' Libby starts, when we're all set up, 'that we've covered everything to this point.'

Adeem looks at his notes: 'We've got her sister's death, her mother's death, Billy's injury, Mr Loukas's murder, and of course, Christos's fall.' He looks up. 'Whew. That's a lot of stuff.'

'It's a lot of stuff to be held responsible for,' I agree. 'And yet, when you're accused of one thing, it becomes pretty easy to be held responsible for others too, at least in other people's eyes. I just stood by while they stacked up. It played right into my father's hands. A perfect crime. My aunt was wrong when she said he wasn't clever.'

'Do you want to talk about that?' Libby asks.

'No,' I say. 'But that's what we're doing here, isn't it?'

Libby nods at Adeem to get the camera rolling. 'Hopefully there are no interruptions today,' she says. 'We have a lot to get through.'

64

THEN

‘Mabel? Is that you?’

When I got home from school, I found Cess and Ness at the kitchen table, which, rather than being covered in food, was covered in manila folders and stacks of paperwork. They both had a glass of whiskey.

As I entered, Ness reached for the seat beside her and pulled it out.

‘What is it?’ I asked.

‘We’ve had a letter from your father’s lawyer.’

Neither Cess nor Ness was looking at me, which was unusual. ‘A letter about what?’

‘What do you think? About his pride and joy.’ Cess lifted her hand and gestured around. ‘Rosehill. His lawyer is making a claim that he should be entitled to this place. Don’t worry, Mabel, we expected this.’

‘But he isn’t entitled to it,’ I said nervously. ‘Is he?’

‘No,’ she said. But not with as much conviction as I’d have liked.

‘Does your lawyer think Dad is entitled to the house?’

Cess let out a long exhale. ‘He thinks your father could make a case that he is. The law is a slippery thing; he can argue that he’s entitled to anything. It will be up to the judge to decide if his case has merit.’

‘What kind of case can he make?’

‘From the sounds of it, his case will be based on a few things, but the long and short is that he’ll argue that he needs the house more than I do.’

‘He needs it? For what? Parties?’

Neither of them responded.

'What?' I asked.

Cess and Ness exchanged a look. 'In not-entirely unrelated news, we heard today that your father is getting married. To Susan. And he's arguing that he needs the house to raise his family.'

'Family? What family?'

'Well.' Ness dropped her gaze. 'Susan has a young daughter, Amelia.'

I hated the sting that this information brought. I found myself thinking of the pretty little girl I saw with him at Mass. 'So he can argue that he needs the house so he can raise his new family?'

Cess looked me straight in the eye. 'The strongest argument he has for claiming the house is that, along with his new wife and stepdaughter, he'd be raising you, the heir to the house, inside it.'

65

The day after Cess received the letter from my father's lawyer, I grabbed Daphne, and we went for a ride.

I needed to process my thoughts. Christos hadn't been at school that day and I'd spent the day obsessing about the reasons for his absence. The best I could hope for, I figured, was that his mother had kept him home in order to keep him away from me. The worst was that his head injury had deteriorated after I left. The memory of Billy's injury and his stay in the hospital was fresh in my mind. Christos had hit his head hard. If something had happened to him, it was my fault. Why did this keep happening?

The other thing on my mind, of course, was my father. I'd always known my father loved Rosehill, but I don't think I'd understood the extent of it. Had he only married my mother for the house? Had his plan always been to dispense with her when he had what he wanted? If that was the case, it was little wonder that he wasn't a fan of me.

'Where are we going?' Daphne asked me, for the seventeenth time.

'One thing I love about you, Daph,' I replied, 'is that you don't ask questions.'

She rolled her eyes. 'Just be grateful I'm still here despite the fact that you haven't answered.'

We pedalled on.

After half an hour we arrived at a house on a quiet tree-lined street. It wasn't Rosehill by any stretch, but it was a pretty bungalow, with shutters and brightly coloured daisies in planter boxes, overlooked by a huge jacaranda, which held a fair-haired little girl in its branches.

My father's car was in the driveway.

'Who is that?' Daphne said as we watched from across the street, tucked behind a tree.

‘That’s my father’s new family.’

It hadn’t been hard to find Susan’s address. I’d got it from the parish directory. I wasn’t sure that he would be there, of course. He’d have his own place, most likely – he wasn’t so unorthodox as to live with a single mother before they were married – but I felt there was a good chance he would be there at dinnertime, as my father wasn’t a cook, nor was he the type of man who would like to open a tin of beans for dinner.

Amelia was high up in the tree, lost in her own little world, gesturing and smiling and talking, playing multiple roles in her imaginative game. It reminded me of the way I’d play when I was her age. She was a sweet-looking child – ethereal – small and fair and pixie-like. This didn’t remind me of myself at all.

‘Amelia! Time to wash up for dinner!’

Amelia broke free of her game. ‘Coming, Mama.’

Even her voice was sweet. Through the leaves and flowers, I watched her making her way carefully down the tree until she reached the last branch, which was a significant height from the ground. She must have had help to get up there.

‘Mama!’ she called out. ‘It’s too high.’

Daphne and I ducked behind the tree as the door squeaked open. But when I peeked around, I saw it wasn’t Susan who came outside. It was my father.

The sight of him made me slick with sweat.

‘It’s okay,’ Daphne said. ‘Just stay down.’

Dad crossed the lawn and extended his arms up to Amelia. Given the extent to which I hated this man, it shouldn’t have felt like such a betrayal. His back was to me so I couldn’t see his facial expression. Was he smiling at her? Was she smiling back? I strained to hear conversation between them, but I heard nothing until an impatient ‘Come on,’ from my father.

He was a tall man, and his arms almost reached her, so what happened next made no sense. He was right under her when Amelia slid from the tree toward his waiting arms. But instead of him catching her, she kept on sliding. He made no move to grab her as she let out a tiny, shocked scream.

A millisecond later she smacked against the ground.

The sound of Amelia's cries, high-pitched and pained, would forever remain etched into my brain.

'Stop making a fuss,' my father told her.

Susan was out the door within seconds. She swept the child into her arms. 'Shhh, darling. Mama's here. It's okay. Shhh.' To my father she said: 'What happened?'

'I wasn't ready. She just jumped. You need to pay attention, Amelia!'

Amelia was wailing, clutching her right arm. Susan thought it might be broken.

My father wondered if dinner was nearly ready.

I thought of all the times my father had been annoyed with me for something outside my control, and how my mother had pandered to him, to the point of dismissing me. I remembered the confusion I felt during those times. The shame I felt. It was different watching it happen to someone else. Instead of feeling confused, I felt clear. Instead of feeling shame, I felt rage.

Susan carried Amelia back into the house, and my father followed unhurriedly.

Daphne pedalled home much slower than she had on the way there. We didn't speak. Daphne understood, without being told, that I needed time to process things.

What had I wanted to see? It was true I'd felt betrayed at the idea of being replaced by another daughter. Even the love that he had apparently felt for Kitty served to remind me that I'd been deficient as a daughter. If he'd caught Amelia, and showed affection toward her, it would have been yet another knife in the back. But seeing him reject that little girl, with her soft voice and innocent play, wasn't what I wanted either.

I may not have known why I felt compelled to go there that day, but I'll always be glad I did. Because that was the day I realised that my father was a monster. And it was never about me at all.

66

I probably should have been grateful. Christos had not died, nor had he become brain damaged from the fall. He'd had a couple of days off school with a bad headache, but the following Monday he was back, and more or less good as new.

Unfortunately, my concern about his mother turned out to be founded.

'I'm sorry, Mabel,' he said. 'I don't know what's wrong with her. She knows what it's like to be judged unfairly. Ever since we came to Australia, she's complained about people judging us because we're Greek!'

I nodded.

'We can still hang out at school.'

'I understand,' I said. And I did. Good things were for other people, not for me. My father had made sure of it.

The least I could do was ensure the same fate for him.

Three months after his death, Mr Loukas's fiancée was charged with his murder. Within a few days, she'd confessed.

Daphne, as it turned out, was spot-on about how she did it. She'd hit him in the head with a wrought-iron poker from the fireplace, then dragged him to the car to dispose of his body and saw the flat tyre. That's what gave her the idea of framing it to look like an accident. So you could say, in a way, I helped.

The fact that Tessa's confession did nothing to quell rumours about my involvement was sad but not surprising, particularly when it became apparent that my father was the one fuelling the rumours.

'Maree Stephenson told me today that I should tell Mabel to confess!' I overheard Cess saying to Ness one evening after they thought I was in bed.

‘Never mind that the police already have a confession. Maree said she had it on good authority that Mabel had pressured the woman into a false confession – though she was unclear on how a fifteen-year-old girl could have convinced a young woman to do this. The only thing Maree was clear on was that if the child’s own father believed she did it, it was good enough for her. Honestly, Ness, I’m understanding my sister more and more every day. If I’d been married to that man I’d have jumped off a balcony as well.’

‘Why is he doing this?’ Ness asked. ‘I know he wants the house, but putting his daughter in the line of fire is a special kind of evil.’

‘The man *is* a special kind of evil. How he sired that darling child will forever be a mystery to me.’

But while Cess and Ness raged by night, whenever I was around, they were more measured.

‘You just ignore them, Mabel,’ Cess would say, when I’d report what someone had said at school that day. ‘It doesn’t matter a jot what anyone thinks because people are idiots and only an idiot would care what another idiot thought of them, and you aren’t an idiot, are you, Mabel?’

‘No,’ I’d say, feeling like I was the one comforting her rather than the other way around. ‘I’m not an idiot.’

Ness was slightly more thoughtful. ‘People tend to go with the pack, Mabel. They believe what other people tell them rather than thinking for themselves. If they thought about it for even a second, they would realise that it is ridiculous to suggest that you would be capable of doing anything like this.’

But I wasn’t so sure. Other than Cess and Ness, possibly Christos, and of course, Daphne, no one knew me well enough to know what I was capable of. There was no one out there discounting me because no one had ever known me. The fact that no one had known me created suspicion and kept people away. And the self-perpetuating hamster wheel kept whirling.

‘It’s never too late,’ my mother was fond of saying when she was alive. But in a lot of scenarios, it wasn’t true. It was definitely too late for me to have the kind of life that most kids took for granted – a life with a loving family, a friend or two, a supportive community. A life of people who

noticed you were there . . . or, dare I say it, wanted you there? It was a simple goal for most, but a lofty dream for me. And while it might have been possible at one point, it was too late now. Perhaps it had been too late from the moment I was born.

'I'm sorry,' I said to Cess and Ness one night. They'd been sitting up at the bar in the front room having a drink while I eavesdropped from the bottom step of the staircase. Cess had been smoking and raging and drinking and raging some more. Ness had mostly been placating her, but even she had raged a couple of times. It was only when Cess said, 'Is this the pain of motherhood? This tiny, little stabbing pain in the heart?' that I'd revealed myself, in my pyjamas. Cess and Ness immediately slid off their barstools. 'Mabel!'

'I'm sorry.' I was crying, but they weren't sad tears. I wasn't sure what they were.

Cess looked alarmed. 'Why are you sorry, child?'

'For . . . the tiny, little stabbing pain in your heart.'

They exchanged a look. 'Darling,' Cess said, smiling. 'You've nothing to be sorry for. That stabbing pain is the greatest gift you've given us.'

I didn't understand. 'But . . . how is pain a gift?'

'I'm not sure either of us can properly explain it, Mabel,' Ness said. 'Other than to say it's the pain of loving and being loved. One day you'll understand.'

Cess nodded. 'All I can say is that once you've felt it, you'll realise that the only thing worse than the stabbing pain is the absence of it.'

They were both emotional, so I let them hug me and I didn't ask any more questions. But I didn't understand it. And I didn't share Ness's confidence in her assertion that one day I would.

67

NOW

I talk. I talk and I talk and I talk. As Adeem and Libby listen, their faces move in the most pure and unusual ways, morphing before my very eyes from childlike youth in one breath, to wise and empathetic the next. It's almost as though the angles of their faces become more defined with every vulnerability I reveal. There's a magic to it – a beauty. Sometimes I wish young people knew how beautiful they were, and I'm not just talking about pretty ones. Even Adeem has a beauty to him. Even I did once, I suppose. It's fascinating, watching people. Miraculous, really.

Adeem gets three calls from Meera over the morning and only answers one. Libby gives him a high five as he lets the second one roll over to voicemail. By the time he answers the third, the underarms of his pale blue shirt are drenched almost down to the waist.

'Time for a break,' Libby says finally. 'Answer your bloody phone, Ads, you're giving me anxiety. Elsie – cup of tea?'

Libby likes a cuppa almost as much as I do. I nod and she heads to the kitchen. She's become very comfortable here, moving about my house, making tea, rearranging furniture as the light fades. At one point she says: 'Your tea towel needs a wash. Where's the laundry, I'll throw it in the machine.'

I can't decide whether I'm embarrassed that the tea towel hadn't been washed or touched that she offered to do it. I think mostly I'm warmed

through at the idea of someone being so familiar with me and my home that they are comfortable enough to suggest it.

While she makes the tea, I go outside to check the mailbox. The street is quiet, no one lurking about. I almost miss Persephone, sitting on the pavement outside my house, part hidden by the rosebushes. 'What are you doing in the gutter, child?'

She doesn't turn around. Her arms are crossed and resting over her knobbly knees. Her shins are covered in the scrapes and bruises of childhood. 'You're not selling your house,' she says. 'I'm not letting you.'

At first I'm confused, but then she points to a sign – FORTHCOMING AUCTION – lying on the ground beside her. It is apparent that it's been pulled out of the grass.

'Oh,' I say. 'I didn't realise they'd put that up.'

'You can't move,' she says sulkily. 'Who will look after me when Mum's at work?'

In another life, I'd have sat in the gutter beside her, but that life doesn't contain my arthritic knees. Instead, I walk out onto the lane and stand in front of her. 'Persephone –'

'Who will make me apple pie?'

I sigh. 'I'm sure that your mum can –'

'Where will Delly and me go to play?!'

I stop trying to reply. Instead, I begin the slow and foolish descent into the gutter beside her. I may never again get to my feet.

'Who will be my grandma?' she says quietly when I land beside her. She slowly looks at me, and her eyes shimmer with tears. It's too much for me. I feel it in my heart first, a tiny pinprick that quickly becomes a stabbing pain.

'Come here, pet,' I say.

She wraps her arms around my waist. As she sobs, a few tears of my own escape, but I wipe them away before anyone can see. *So this is the pain of loving*, I think to myself. *This is the pain of being loved.*

When I return to the house, it's clear Libby and Adeem have been conferring and are ready to bring things to a close. Fair enough. We all know what we're here for. Every word I've spoken, every dusty memory I've hauled out of the vault – it's all been leading to this. Time to get the show on the road.

'This is the big one, Elsie,' Libby says as I sit down. She lays a hand on mine. 'You ready?'

But I'm not sure I am. I haven't revisited this day in sixty-six years. Not properly. Not out loud.

Libby gives a small, encouraging smile. 'Right then. Tell me about the day of the murder. What happened?'

I'm just retelling it, I know that. It's over now. And yet, as I open my mouth to talk, and images of that day flash before my eyes – I feel the air shift, as though the past has slipped into the room beside me.

68

THEN

It rained from dawn until dusk. That slow, relentless kind of rain that slides down your neck and settles into your bones, turning everything heavy – your clothes, your limbs, your thoughts. I'd felt off all day – headachy, nauseous, like I was on the edge of something. A cold, maybe. Or something worse. A knowing.

That morning, I'd told Cess I'd be late. I'd taken to lingering at school, waiting for the bike shed to empty out before I collected my things. But today I had a legitimate excuse: I owed the library three overdue books and figured returning them would soothe my conscience.

But when the final bell rang, I couldn't face it. The idea of spending another minute in that building turned my stomach. I headed straight for the bike shed, mounted my bike, and pedalled home through the rain like my life depended on it.

The moment I entered the gates I saw his car. Parked right in the driveway like it belonged there. My whole body seized up. I nearly turned around. I *should* have turned around.

Even now, all these years later, I don't know why I didn't. Maybe I was too tired to think straight. Maybe some twisted part of me hoped it would be different this time. Or maybe – most likely – it was plain old stupid curiosity.

I dragged my bike up the path and onto the porch. Ness's umbrella was propped beside the door, dripping a quiet, steady rhythm onto the tiles.

When I opened the door, I heard him immediately. His voice carried on the polished boards, booming like a thunderclap.

'You filthy whores.'

I froze.

'Get out of here, Elliott!' That was Cess, fierce and unyielding.

'Get out?' my father cried. 'This is my house.'

'Actually, it's *my* house,' Cess replied.

'Not until a judge declares it so!'

I remained in the doorway, soaked through and trembling. I didn't call out. Didn't move. Every instinct told me to run – but instead I crept up the stairs like a ghost.

'What would your sister say, Cecily?' My father was roaring now. 'Engaging in this *unnatural* behaviour. And after I left my impressionable daughter in your care.'

I gripped the banister so tightly my fingers hurt. By the time I reached the top of the stairs, my heart was beating so loud I could barely hear them anymore. The door to Cess's room was wide open. My father's umbrella was leaning against the wall outside, dripping onto the carpet, and I found myself focusing on it. That umbrella had been a present from my mother. My father had loved it. He'd made a big deal about the workmanship – the handmade wooden frame, the sterling silver handle. The fact that she'd cared enough to get him this struck me for a moment, but only a moment. Because then, inside the room, I saw them.

Cess and Ness.

They were on the bed, wrapped in a sheet – barely. Cess's arm was around Ness, their bodies pressed close, hair mussed, cheeks flushed. It didn't make sense. Or maybe it did, but only in some far-off, abstract way, a way I hadn't allowed myself to consider. Seeing it with my own eyes was different. Shocking. Terrifying. *Wrong*, my mind screamed, even though some deeper part of me whispered that maybe it wasn't.

'She's not your daughter.'

Cess's voice cut through the fog in my head as she stood and faced my father. She wasn't cowering. She wasn't even flinching. 'You don't get to

call her that anymore. You've done nothing to earn the role of a father. You abandoned that child emotionally from the moment she was born, blamed her for the death of her sister, ruined her reputation in the community, and then, just months after bullying her mother to suicide, you take up with another woman. And don't get me started on how you've cast suspicion on her for her teacher's murder even though another woman has confessed. It's no wonder the child has to retreat into a fictional world to find solace.'

'That child lives in a fictional world because she's mad. Mad Mabel!'

I flinched. And that small, traitorous movement drew all their eyes to me.

'Mabel.' Ness's voice. Soft. Aching.

My body flushed hot, then cold. I wanted to disappear, vanish into the floorboards. My throat had closed up. I felt like I might vomit.

'I . . . I wasn't feeling well,' I managed, barely above a whisper. 'I came home early.'

My father's face twisted in disgust – at me, or Cess and Ness, I wasn't sure. 'Good. Pack your bag, Mabel. We're getting out of here.'

His voice turned my insides to liquid.

'It's all right, darling,' Cess said to me, calm as ever. 'Ness, can you take Mabel downstairs, please?'

Ness moved – slow, careful, like she didn't want to spook me. She bent to pick up her clothes from the floor.

But I didn't wait. I turned and ran.

I wasn't a runner. I was clumsy, always had been. But I flew down those stairs like hell was at my heels. The screen door slammed behind me. I didn't stop running until the house was a blur in the distance and the rain had soaked me straight through, like it was trying to wash the whole thing away.

I heard Ness calling my name as I left, but it was quickly drowned out by the driving rain. The adrenaline, the thunder of my heartbeat and the blood swirling in my ears did little to offset the horror I felt, but at least they gave

me momentum as I fled the scene, leaping over the fence between our house and the neighbour's, and then the fence after that. Idly, it occurred to me that, had I completed the back-fence challenge all those years ago, I would have got one of Mrs Casey's milkshakes for sure.

I had no plan. I didn't know where I was going. All I knew was that I had to get as far away from there as I possibly could. Far enough that I could go back in time and unsee what I'd just seen, unhear what I'd just heard. Of course, I ended up seeking out Daphne.

'What's wrong?' she cried when she saw me.

My face was slick with tears. Usually I processed my emotions internally, where I knew they wouldn't be ridiculed. But this day, my feelings didn't get the memo because as I fell into her arms, I let out a sob.

'Ness,' I said, through gasps. 'I saw her . . . with Cess. And my . . . my father saw too.'

I could see Daphne's confusion. 'You saw Cess and Ness? What's so strange about that?'

I couldn't explain it. How did one explain something they didn't understand themselves? I understood queer men existed. Several times I'd overheard my father talking about Roger McGuinness, the old man in the football jersey who hung around the train station, calling him 'camp' or a 'fag' and my mother told me it meant that he was queer. I must have continued to look perplexed because she added: 'It's when men have impure thoughts about other men.'

'More than impure thoughts,' my father called out.

Neither of them had talked about it any further, telling me it was sinful for young ears, so I'd had to obtain the rest of my knowledge on the matter from the schoolyard. From what I cobbled together, there were men who engaged in intercourse with other men, typically while drunk. Some had wives, others were single. All were to be avoided, though I was unclear why, as no one had suggested that these people were violent. I'd never heard of a queer woman, and I'd certainly never suspected Cess or Ness of such a thing.

And so I didn’t tell Daphne any more about what I’d seen, and she didn’t offer any wisdom or explanation that would have made sense. But Daphne did provide me with the one thing I needed in that moment – refuge. I’d always be grateful for that.

69

I returned to the house about an hour after I'd run away. The rain was lighter by then, and afternoon sun was peeking through it, but I was wet and cold to my core.

I wasn't sure why I returned – maybe because I had nowhere else to go. Maybe because something in me knew it wasn't over yet?

I was surprised to see my father's car still in the driveway. He should've been gone. After what he'd discovered upstairs, I imagined he'd be halfway to town by now, laying waste to Cess's reputation, claiming Rosehill as his own. But there was his car.

I hesitated at the porch steps. My heart was pounding again – not the panicked gallop of before, but something slow and heavy, like a war drum. Ness's umbrella was gone, I noticed, leaving a small puddle on the tiles where it had been an hour earlier. *Is that it then?* I wondered. Were Cess and Ness gone? Or just Ness – gone looking for me?

Inside, it was silent apart from the rain ticking softly against the windows. I climbed the grand staircase slowly, imagining Cess waiting for me at the top, Ness nearby with a cup of tea, some soft, strange explanation tumbling from their mouths. Instead, at the top of the stairs I saw my father's umbrella, still tilted against the wall. My fingers curled around the silver handle. It felt oddly warm, though I knew it couldn't be.

The door to Cess's room was no longer wide open, just slightly ajar, and I used my free hand to push on the door. It swung wide with a long, slow creak and my breath caught.

Cess lay sprawled on the parquetry floor, naked. The afternoon light cut through the hallway window, casting her in a strange, golden glow. Her head hung at an impossible angle, eyes wide, her mouth gaping open. Her

lips – painted that morning – were bright red, as usual. Cherries in the Snow.

My father stood over her, his back to me. His jacket was off and his shirt clung to him, damp with sweat. He turned, slowly, deliberately, as though he'd been expecting me.

'You . . . killed her,' I whispered.

He looked over his shoulder at Cess, almost admiringly. His handiwork. Or his trophy. 'Actually,' he said, 'you did it, *Mad Mabel*.'

His face was disturbingly calm. Serene, even. I gripped the umbrella handle, remembering, suddenly, that the maker had told my mother that it was so well-made it could withstand *anything*. I wondered if that was true.

As I took a step toward him, he smiled. That same smug twist at the corner of his mouth. But when I raised the umbrella – high, both hands wrapped around it like a weapon, the pointed steel tip aimed at him – his smile froze.

The first blow was awkward – the tip piercing the flesh under his collarbone, sliding inward, skewering him through the upper chest. He stumbled backward, his eyes bulging in disbelief more than pain.

Before he could find his footing, I regripped the umbrella and aimed for the skull. There was a split second before I lunged when I saw something like recognition in my father's eyes. He didn't scream or plead. It was just this microsecond of pure, soul-deep comprehension.

The tip of the umbrella cracked his brow, split skin and bone, and sent him sprawling onto the floor.

I brought the umbrella down again. And again. And again.

Blood sprayed across my arms, my dress, my cheeks. My hands slipped against the handle. But I didn't stop until my limbs were trembling and my breath was ragged.

Then I knelt beside him. Pressed two fingers to his neck. Waited.

Nothing.

Just the echo of my own breath, and the terrible stillness of what I'd done. I stared at his body – at the blood, at the brokenness. Maybe I was

Mad Mabel after all. Maybe I always had been. But if I was, it was the way he made me. Every ounce of madness in me had his name on it.

70

NOW

Libby and Adeem had let me talk for more than an hour, without interjecting once.

Adeem's phone hadn't even rung during that period, leading me to believe that he must have turned it off. When I finally stop talking, they blink at me for a few minutes, as if the film had ended and the lights had come back on. Now, it's such a relief having someone else speak, I leave them to it.

'To conclude,' Libby says. 'Your father killed your Aunt Cess. Your sister's death was an accident, your mother's death was a suicide.'

'No,' I say.

Libby looks set to continue with her monologue, but this appears to throw her. 'No?'

'My father killed them all. Indirectly, perhaps, but he still did it. My father was poison. He killed everything he touched.'

Libby and Adeem don't respond.

'It's of no consequence to me if you believe this,' I say, 'but if there's one truth I can stand on after my eighty-one years, that is it.'

They are quiet a moment. Then Libby speaks. 'You were found guilty of your father's murder, as well as your aunt's. You admitted murdering your father but have remained steadfast that you didn't kill your aunt.'

'And I still remain steadfast.'

‘Ness spoke for you in court. She also believed your father had killed Cess.’

‘Yes. She was right.’

Libby looks back at her notes. ‘We noticed that the court reviewed your journal during the trial and commented that your entries were incredibly detailed and accurate – the weather, the dates, the tiny, specific details about what you did on certain days. The only part of your journal that couldn’t be verified was . . .’

‘Daphne.’

71

THEN

After I was sure my father was dead, I covered Cess in her blue silk bathrobe. The idea of the police finding her naked was too much for me. I found a pillow, turned her neck carefully, and rested her head against it. I smoothed her hair. All of these actions – tampering with her body – looked very bad for me in court later, but I've never regretted it. Cess would have done the same for anyone.

I left my father in a pool of his own blood.

Then I went to find Daphne. To say goodbye.

I knew what was going to happen to me. Of course I knew. Daphne refused to believe it. She wanted to fight. But I'd been fighting too long.

'I'll be fine,' I said. 'Don't forget: I'm Mad Mabel.'

I tried to smile, to be brave. But Daphne didn't smile.

'I hate that name,' Daphne said as I stood to leave. 'It doesn't fit at all. To me you'll always be Maybelline.'

She smiled at me, through tears, and we hugged. Then I went outside. Daphne came to the window to wave. As I waved back, I thought of that night at the hospital when I tried to conjure up Katie Maurice in the window, just like Anne did, in *Anne of Green Gables*. A few days later, Daphne appeared, just like she did when I was in kindergarten and desperately needed a friend. She was a mirage, an answered prayer. She appeared as if by magic.

72

NOW

‘So who is Daphne?’ Adeem asks.

I’m surprised to feel that my cheeks are damp. ‘Daphne,’ I say, ‘is my *friend*.’

My voice betrays me by cracking. Libby and Adeem are quiet a moment.

‘Records show that there was a child called Daphne Barton enrolled in your kindergarten class,’ Libby says gently. ‘From what we can see, she returned to England with her parents after kindergarten, but we have been unable to find any evidence of her return when you were fourteen.’

I don’t reply.

Adeem looks at his notes. ‘The court expert called it multiple personality disorder. It made sense given the traumas of your childhood – losing your mother and sister while you were so young. This finding allowed you to go to a mental facility rather than a prison, and only be held for five years before you were released.’

‘I know,’ I say.

Adeem looks up. ‘Were you insane, Elsie?’

‘You mean was I mad, Mabel?’ I say, laughing blackly. ‘What do you think?’

‘I think you were perfectly sane then, and you are perfectly sane now.’

‘Thank you.’

Now the tears are falling in earnest. Adeem stands and takes a tissue from the box on the mantel and hands it to me.

'So, she is a . . . fictional friend?' Adeem asks. 'Someone from your early childhood that reappeared to bring you comfort?'

I shake my head.

Libby and Adeem exchange a look. 'You do know that Daphne isn't real, Elsie?' Adeem says.

'I'm not senile, Adeem,' I say sharply. But I stop short of saying she isn't real. It's true that I can't see or hear or smell her. I can't touch her. And yet, like a character in a novel that continues to exist in your mind after you've finished the book, she can't be simplified into real or not real. I know her innermost thoughts, I know what she would do or say in any given situation. I know that without her, I never could have survived. It's hard to imagine anything more real than that.

'I suppose you could call her an imaginary friend,' I admit finally, wiping my eyes with the tissue. 'But when that's the only kind of friend you have, you don't need to make such a disclaimer. Even to yourself.'

It sounds mad, and I understand this. I think about making a joke about how I earned my name Mad Mabel. But I'm distracted by the perplexed looks on Libby's and Adeem's faces.

'But it's not the only kind of friend you have, Elsie,' Adeem says. 'In fact, in the very short time we've known you, it's already become clear that you are surrounded by friends.'

'Really?'

The pair nod like a couple of bobble-headed toys.

'And I don't mean to speak for Ads here,' Libby says, 'but if you'll have us, we're kind of hoping you'll have room for two more.'

I'm embarrassed at the way my heart swells at this, even at my age.

'I'm not sure about Adeem,' I say. 'But I'll take you, Libby.'

Adeem's jaw drops. Libby chortles.

'If we're going to be friends,' I say to Adeem, 'you're going to have to work on your sense of humour.'

He smiles. 'You've got a deal.'

I feel sad the story's over. Sad that I won't have the undivided attention of these two intelligent young people, desperate to hear what I have to say. So when they tell me they have to shoot a few monologues before they go, I hurry to the kitchen to put on a fresh pot of tea.

'What happened to Rosehill?' Libby asks. 'I assume you couldn't inherit it, and with Cess and your father dead . . .'

I pour the hot water into the mugs. 'It went to a second cousin of my mother's in England. She was already the owner of a stately home in the Cotswolds, so she leased it to the council. It's been used for community events, art gallery openings and such since then.'

'Is your mother's cousin still alive?'

'As far as I know she's in her nineties.' I put the kettle down slowly.

'And after she dies?'

'It will go to the next descendent in line.'

'And who is that?'

I shrug. 'In my experience, when there's money to be inherited, someone always materialises.'

'True,' she says. We take the mugs over to the table and I sit in front of the camera. 'Ready to record?'

'Ready.'

'This is actually a great little afterthought,' she says. 'It might be the place to end it.'

She nods at Adeem, who presses Record.

'I read that you gave birth to a child while you were incarcerated,' she says to me.

The comment throws me. 'Wow,' I say. 'You did go deep with your research. That one isn't commonly reported.'

'That was me,' Adeem says proudly.

'All right,' I say. 'No one likes a clever dick, Adeem.'

Libby snorts.

'Well,' she says. 'Don't leave us in suspense. What happened to the baby? And whose was it?'

73

Adeem and Libby are packing up their things when there is a knock at the door.

'Get it,' Libby says. 'We'll finish up here.'

But I'm slow on my feet after all the sitting and by the time I get to the door, Peter is almost out my front gate.

'Hello, Peter.'

He turns back. 'Oh. You *are* home.'

'I know I don't look a day over twenty-five,' I say, 'but I *am* eighty-one. And sadly, I'm not as quick as I once was.'

He chuckles. 'You're a card, you know that, Elsie?'

'Indeed I do. Now, what can I do for you, Peter?'

His smile disappears. 'What can you do for me? Well, for starters, you could tell me what this sign is all about.'

He points at the FORTHCOMING AUCTION sign, which is upright again after Persephone's vandalism. 'Oh.'

'You're selling? What ever happened to "they're going to have to take me out of Kenny Lane in a mahogany box"?'

I sigh. 'When I said that, things were a little different. But now my presence on the street is causing issues.'

'But that's not your fault.'

'Perhaps not. But it's also not *your* fault. Or Joan's or the Nguyens' or Roxanne's. And with a child living on the street now, I think it's better that I clear out.'

Peter shakes his head. 'Where will you go?'

I shrug. 'The country? Somewhere where people keep to themselves.'

'The country?' He's up in arms. 'You're in your eighties, for God's sake!'

‘Old people love the country.’

‘Good for them. But this is your home.’

He makes a cross, petulant face. It makes me smile. ‘Careful. People might think you like having me around.’

He doesn’t return my smile. ‘I *do* like having you around. Besides, before my mother died, she made me promise that I’d look after you. How can I do that if you’re miles away?’

‘By telephone,’ I say.

‘I don’t think my mother would be happy with that.’

‘Well,’ I say, ‘when you promised your mother, things were different. You didn’t know who I was.’

‘You’d be surprised what I know,’ he says.

‘What does that mean?’

But of course, I know what it means. He puts his arms around me. ‘You can’t go. I won’t let you,’ he says. He has tears in his eyes when he says, ‘Mum.’

I lean into him, despite the risk we’ll both topple. I can’t help myself. ‘Darling,’ I say. ‘You don’t have a choice.’

74

‘Hello, Elsie.’

I’m on my porch, secateurs in hand, lopping the heads off roses when I hear Roxanne’s voice calling down the alleyway. I turn, shielding my eyes from the afternoon sun. She looks tired as usual. Her hair is tied up in a very high bun with those loose stragglers around the side that a lot of women her age sport. But unlike the others I’ve seen, the loose stragglers do not look intentional. Her gaze is set, reminding me of the face of someone who lives in a flood or fire zone who has been asked to evacuate and knows what is coming. Resigned.

‘Roxanne. How has your day been?’

‘Long. Actually, I need to talk to you.’

Something in her tone makes me pause. I wipe my hands on my apron, placing my secateurs carefully on the porch railing. ‘What’s wrong?’

‘I saw Shane.’

Of course, it was too much to hope he’d vanish from whence he came. ‘When?’

‘Last night. He was waiting outside when I came home from work.’

‘At 4 am?’ I take off my gardening gloves and put them in the pocket of my apron.

‘Yes. He asked if I wanted to take him back. Said he wanted to be a family again.’

‘For the love of God, Roxanne, tell me you told him to take a hike.’

‘I did,’ she says.

I feel relieved. Roxanne seems like she has a good head on her shoulders, but you never really know. Sometimes it’s the smart women who accept the worst treatment. Father wounds, etc.

‘That’s the problem,’ she adds.

‘What do you mean, that’s the problem?’

‘He didn’t take it very well. He started raging, saying I’d never do any better than him, that I’d be sorry. He doesn’t do well when he is rejected. It’s kind of a . . . trigger for him.’

‘Did he hurt you?’

‘No. I got away. But before I did, he was mentioning Persephone. He’s never done that before. He’s not interested in her at all. Which means the only reason he’s interested in her now is because she is a way to hurt me.’

The ground feels like it’s tilting below me.

‘Did he have a weapon?’

‘Not last night. But once, before I left him, he threatened me with a gun.’

It’s a challenge to remain outwardly calm, but I try for Roxanne’s sake. ‘Have you gone to the police?’

‘I went this morning. For what, I have no idea. They told me to call 000 if he comes to the house again.’

‘For fuck’s sake,’ I say.

Roxanne blinks. ‘Sorry. It just feels weird to hear an old lady say that.’

‘I often say worse, believe me. I’ve said worse in front of your daughter.’

‘I believe you.’ She smiles. ‘I’m sorry to involve you in this, Elsie. But I felt I should warn you, since you have Persephone a few nights a week. You should be on guard – keep your doors locked, etc.’

‘I’ll make sure Persephone is safe when she’s with me,’ I say. ‘I swear it on my life. But I can’t help you, while you are out there at all hours of the night.’

She shrugs. ‘I’ll be all right. Don’t worry about me.’

‘You can’t go on like this,’ I tell her.

‘What choice do I have? I don’t have another house to go to. I don’t have a security guard. I have to deal with reality.’

‘I’m sorry, Roxanne.’

‘Don’t be.’

But I am. Not just sorry – useless. Powerless. I hate that more than anything.

I hadn't realised before that an upside of being alone was that I never had anyone to worry about. No one to protect. But looking at Roxanne, and thinking of that child asleep in my bed with one arm around my waist, I feel the weight of powerlessness like a millstone around my neck.

75

Libby and Adeem's YouTube documentary about my life is called *Magnificent Mabel*. The title was Adeem's idea, and even Libby admits, it's genius.

I'm invited to Adeem's house for a 'screening' before they release it. I dress in my good slacks and blouse, but when I arrive and see the red carpet that has been laid down the hallway of Adeem's apartment, I wish I'd bought a frock.

I'd taken Libby and Adeem up on their offer to bring a 'plus one' and invited Peter. I'd asked Adeem if a 'plus two' would be appropriate so I could extend the invitation to Joan, and while Adeem agreed, Peter said he'd rather just the two of us attend, and assured me that Joan was perfectly happy to sit this one out.

Libby has a plus one too: her best friend, Sasha, a firecracker who tells me she liked me even back when she thought I was a serial killer, and goes on to tell me about all the people she wants to murder: her boss, the fellow she's dating, his mother – and that is this week alone! She asks for tips on how to do it, and I tell her she needs to watch the show, and everyone laughs.

Meera made the canapés, which are delicious. She offers to send me home with some – and Peter too – and Peter comments that he'd need to get his slacks adjusted if he eats even one more (then immediately accepts her offer). Then we are ushered to the 'screening room', which is the living room. It has an enormous television that I assume has been hired specially but turns out is just their regular television. Young people these days.

Meera gives us each some popcorn in a red and white striped bag and Adeem lowers the lights. Peter and I sit on the couch with Libby and Sasha. Adeem and Meera sit on beanbags on the floor.

It starts with a monologue from Libby.

'In 1959, at just fifteen years of age, Mabel Waller became the youngest Australian in history to be convicted of murder. The media interest around the case was enormous, due to the aggressive nature of the crime. Rumours abounded that this was not "Mad Mabel's" first murder, and this has remained the topic of debate for decades. She is known around the world as Mad Mabel. But is she mad? More importantly, is she guilty?

'In a world first, at the age of eighty-one, Mabel Waller is speaking.'

It cuts to Adeem. 'It is our privilege to tell this story. It's a story you'll be familiar with. One you've probably heard countless times, from countless people. But never from the one person at the centre of it. The only person who knows the truth. A person you've come to know as Mad Mabel. But was the child at the centre of this story really mad? Or was she sad? Sad that she lost her sister, her mother, and was socially ostracised at the behest of her father? This isn't the story of a murderer. It's a story of a child who was failed not only by her father, but by all of us. Mabel Waller is her name. This is her story.'

A photo of Rosehill, and then of me, as a child, appears on screen. Then it morphs to me at eighty-one. I'll admit, it's quite a shock, on the giant screen.

Then I start talking.

'It's interesting to note that there are two groups of people who are rarely, if ever, suspected of murder. These groups are elderly women and little girls.

'On the whole, when it comes to murder, the stats very much favour the men. The odd woman is thrown into the mix every now and again, but she's inevitably perimenopausal – and having been through the change myself, I certainly understand why. But an elderly woman or little girl committing murder? It's one in a million.

'I've always liked to think I was special.'

And so it goes on.

Peter's instinct was right, to keep the event intimate. I'm grateful for the small group, and for the low lighting, a thin shield of protection for my

emotions as I hear my story back. But Peter still notices me weeping, because he reaches for my hand in the darkness. Neither of us lets go.

A day after the first episode is 'released' on YouTube, Libby calls to tell me it has 1.5 million views. I ask for context and she tells me that the top-selling newspaper in Australia sells fewer than a million copies per week.

'Right,' I say. 'Well. That's . . . not bad then.'

A week after that, it has 7.5 million views.

And it continues to grow week on week.

'It's gone viral, Elsie,' Peter keeps shouting at me when I come into the laneway. 'VIRAL!'

I suspect Peter has just learned the word 'viral' in this context. I too understand the context, but – call me old-fashioned – I'd prefer that people not shout the word at me in public.

'Sorry,' he says, when I tell him this. 'Point taken.'

It might have made me nervous, the idea of my story being shared so widely, had Libby and Adeem not kept me informed of the correlating influx of support. I didn't even have to take their word for it. One morning I opened my front door to find a hand-painted sign. NOTHING MAD ABOUT MABEL.

For pity's sake.

I put it above the fireplace.

The local police station touches base to apologise for not being more reactive when the vigilantes had come to the house. I now have the sergeant's private phone number and instruction to call, day or night, if I ever feel unsafe. I asked if he'd offer that same support to Roxanne over the road, and he went quiet. Hmmm. All very well to offer support when one no longer needs it, isn't it, Sergeant?

In the last few days, flowers started arriving. Daisies. Freesias. Hydrangeas. Some were sent by florists; others were hand-delivered and left at the door. Each time I leave the house, I return to find more flowers. Joan says my house is like Buckingham Palace after Diana died. Many

contain heartfelt notes about how sorry people are for judging me. I read each and every one.

One day, there is a knock at the door, and I open it to find Peter, looking mildly hysterical. ‘Else – you’ve got to see this.’

‘Don’t tell me,’ I say as he drags me outside. ‘Sale on whipper snippers at Aldi?’

And then I see it. A banner in the sky, being pulled by a small aircraft.

‘Did you do this?’ I ask when I read what it says.

He shakes his head.

‘Who did?’

‘No idea.’

I look away from the sky, down at the cobblestones, but I still see the words in my mind’s eye. Words that at my age, I’d long given up on hearing.

FORGIVE US, MABEL.

76

When I wake up the next morning, Persephone is sitting on my bed. It wouldn't have been odd had she stayed the night before, but she hadn't. I have no idea how she got in.

'People at my school say I'm famous,' she says, the moment I open my eyes.

I yawn. 'Is that right?'

'Because I live on the street with that crazy murderer-lady. You!' she says delightedly.

I rub my eyes.

'Will you give the kids in my class your autograph?'

'Which kids?'

'Rose. Lily. Ava. Ella. Delly.'

Interesting. She's made a few more friends. I push myself up onto my elbows.

'Maybe you could come into my classroom for show-and-tell?'

'Don't be ridiculous,' I say. 'When?'

She giggles.

'How did you get in here, anyway?'

'My mum has a key,' she admits. 'I took it.'

I'd given Roxanne a key a couple of weeks ago when she'd knocked and I hadn't heard. She'd panicked and thought I'd 'done an Ishaan' (aka keeled over and was lying dead on the kitchen floor). I'd agreed to give her a key so she could investigate under such circumstances, which this most certainly is not.

Lucky for Roxanne, I like this circumstance much more, not that I'll ever admit it.

‘Elsie,’ Persephone says. ‘Why did you choose the name Daphne for your imaginary friend?’

I am impressed. ‘You’ve been reading the newspapers?’

‘I watched the YouTube documentary,’ she says.

‘Did you?’ I say. ‘Doesn’t seem like ideal viewing for a seven-year-old.’

‘If you tell my mum, you’re not coming to my birthday party.’

Jeez. Kids can be so snotty sometimes.

‘Fine,’ I say. ‘I guess the damage is done anyway.’

‘As I was saying,’ Persephone says, ‘I think Daphne is a stupid name. I would have called her Daisy.’

‘As would be your right,’ I say, ‘if she was *your* friend.’

She looks thoughtful. ‘Why did you have an imaginary friend anyway?’

‘Well,’ I say, ‘when I was a child, I didn’t have any friends of my own. Not a single one.’

Persephone looks at me, her eyes wide and appalled. ‘Seriously?’

‘Seriously,’ I say. ‘And . . . I read a lot of books. I had a good imagination. So I made one up.’

Persephone is uncharacteristically impressed. ‘What a good idea.’

‘I thought so.’

‘Do you still talk to her?’

‘Sometimes. Less and less, lately.’

I can see the cogs turning in her brain. ‘So . . . you don’t talk to her as much anymore because of me? Because I am your friend so you don’t need her anymore?’

I roll my eyes. The narcissism of children.

She flashes me a self-satisfied grin, and I feel something move in my chest. Looking at her now, the morning sun catching her hair, I can’t believe I never noticed how pretty she is. How precious.

‘Off with you,’ I say. ‘You’re going to be late for school.’

She glances at the clock on the wall and then scrambles off the bed. ‘Bye, Elsie. See you after school.’

‘Not if I can help it,’ I say.

On the way to the door, she pauses at my feet. ‘Cool socks,’ she says, and runs outside.

I look down at my feet. They *are* lovely, it’s true. They’re maroon with grey diamonds. Pure wool.

77

I wake suddenly, in darkness. The air in the room feels disturbed, as if something – or someone – has just moved through it. I stretch a hand across the bed, searching for Persephone's small, warm body. No matter how often I tuck her into her own bed, she always finds her way back to mine. But she's not here. I exhale sharply, my breath loud in the silence. That's right. She's home tonight.

The glowing red numbers of the clock cut through the dark: 1:11 am. A time that feels eerie, like an omen. I reach for my lamp, but at the last moment, I hesitate and leave it off. Instead, I remain still, listening. There it is – faint, fragile. The sound of tinkling, like broken glass swept across a floor. Nugget hears it too. I hear her paws on the floorboards in the corridor, then her head peers around the door, as if to say, 'Do I need to bark?'

'I don't know, Nugget,' I tell her and I pull back the curtains and peer outside. Peter's sensor light flickers on, illuminating light droplets of rain and the quiet, sleeping street. At first, everything looks normal. Then I see him. The Italian Stallion. Shane.

He's standing on Roxanne's porch. And in his arms –

Persephone. Her small form is slack against his chest, her head lolling like a rag doll's. The window behind them – Persephone's room – is shattered, jagged edges glinting in the dim light.

I'm an eighty-one-year-old woman with arthritic knees, but I move like a cheetah, tearing out the door in nothing but my nightie and socks. Nugget scurries after me. The cold, wet pavement bites into my feet, but I don't feel it. All I see is him. Her.

'Hey! You.' My voice is sharp, cutting through the rain-drenched silence.

Shane startles, just for a second. Then his expression hardens. He lifts a hand. He's holding a gun. Nugget barks madly.

'Leave it alone, old lady,' he slurs. His voice is thick with drink. 'And shut your dog up.'

'Shhh,' I say to Nugget, and she stops.

Persephone stirs slightly, shifting in his arms, but she doesn't wake. The way children can sleep through anything will never cease to amaze me.

'Put her down.' My voice is steady, though my insides are trembling.

Roxanne. Where is Roxanne?

As if summoned, Roxanne bolts from the house, her eyes wide and frantic. I'm relieved, at least, that she's okay.

'Shane,' she says.

'Call the police!' I shout.

She hesitates for a second, but perhaps seeing my expression, she disappears inside.

'Put the child down, Shane,' I say, inching forward. 'This has nothing to do with her.'

'Bullshit,' he spits. 'She's mine.'

'Rubbish.'

He falters for a moment, blinking at me. 'She is.'

A light flicks on in Joan's house. Another one follows at Peter's. I see movement behind curtains at the Nguyens'.

Shane sees it too. He shifts Persephone in his arms, and she stirs, blinking against the darkness.

'She might be your child, but she's not *yours*,' I say. My voice is sharp, unwavering. 'She's a human being. Not a tool for your revenge or a way to get what you want. If you stopped thinking about yourself for five minutes you might see what an amazing person she is, and how many people love her.'

Somewhere in the back of my mind, I know I'm not just talking about him and Persephone. And while my father will never hear it, it feels good to say.

‘What’s happening?’ Persephone blinks up at her father. Her lip quivers. ‘Elsa?’

‘It’s all right, darling,’ I say softly.

Roxanne bursts back outside, the phone pressed to her ear. ‘They’re coming,’ she says breathlessly.

Joan and Peter step outside, their silhouettes stark against the light.

Shane’s eyes dart around. He’s cornered, and he knows it. ‘Move!’ he snarls, lifting the gun and stepping forward. I back up instinctively.

‘Mother . . . fucker!’ Shane shouts, dropping Persephone. She lands hard on the ground, then scrambles toward me. ‘You little bitch. Did you just bite me?’

He pushes back his sleeve and even in the darkness I see the child-size ring of teeth marks on his arm. I see the look on Shane’s face before Persephone does. He lifts the gun and points it at her head. I start to run.

Roxanne screams, a sound that rips through the night. Nugget barks madly. Persephone covers her head with her hands.

I lunge.

The gun goes off.

Instinct. That’s what it is. It’s instinct to leap in front of the child. Instinct, but also a choice. It’s one of the easiest, best choices I’ve ever made.

How lucky I am, to be able to choose.

Even before everything goes black, I feel lucky. Because when I go, it’s with my dog barking madly in the background, and the people who love me calling my name – Joan. Roxanne. Peter. And Persephone. My darling Persephone.

78

ELSIE: Three months after I entered the mental institution, I gave birth to a son. A lot of people worked hard to keep this out of the media. Imprisoning a child looked bad enough. But as hated as I was, it was a worse look to have a child give birth while imprisoned.

I was taken to a hospital to deliver, and my labour was spent in a room with a warm but no-nonsense nurse called Maureen, who gave me ice chips and called me ‘pet’. No one else was allowed in the room, but the nurse told me Ness was waiting downstairs, and I drew enormous strength from that.

A doctor came in to deliver the baby, and though it took over an hour of pushing to get the baby out, he never addressed me directly once.

I didn’t hold my son after he was born. I think I could have if I’d wanted to, but I didn’t see the point since I knew what was coming. Perhaps I should have? Still, I felt the little stabbing pains in my heart the moment I first heard him cry.

Afterward, I listened to the chatter of the doctor and nurse as they checked him over, then a different nurse came into the room and took him away. I let my nurse hold me while I cried, and I nodded when she asked if I would like an ice cream. I was fifteen years old.

After five years at the institution, I was released into the community. I studied to be a librarian and got a job at the State Library.

LIBBY: Did you ever see Ness again?

ELSIE: I did. She moved to North Melbourne after Cess died, and started a home that assisted war widows and unwed mothers and their children. I'd never seen her more fulfilled than when she was working at that home. She was beloved by the children and mothers alike. I worked there for a little while I was studying to become a librarian.

ADEEM: That must have been rewarding, working with babies?

ELSIE: It was, in its way. I was grateful for the work, of course, and grateful to earn money and have a place in the world again. But it wasn't the babies that made me tick. I'm not maternal, not in the way some women are. I kept my distance from the babies, mostly. Except for one child.

ADEEM: Oh? Why was that?

ELSIE: There was a little boy I kept coming back to see, a boy who Ness adopted as a newborn. He was a sweet, quiet boy with dark hair like his Greek father's, and already tall for his age. Even after I finished my studies, even after I'd moved in to my own tiny cottage on Kenny Lane, I found reasons to visit, to sit with him, to read to him. He'd been placed for adoption, the file said, by a teenage mother who had given birth in a psychiatric facility.

[Off camera, a gasp can be heard.]

ELSIE: A little boy called Peter.

79

ROSEHILL, THE ESTATE OF MABEL WALLER, HAS A NEW OWNER

After sixty-seven years, Rosehill, the estate of infamous Mad Mabel Waller, has a new owner.

The fate of the property – which has been home to several notable figures, including a former prime minister of Australia, and which became infamous after the murder of Waller's father and aunt – has been hotly debated for many years now, with some believing it would be donated to the council, and others suggesting it would be sold to developers upon the death of the current owner. Waller herself was precluded from inheriting the property due to the Forfeiture Rule, which prevents those who have unlawfully killed another person from benefiting under the deceased person's will, but in a loophole it appears Waller retained the ability to pass along the property to her children.

Before the late Ms Waller's death she had identified a biological son – whom she gave birth to while serving time in a psychiatric facility and had given up for adoption – as the next in line to inherit the estate. The property is believed to be worth in excess of twenty million Australian dollars.

A second series of *Magnificent Mabel* is currently in production by duo AdLib, and is described as a celebration of the life of Ms Waller and will include testimony from several of her former Kenny Lane neighbours.

Waller, who had been interviewed in regards to the suspicious death of her neighbour, was this week exonerated after the toxicology report revealed that the neighbour's death was a result of a lethal vitamin overdose.

80

Persephone

‘Elsa died,’ I say.

We are sitting on the floor of my new bedroom. It’s a very nice bedroom. Peter from Kenny Lane gave Mum a whole lot of money after Elsa died. Elsa left the money to him when she died and Peter said he had a feeling she would like it if he shared it with us. Now Mum and I have moved into a fancy rental. Soon we’ll buy our own house, Mum says. I know this makes her happy. I wish I could be happy. But I miss Elsa too much.

There are colouring books between us on the floor, markers spread about. But neither of us is colouring. Nugget is in my lap, where she always is when I am home. At first I thought she smelled Elsa on me, but it’s been three months since she died. I can’t still smell like her.

‘I know,’ Daisy says. ‘You told me. But this is the first time you’ve said that without crying.’

I still cry all the time. I cried this morning. Maybe it’s weird. She was an old lady. She wasn’t even my grandma. But she was my friend. When you’ve never had a lot of friends, that is important. Elsa knew this. That was another reason we were friends, I think.

‘Maybe you’re starting to feel better?’

Daisy smiles at me hopefully. I like it when she smiles, even though she has oddly small teeth. It makes her face look rounder. She’s not a pretty girl, not like Delly. But she wears nice clothes. Today she’s wearing a magenta

T-shirt with a bedazzled Eiffel Tower on the front. Her glasses are also magenta. It's hard to be sad around someone wearing magenta glasses.

'I don't want to feel better. I feel like if I get better, it means I don't love Elsa anymore.'

'Balderdash. Of course you love her.'

'But what if she's watching me? And she sees I'm happy? And she thinks . . .' I look down at my lap. Nugget looks back at me. I think she's as sad as I am.

'She won't.'

'How do you know?'

'Because I *know*.' Daisy taps her head atop her wispy hair. 'Don't forget, you weren't the only one who knew her.'

I look up at her. I *had* forgotten that. After three months with her, it felt like she belonged to me.

'That's right,' I say. 'You did.'

She smiles. 'Except when I knew her,' she says, 'she used to call me Daphne.'

ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

I am fortunate enough to have a rock-solid group of friends who have been around for most of my life. These women are my lifeline. My safety net. My soft place to land. I like to think I've been theirs too (although I suspect I've been more of a scratchy patch of gravel on which to land on occasion).

Together, we've navigated all the big stuff – first periods, first loves, first babies, divorces, diagnoses, the death of loved ones. These women – wonderfully wise, wildly supportive, and more than a little unhinged (talking to you, Laundry Em) – are my life partners.

Recently, as I navigated my own divorce, it was these women who held me up during the darkest moments – sometimes with tissues, sometimes with wine, always with love. And it got me thinking: what if I hadn't had them? As with most things I ponder on, eventually this question made its way into a book.

Last week, when early copies of this book arrived at our house, my eight-year-old daughter Clementine asked what the book was about.

Me: 'It's about the power of female friendship.'
Clementine (deeply sceptical)**:** 'I thought it was about a granny who murders people?'
Me: 'Exactly. Could you *imagine* a more perfect vehicle for a story about friendship?'

I mean . . . could you?

There are a few real people's names hidden within these pages.

One of these names is Libby Conquest, who bid for the honour of inclusion, raising funds for a cause dear to my heart. Libby (and her partner Adeem) became two of my favourite characters in this book. I hope you like them as much as I do.

The other name is Linda Raiti. Linda – known to many in the book community as @lilyraiti – was a beloved bookstagrammer and all-round beautiful human. After learning of her terminal cancer diagnosis late last year, I was lucky enough to connect with Linda via FaceTime and video messages. A few days before she passed away, I promised I'd name a character after her in my next book. With her family's blessing, it is my privilege to have made good on that promise.

While I have used their names, neither Linda nor Libby inspired the characters themselves – their actions are entirely fictional (and in some cases, legally questionable). Don't sue them, sue me. Actually, please don't sue anyone. For pity's sake.

As always, many hands (and deadlines and coffees) help deliver a book into the world.

First up: Jennifer Enderlin, my editor, cheerleader, truth-teller and partner-in-publishing for *ten* books now. TEN! That's a full decade of collaboration, exclamation marks and occasionally terrifying deadlines. Let's do a hundred more (or at least until one of us retires to a tropical island with no email access).

To the dream team at St. Martin's Press – thank you for championing my books with so much heart, humour, and marketing genius. I love and adore you all.

To my publishers around the world – particularly Alex Lloyd and the team at Pan Macmillan Australia – thank you for all you do. Special thanks to Bri Collins for saving my skin when I accidentally marked up the wrong document. It is a true curse to work with me when anything technical is involved. Or anything involving detail. Or anything that requires me to remember . . . anything.

To the translators: you are brave, wonderful, and probably slightly traumatised by the strange Aussie lingo I insist on using.

To my literary agent Rob Weisbach – thank you for being the calm in every storm, the brains behind the business, and the one who talks me off metaphorical ledges with terrifying regularity. You make the impossible happen again and again and I am so grateful.

To Mum and Aunty Lones, my astute first readers – thank you for reading an early version of the novel and not judging my rudimentary grammar. I'm delighted you loved Mabel as much as I do (despite her foul language). Also thanks to Mum's friend Meredeth Kenny who helped me unlock an important plot point. I suppose I should thank Pansy Beger for this too. 😉

For Sash. If I'm Mabel, you're Daphne. Or possibly the other way around – let's be honest, we're both bat-shit crazy old ladies at heart. We've seen each other through just about everything: heartbreak, hilarity, and more than one trip to the police station (always for you). You are the bravest, most resilient person I know. You also have a blatant disregard for traffic laws and very poor discernment with men. Still, you've made my life a wildly entertaining story. So this story, my darling friend, is for you.

To my readers: thank you for embracing my weird ideas – like books about granny serial killers – and for allowing me to turn them into an actual career. Keep embracing weird things. Keep embracing weird people. Weird people are the best.

Speaking of weird people – thank you to my children. If I had to pick three humans to hang out with for the rest of my life, it would be you three. I love you fiercely. I am endlessly proud of you. And I'd like to take this opportunity to say: please stop sticking used ice-cream sticks down the back of the couch. I know you say it isn't you, but it's not me, and unless we have a stealthy dessert-loving burglar, we all know who it is. Do better. ILY.

About Sally Hepworth

Sally Hepworth is the *New York Times* bestselling author of ten novels, including *The Soulmate* and *Darling Girls*.

Drawing on the good, the bad and the downright odd of human behaviour, Sally writes incisively about family, relationships and identity. Her domestic thriller novels are laced with quirky humour, sass and a darkly charming tone. They are available worldwide in English and have been translated into twenty-five languages. *The Family Next Door* is Sally's first book to be adapted for the screen.

Sally lives in Melbourne, Australia, with her family and one adorable dog.

The Younger Wife

Sally Hepworth

The moment she laid eyes on Heather Wisher, Tully knew this woman was going to destroy their lives.

Tully and Rachel are murderous when they discover their father has a new girlfriend. The fact that Heather is half his age isn't even the most shocking part. Stephen is still married to their mother, who is in a care facility with end-stage Alzheimer's disease.

Heather knows she has an uphill battle to win Tully and Rachel over, while carrying the burden of the secrets of her past. But, as it turns out, they are all hiding something.

The announcement of Stephen and Heather's engagement threatens to set off a family implosion, with old wounds and dark secrets finally being forced to the surface.

A garage full of stolen goods. An old hot-water bottle, stuffed with cash. A blood-soaked wedding. And that's only the beginning . . .

SHORTLISTED FOR THE ABIA GENERAL FICTION BOOK OF THE YEAR 2022

'Smart, suspenseful, brimming with secrets. This is Sally Hepworth at her unputdownable best.'
KATE MORTON

'At once familiar, wonderfully unpredictable and riveting. My kind of story.'
ROSALIE HAM

‘Completely compulsive. Sally Hepworth delivers with this stay-up-late one-more-chapter gem.’
JANE HARPER

The Soulmate
Sally Hepworth

Gabe is alone at the cliff's edge. His arms are outstretched, palms facing the empty air.

He said she jumped. He wouldn't lie.

Before the woman went over the cliff, Pippa and Gabe were happy. They had the kind of marriage that everyone envies, as well as two sweet young daughters, a supportive family, and a picturesque cliff-side home – which would have been idyllic had the tall beachside cliffs not become so popular among those wishing to end their lives.

Gabe has become somewhat of a local hero since they moved to the cliff house, talking seven people down from stepping off the edge. But when Gabe fails to save the eighth, a sordid web of secrets begins to unravel, pushing bonds of loyalty and love to the brink.

What *wouldn't* you do for your soulmate?

SHORTLISTED FOR THE NED KELLY AWARD FOR BEST CRIME FICTION 2023

'Could not stop reading'
HOLLY WAINWRIGHT

'Masterfully designed . . . *The Soulmate* examines love and loyalty, and how fare we're willing to go for the sake of family'
MARY KUBICA

‘Scalpel-cut insights into modern marriage and the things we overlook in the name of love’
TRENT DALTON

Darling Girls
Sally Hepworth

It's not just secrets buried at Wild Meadows.

For as long as they can remember, Jessica, Norah and Alicia have been told how lucky they are. Rescued from family tragedies and raised by a loving foster mother on an idyllic farming estate, they were given an elusive second chance of a happy family life.

But their childhood wasn't the fairy tale everyone thinks it was. And when a body is discovered under the home they grew up in, the foster sisters find themselves thrust into the spotlight as key witnesses. Or are they prime suspects?

A thrilling page-turner by *New York Times* bestselling author Sally Hepworth of sisterhood, secrets, love and murder.

WINNER OF THE NED KELLY AWARDS
BEST CRIME FICTION 2024

'Sally Hepworth's *Darling Girls* is the kind of story that grabs you hard and doesn't let go. Easily one of the best books I've read all year. An absolute page-turner from first word to last, and a story told with wit and compassion. It's got HUGE HIT written all over it, and I'm going to be pressing it into the hands of everyone I know. A superb and haunting mystery.'
JANE HARPER

Pan Macmillan acknowledges the Traditional Custodians of Country throughout Australia and their connections to lands, waters and communities. We pay our respect to Elders past and present and extend that respect to all Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander peoples today. We honour more than sixty thousand years of storytelling, art and culture.

This is a work of fiction. Characters, institutions and organisations mentioned in this novel are either the product of the author's imagination or, if real, used fictitiously without any intent to describe actual conduct.

First published 2025 in Macmillan by Pan Macmillan Australia Pty Ltd
1 Market Street, Sydney, New South Wales, Australia, 2000

Copyright © Sally Hepworth International Pty Ltd as trustee
for the Sally Hepworth International Unit Trust 2025

The moral right of the author to be identified as the author of this work has been asserted.

All rights reserved. This publication (or any part of it) may not be reproduced or transmitted, copied, stored, distributed or otherwise made available by any person or entity (including Google, Amazon or similar organisations), in any form (electronic, digital, optical, mechanical) or by any means (photocopying, recording, scanning or otherwise) without prior written permission from the publisher.

This ebook may not include illustrations and/or photographs that may have been in the print edition.

Cataloguing-in-Publication entry is available
from the National Library of Australia
http://catalogue.nla.gov.au

EPUB format: 9781761773877

Typeset by Midland Typesetters, Australia
Cover design by Christa Moffitt, Christabella Designs
Cover image by Bill Hope

The author and the publisher have made every effort to contact copyright holders for material used in this book. Any person or organisation that may have been overlooked should contact the publisher.

Love talking about books?
Find Pan Macmillan Australia online to read more about all our books and to buy both print and ebooks. You will also find features, author interviews and news of any author events.



Thank you for downloading this Pan Macmillan Australia ebook!

We have regular giveaways in our newsletter, as well as discounted ebooks and exclusive sneak peeks!

SIGN UP HERE

We hope to see you there!

